

Engl 230 Screenwriting

Numbered Transcript

ENGL 230 • Nick Vallelonga

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Lecture 1: "FADE IN"

At a glance — Vallelonga opens his screenwriting course — 'Fade In'.

- 1.1 What do I say? What do I do? The reason I'm doing this right now is because I'm putting you in the place of a writer. You're all here to write scripts, right? So mostly, the first thing you do when you look at your page, that blank page, you're going to be doing this: you're going to be thinking. The thinker, right?
- 1.2 Because that's the dilemma every screenwriter faces when you start to write a screenplay is the blank page. I know we just started. If I do my job here, we're going to have several hours of talking about all the things you might need to do to even get you in front of the blank page—what you've done to even get there when you're about to write your script.
- 1.3 But I'm going to jump forward for now. We're going to go back to everything. I'm going to jump forward to the place where you are staring at that blank page, and you're ready to write the screenplay that you've been dreaming to yourself.
- 1.4 Now, you're probably saying to yourself, "Who is this guy? Why is he here teaching us about writing scripts? He's doing Screenplay Writing 101. Shouldn't he be doing Pizza Making 101?" And probably I should be. But I'll talk about me in a little bit. We're going to get to that. But again, I'm going to jump ahead.
- 1.5 You've been planning your screenplay. Now you're staring at the blank page. Now, you've been probably thinking about your script for weeks or months or years or days or whatever long it's been. You might have laid out your basic story lines, your plot lines, your characters, your protagonist, your antagonist, the good guy, the bad guy—act one, the beginning; act two, the middle; act three, the end—which you can't wait to write because you got this great ending. And you've got this story that you've been having in your head that you really want to write into your screenplay.
- 1.6 But I don't care what you do—all your character arcs, you may have the greatest idea in the history of screenplays—but now you face the dilemma that everyone has. You have to write it. You have to stare at the blank page, much like these walls. That's all you've got. So whether you're writing it on a typewriter—which many people do, still do—on a computer, or as many people do, they handwrite.
- 1.7 A friend of mine, George Gallo, a very prolific writer, he wrote a big movie called Midnight Run with Robert De Niro and Charles Grodin. And if you haven't seen Midnight Run, you should see Midnight Run. And George Gallo's script of Midnight Run changed the way buddy movies were done. But George Gallo writes everything in longhand on a yellow pad. That's the way he does it. By the way, see Midnight Run.

- 1.8** That's another thing about this. I'm going to mention a lot of movies. See the movies. Matter of fact, if you're at home now watching this, if you haven't seen Midnight Run, stop. We'll wait for you to come back. Watch Midnight Run and come back.
- 1.9** But all the movies I mention are movies that are important for you to see. I'm not going to mention them all. There's dozens and dozens of movies and books, which we'll get into, that you should read and get into. But the movies are important to watch because ultimately, that's what you're doing, and we're going to get to that, too.
- 1.10** So George Gallo writes by hand. Sylvester Stallone, a little movie called Rocky, in case you haven't seen that. If you haven't seen Rocky, we should stop this whole thing right now. One of the biggest movie stars in history wrote most of his scripts. Another guy who writes longhand. I just saw an interview with him. He's writing a book about his life. It's like this thick because it's in longhand.
- 1.11** But whatever you're doing, whatever page you're facing, it's going to be empty. So how do you start? Because now you have to take this idea, even if you've mapped it out, you put things on—a lot of people put things on index cards, which we'll get into, that's a way of mapping out your scenes. A lot of people do outlines and character breakdowns, et cetera, et cetera, which we're going to get into all that, too. But eventually, you have to stare at that page, and you have to write something.
- 1.12** So the first thing you're going to write, here's a little trick, is "FADE IN." Two words: fade in. Now you've written something. Now you got something on the page, fade in. Now, fade in might be an old thing; there's scripts now I see that don't have fade in. But I'm going to tell you my fade in story.
- 1.13** There was a producer named Gene Kirkwood. He was one of the producers of Rocky. He found Stallone and gave Rocky his chance. He produced another movie called The Pope of Greenwich Village. Did anybody see The Pope of Greenwich Village? Pope of Greenwich Village: on the list.
- 1.14** Gene Kirkwood, I remember I tried to get a script to him one time, and I had just come out to Los Angeles, and he called me in to meet with me. He liked my script. I wouldn't say love—I don't think he loves many scripts. He liked my script. Liked it enough to call me in.
- 1.15** So I went in there to meet him. He said, "You know why you're in here?" I said, "Why? Why am I in here?" "The script is good. We could talk about it. We could work on it." He goes, "But I have one rule. One rule. I open a script, I don't see 'FADE IN' on the top, right in the garbage." That was his thing because he said, "If you don't know the formatting of how to write a proper script," he goes, "I'm not even going to bother. I'm not even going to get past fade in if there's no fade in." Nowadays, that might have gone by the wayside, but I always start with fade in.

- 1.16** So now you got fade in, you have to start your first line. Interior, exterior, where is it? Where does it take place? Because now you have to write the screenplay. And again, you've got this amazing story, this great idea that you've been wanting to put on a page. It's not an idea anymore. It has to be a screenplay. It's different from a book. It's a screenplay.
- 1.17** You've got to fill 100–120 pages or so. In my case, I overwrite; they're usually pretty long, so I've got to cut them down. We'll get into that, too—overwriting—which I think is important because you could write a lot and then cut it back. But I need another hour for that one. But you have to write 100–120 pages, and you have nothing to go by but your notes. Now you have your notes because you need those notes—you've thought it out, right? But how do you get that 120 pages on the page?
- 1.18** You're going to be judged by this script. Everyone you give it to is going to judge it. If you have no connections in the business yet, you're going to give it to a friend, or a family member, or somebody, to read it. Whoever you give it to is going to judge it. And I guarantee you whoever you give it to, and as many people that you give it to, are going to tell you what's wrong with it and how you can fix it. After you've put all this time and effort into thinking about it, writing down the notes, creating it—beginning, middle, and end—every single person you give a screenplay to is going to tell you what's wrong with it and how you can fix it.
- 1.19** It's probably the worst artistic endeavor you can do. Books—a novelist writes a book, maybe he has an editor, maybe he doesn't listen to the editor. It's what you put out there. A script, a screenplay, it's not yours once you get it out there. Because like I said, everyone wants to change it. It's going to get changed all the way down the line to the point of maybe you won't even recognize it by the time it's done. But that's going to happen. But you can fight that. It all depends on how powerful you are. But the first couple of times in, you have to go with it.
- 1.20** Now, what is your job? What do you have to do to get this done? All the things I said are only after the judging happens, if you actually finish it. Because many times you may start your script and you may get into it, and then you're going to be looking at another blank page. "Okay, I got five pages. What's page six? How do I get there? I thought I had this all worked out in my head already." How's it going to happen? Because it's your job.
- 1.21** The bigger story of your character—let's say you have one main character—you got to get your main character from page 1 to page 120. We have to follow that arc of his story, his or her story. You have to love this person, maybe hate the person. You got to want to follow this person. But that's all up to you. It's your story because you're not getting him or her from this point A to point Z unless you get from point A to point Z.
- 1.22** So your screenplay is really your story. Because if you fail, if you have a character that fails in the script but then picks himself back up and moves forward, that's a great

story. That's usually the basis of a lot of stories that are based on that. But what if you fail and you're in the middle of your script and you just go, "What have I done? I don't know what to do. It sounded all good on paper. It sounded good when I thought it out. It sounded good on the index cards. But it's not reading well. It's not going where I want."

- 1.23** Now, you've got to get them there. You have to succeed. Not the character, you, because that character is waiting for you, going, "Okay, you brought me here. You put me in this dilemma. Get me out of it. How do you get me out of it?" That's a big problem in act two of screenplays. Most screenplays, you consider, "This is act one, act two, and act three." That's the general format. We'll get into that at some point also.
- 1.24** But the act two is always the big problem because you could set something up and it's great, and you may have this terrific ending, but that middle part of your script has got to keep them reading. It's got to keep them moving forward because it's different than a book. You have some time with the book. People want to read a book. They'll go on a journey with you. You can go off into existential thoughts and ideas and what someone's thinking and feeling—a script, you can't do that.
- 1.25** In a script, you can only write what you see and what you hear. You can't write what the person 's thinking. You can't write any of that type of stuff that you would get in a novel or a book. So you have to be very succinct in how you write it. It's a special way of writing. It's different than writing short stories or novels and literature because you're writing what a person visualizes.
- 1.26** Now, over the years, scripts have changed. There's some flowery expressions and descriptions that are going on in there. But really, that's only for the reader of the script. You have a twofold problem. You have to make it readable so they keep going. But it's not really about the read. You have to make them visualize what they're reading as a movie because you're not selling a script. No one cares about your script. You don't write scripts to have them read. You write scripts to get movies made. So you have to write it in a way that they can see the movie.
- 1.27** Now, when I first started, that was my thing—and I think it's most people—when you read a great novel or a book, you picture it in your mind as a movie, if it's written well. So they'd lend themselves to movies before there were movies. People's imaginations—you picture, you get into the story, you feel like you're there, you get to know these characters, you're along for the ride. So you have to do that with the script as well.
- 1.28** So now, like I said, it's your journey. You have to get them there. So what are you going to do? Are you going to sit there and fail when all is lost? Or do you fight through it? Do you get the script finished? Do you keep working on it to make it better, and better, and better, and not listen to all the people that are telling you how bad it is and how terrible it is? "Would you read these first 10 pages?" "Oh, I don't get it." "Would you read this first half of my script? Will you read this full script?"

- 1.29** Like I said, you're going to get criticism for it, but you've got to fight through all of this. So it's your journey along with your character's journey is what I'm trying to say. And all the people telling you that it's not good and it's never going to get made, that's going to happen, too. I'm going to get into that later on my Green Book film of how, for years, people told me, "There's no one watching this movie. It's about two guys sitting in a car talking. So who wants to see it?"
- 1.30** Are you going to fight through all the obstacles that are in your way? Because if you do, maybe one day you do get it made. Maybe you get it out there. You get it read. Someone likes it. Someone else likes it. Someone takes it. Someone reads it. And maybe you get it to someone like Steven Spielberg who likes it. And then he gets more people to see it who love it. They want to make it. You get it made into a movie. You get a nomination for a Golden Globe. You win the Golden Globe.
- 1.31** Then you get a nomination for the Academy Award. You win the Academy Awards. You go up there, you win the Academy Awards. Julia Roberts comes down, hands you the Academy Award, gives you a big hug and a kiss. Julia Roberts. Hug, kiss, right? No, that could never happen. Never happen. Except it happened to me. That's my story. But if you wrote a screenplay about something like that, no one would believe it. It's almost an unbelievable scenario how that happened. But it can happen.
- 1.32** So I didn't start with me, with this, "Who am I and why am I teaching this course?" Because it's boring. I'm talking about me—how long have I been talking now? For 15 minutes? I don't even want to listen to myself anymore. So to tell you about me, I think would have bored the heck out of you. I wanted to grab you and pull you in at the beginning to tell you how difficult this is going to be. So hopefully, I did something that you would do in a script. You've got to start somewhere at the beginning and grab somebody. You've got to take them, take them on a little bit of a ride, continue that ride, and keep them going the whole way.
- 1.33** Now I will give you a little backstory about me. And you're going to have to do this in your script also because you're going to reach a point where you may do a big setup, then you've got to explain stuff to get them there. So I'm here. I will tell you a little bit about me—I'm boring myself just thinking about myself. But in this case, I want to try to make this as entertaining as I can as you need to do with your script. So hopefully, you're going to want to continue on this screenplay journey with me.
- 1.34** And I have notes, by the way, because there's only so many Jordan Petersons in this world. And this Academy has geniuses teaching classes. And like I said, I should be making meatballs right now. But—
- 1.35** My name is Nick Vallelonga. I'm here for one reason, one reason alone: I won a couple of Academy Awards for the film Green Book. Did you see Green Book? Has anyone seen Green Book? Okay, because that's good, too. If you're at home, you didn't see Green Book, stop the video again. Watch Green Book, come back. Because there'll be a lot of

spoilers, and there's going to be spoilers about a lot of movies and scripts that I mention. So try to read these books and scripts and watch these movies.

- 1.36** But *Green Book* was the true story about my father, Tony Lip—and not a lot of people know—actually, it was Viggo Mortensen who played my dad. It was a true story. It was a story that I had my whole life. It was a true story, which was a gift given to me. And I'm going to get into more detail about this, too. But I just believed in this story. And as I mentioned at the beginning here, I fought through a lot of obstacles to get it there. I wrote a lot of crappy scripts. I got a lot of movies made that I didn't really care about. But I always had that story in the back of my head. And later on, I'm going to get into the very long story about it.
- 1.37** How did I start writing? In loving movies—I was a little kid. My mother told me I would be fascinated by the TV. And she took me to my first movie, which was *Mary Poppins*, when I was five years old or six years old. She took me five days in a row, and I was hooked. So I'd rather be writing Disney movies. I get hired a lot to write mob movies and tough-guy movies. I wish I was writing *Free Willy* or Disney-type movies. It's really what I want to do.
- 1.38** And I always wrote little stories. I made little films with Super 8 [films] that you used to cut with scissors and tape them together. I think maybe you understand what I'm talking about. You don't understand what I'm talking about. So I'll go into more detail about all this. But I was always writing short stories, making little movies.
- 1.39** And then my father—if you saw the movie *Green Book*—he was a bouncer at the Copacabana nightclub in New York. When they were making *The Godfather*, the director, Francis Ford Coppola, and the casting directors went in there to the Copacabana, and they were looking to meet real mobsters. So the guy, the liaison, to introduce them was my dad. And so they got to know him pretty well, and they said to him, "You got a great look—we're doing this movie—are you an actor?" And if you saw my father in the movie, Tony Lip, what did he say? "Oh, yeah. I'm an actor, yeah. I did a lot of off-Broadway, a lot of plays, a lot of off-Broadway." Now, my father never acted in his life—except in real life, he was acting all the time.
- 1.40** So long story short, he got an audition for the movie, and they liked him. And they said to him, "Do you have any kids? We're doing this big wedding scene." If you remember the wedding scene at the beginning of *The Godfather*—all families. And they said, "Do you have any kids? We need Italian kids." So my brother and I went in, screen-tested for Francis Ford Coppola with the camera, the whole thing, and we're a couple of the little kids in the wedding scenes. So I was on that set. It was mind-blowing to me. I couldn't believe what I was seeing, how a film was being made.
- 1.41** I'll tell you a quick little bit. I was going to save some of this stuff, but—I was running around so much the first couple of days that day three, the assistant directors were looking for me, and my brother was like, "Hide, hide! They're asking about you! They

want to know—" I'm like, "What? What did I do?" They grab me, and they take me over to Francis Ford Coppola.

- 1.42** He introduces himself, and he says, "You remember me? I was the guy when you first came in; we did the screen test. I'm the director of the movie. I don't know if you understand this, but we film every day. And then I go watch the next day, the next morning, what we filmed the day before. I see you more than I see anybody." He goes, "And you can't be over here and then be over here at the same time." He says, "Because we cut to each side. You may not understand it, but I can't have you in every single shot of the film."
- 1.43** He said, "So what I'm going to do with you is I'm going to keep you next to me." And they got me a director's chair and put it next to Francis Ford Coppola. And that whole day, I was behind the camera—he wouldn't let me in front of the camera. I sat next to him. So you talk about a film school or really get me to want to do it. That was the one. The Godfather set was my film school. I was obsessed from that point on. And I'll tell you a couple more Godfather stories later on.
- 1.44** We're going to be honest with each other now. I'm going to be honest with you this whole next seven, eight hours that we're going to do. And you've got to be honest with me, because none of you here are here to write a screenplay. None of you. You could say you are. Everyone watching could say you are.
- 1.45** You're all here because you want to make a movie. Screenplay, yeah. How do I write a screenplay? But why are you writing the screenplay? Like I said earlier, it's not a novel. You can't sell it. No one's going to read it. The only reason people read a screenplay is to see if it will make a good movie. And that's what you want to do. You want to make a movie, right? That's why you're here.
- 1.46** You have a movie idea in your head, but the obstacle is writing this darn screenplay. That's the pain in the neck about it, because really, if you could just tell your story of the movie, it would be much better than taking the time to write it. And that's the hard part, like we talked about earlier. How do you get that idea—and you may have it all laid out, like I said earlier, but you've got to get that onto the page.
- 1.47** So we're here to make movies. And that's why watching movies, studying movies—we're going to get into this: the history of movies, how they've changed, and how the screenplays for movies have changed to what we have now. But one thing is certain: you have to have that screenplay. That's the blueprint. That's the blueprint of your building a skyscraper. You have to have those blueprints, and someone has to do it.
- 1.48** So the thing about it is most people never get their script out to the right people. So that's another thing we're going to talk about. Once you have it done, how do you get it right? If you are new to this industry, you don't know anyone. We're going to get into this more.

- 1.49 But a quick story is when I was in New Jersey, I grew up in New York and then New Jersey, and I wrote a script, and I had this dream—this was like in the '80s—of Arnold Schwarzenegger doing this script. So I didn't know anyone or anything. I was maybe 18 years old or 17 years old, and I had the script. I just wrote it with him in mind.
- 1.50 And I started looking up, how do I get it to anyone? I found out, oh, they have agents. Could I get it to his agency? I found out who his agent was. I just did research. There were no computers then looking it up. I forget how I found out. I somehow talked to some assistant on the phone to let me send the script. I sent the script, and I thought I'd never hear anything.
- 1.51 And then all of a sudden, I get this phone call. "Nick Vallelonga? Yeah, this is"—I think it was Lou Pitt—"Arnold Schwarzenegger's agent." I'm like, "What?" He said, "Yeah, script's not bad. Do you have any financing? You've got it set up anywhere?" I go, "Set up?" I'm in my basement in New Jersey with Stallone and Schwarzenegger posters on the wall. And I said, "Well, no, I just wrote it. It's not with a studio. Nobody's looking at it." So he said, "Let me get back to you." So he got back to me. He said, "I showed it around. Arnold's booked for the next two years. Can you wait two years?" I said, "I guess so. I don't know. Yeah." And then I never heard anything ever again.
- 1.52 But the point is, it showed me something that, yeah, it's hard, it's difficult. I struggled a long, long time before I made Green Book. I made a lot of little, like I mentioned, movies that I wasn't really proud of. But I was out there trying. I was doing what I could do. But it also showed me that it's not impossible to do. I made a call from New Jersey to one of the biggest agents in Hollywood with one of the biggest stars of all time. He took the time to look at it and read it, which I couldn't even believe because they want good material. They need good material. They need good movies. And he thought it was good enough to call me and see who I was. And then when I told him, I said, "No, I'm still in high school." He said, "Well, get back to me in a couple of years."
- 1.53 So my point of it is: it can be done. I don't know how many people here have tried this before or people that are tuning in. If there's anyone tuning in, it all could be just us right now. But I think Peterson Academy has got a lot of great people to watch this. If you don't know anyone, first things first, get the script done. And we're going to talk about how to get the script done in the upcoming episodes.
- 1.54 Now, I'm going to say to you this. There's a line from a famous movie, "Fasten your seatbelts, it's going to be a bumpy ride." Because I want to try to be honest with you during this whole process. Some stuff is going to be fun, but some stuff is going to be not fun. It's not easy to do this.
- 1.55 "Fasten your seatbelts, it's going to be a bumpy ride." Has anyone ever heard that line before? Do we know it's from a movie? It's a famous quote from the screenplay of a 1950 film, All About Eve, and it was written and directed by Joseph L. Mankiewicz, who

won the Academy Award for that script that he wrote. It was based on a short story, 1946, "The Wisdom of Eve" by Mary Orr, and it was a Cosmopolitan magazine article.

1.56 Now Mary Orr did not get any credit for writing that article, but Joseph Mankiewicz, he said he took it. They did it from her article. But in those days, it wasn't—now you would reference that article that's based on that, if you wrote a script based on something. So he wins two Academy Awards for that movie, Best Director and Best Screenplay, Joseph L. Mankiewicz.

1.57 Now, the real line is, "Fasten your seatbelts. It's going to be a bumpy [night]." That was said by a character played by Bette Davis. Does anyone know who Bette Davis was? Okay, Bette Davis, great actress. And again, this movie, All About Eve, you should watch that movie, too, because it's an amazing movie.

1.58 So "Fasten your seatbelts, it's going to be a bumpy ride," was said by the character played by Bette Davis. And that's become a staple in the American lexicon. It's a quote, when trouble is brewing. But it's a misquote. Like I said, the line is "Fasten your seatbelts. It's going to be a bumpy night." That's really what she said. But over time, it picked up the bumpy ride ending, and that's how it's usually quoted. But it just shows that film writing, lines in movies, they become part of the American dialogue. People quote movies all the time.

1.59 Now, another little aside, Joseph L. Mankiewicz, his older brother was Herman J. Mankiewicz. He was a renowned Hollywood screenwriter who, at the time, was bigger than his younger brother. This guy was great. He was famous for a lot of scripts, but the big one that he wrote with Orson Welles is the movie called Citizen Kane. Has anyone ever heard of Orson Welles? Let's start there. Okay, Orson Welles. Citizen Kane—watch Citizen Kane. Amazing movie, an amazing script. So it's considered one of the best scripts ever written and one of the greatest films ever made. We're going to be talking about that and the format of that and what Mankiewicz, the other—I get them mixed up—what Herman Mankiewicz did to get that script done and get it made with Orson Welles. So watch Citizen Kane.

1.60 Back to the dilemma of where are you going to start? Have any of you ever even tried writing a script yet? Let's see some hands. Okay, so we have a couple of people, and a couple of people you might be interested in doing this, right?

1.61 There are scripts that I've done that I've kept in my head for years. I roll them around, I roll them around. I think them, I think them, I think them. Now, part of that could be procrastination because I just don't want to actually face the fact that I have to write this thing. But a lot of it is getting it in my brain, in my consciousness, so that when I do write it, I know it inside out. I know the characters.

1.62 There's been different ways that I've written scripts. I started some scripts with just nothing. And we're going to do an experiment here later on. We're going to look at a script, have a blank page, and see if we can get a page or two out of it with nothing.

There are scripts I've written where I thought of an ending. "Oh, this would be a great end to a script. How do I get it there?"

- 1.63** I remember once I went to see a Billy Bob Thornton film called *One False Move* early in his career—another great movie, you should see. And I was in the theater watching the movie, and I was so taken in by the film that I just started—a new idea came into my head. As I'm watching the movie, and I was into the movie, but by the time I was done, I had a whole movie in my head, and I went and wrote that movie. I almost got that made. Not yet, I haven't made it. But my point is, it led to a script.
- 1.64** So you get inspired by things, you get inspired by stories, you get inspired by life. But why do you want to tell the story? What each of you has in you that says, "There's a story I feel I need to be told?" Is it a true story? Is it just a made-up story? Is it a story that you heard from someone else? All of these are valid. But this is a long journey, as I said, and a lot of it is about you.
- 1.65** You're going to put your personality, your mindset into the movie, your feelings, your thoughts. It could be fantasy. It could be sci-fi. There's a young man here—you might write something that takes place in outer space. There could be something about history, about a true story of history. I have this Daniel Boone movie that I want to make. I've always wanted to make. I still haven't written it, but I've always wanted to do it.
- 1.66** It could be a personal story like I had from *Green Book*, which is basically a gift from my family, my parents. My mother and father should have gotten the best screenplay award for that because of how much—and Dr. Donald Shirley—for how much information they gave my co-writers, Brian Currie and Peter Farrelly, for us to work with. So it doesn't matter what the genre is, where it is, or the whys and hows; it's you. What mental state are you in, and why do you want to tell the story? And what point do you want to put across the story? So you're putting yourself in there, whether you like it or not.
- 1.67** We're going to get into themes, the basic themes of most movies, how they come from a certain amount of stories that was set by William Shakespeare. And I know, I think Peterson Academy has a couple of great classes about the teachings of Shakespeare, so I dare not even go there.
- 1.68** But I want to talk about how Shakespeare has influenced all of literature and then ultimately movies, that what he set forth in all his plays are the storylines that everyone follows to this day, whether you do that consciously or unconsciously. I think if you've read a lot of books, we're going to get into that next—books—it's in your DNA.
- 1.69** When I first went to write a script, I never thought of acts: act one, act two, act three. That's the basic structure for a movie. Now, there's sub-acts and side stories. Some say there's a five-act structure. We're going to get into all that, too. But the basic structure is act one, act two, act three. Chazz Palminteri told me, great writer, *Bronx Tale*. Has

anyone seen the film of Bronx Tale, Robert De Niro? Watch Bronx Tale. Chazz Palminteri, true story about his life also.

- 1.70** Chazz always said to me, "It's very simple. You get a guy, you get him up into a tree, you leave him up in the tree for a while, you've got to figure out how to get down. In act three, you get him down. That's it." He goes, "The guy's got a problem. Somehow he lands up in a tree. Sometimes that's how you got to get him down." So that's the basic idea of it. But of course, there's much more to it. But you've got to follow these structures. My point of it is that from watching movies and reading books, you have it ingrained in you, whether you know it or not, what a story is.
- 1.71** When I first wrote my first script, I got a basic book, but I only used that book to tell me how to set the typewriter settings so that I have it formatted right. I didn't bother reading the stuff about what act one should have, act two, act three. I just started writing. I had an idea for something, and it just fell into place, and I ended up with a 100-page script. I didn't think about act one, act two, or act three. I didn't even know what that was.
- 1.72** Now, we have the luxury of learning, and there's books about screenwriting, which I want to tell you about. You should know them anyway. But what I'm trying to get to: your first draft of your script, don't worry about any of that type of stuff. Don't worry about acts. Don't worry about character arcs. Don't worry about—I mean, you're going to know who the good guy or bad guy is. You know your basic plot. But don't worry about following anything.
- 1.73** Draft one, I say it in an odd way, just puke it out. Get all of it out. Write out everything you can write, stuff that you're probably going to look back on and go, "Oh, that's terrible. I got to cut that down." Overwrite it. Have someone talk for five pages if you need to. Get your story out on the page. Like I said earlier, we're talking about a blank page. You've got to get past the blank page. So start with something.
- 1.74** I like just writing it. I don't do the cards for scenes. I don't do character breakdowns. I just have it in my head. That's the way I do it. But then again, maybe I'd be much more successful if I did it the way you're supposed to do it, with outlines or with treatments. But I think to myself, the time I'm going to spend thinking this out, writing down the characters, writing out the outlines, getting full treatments, I could have a script done, and then I could work on it that way. That's just me.
- 1.75** A lot of people are more organized than me. I'm off the top of my head type of guy. I want to feel it. I'll go months without writing anything. And then I'll lock myself in and in 10 days, come out with something, but I don't leave the room. It's just pizza boxes and Chinese cartons of food. The blinds are shut, and I don't come out until I'm done. That's the way I do it. I have to get it all out. But there's a lot of thought that goes behind that.

- 1.76** So whatever your process is—and maybe you don't even have a process yet. So we're going to talk about, over the next few classes, maybe how to get you to that process. And I am going to talk about some of the ways you can outline them, some of the ways you can do treatments, some of the way you can do index cards, maybe do a character breakdown. So I want to show you the proper way to do it. But I think, hopefully, by the end of this, you take all of it through osmosis and just do it whatever way is best for you.
- 1.77** I mean, you could be sitting here bored right now or watching this right now. If you feel like writing something, start writing something. Don't even bother listening to me anymore. Because really, that's what it really comes down to. You have to actually get in there and start the writing.
- 1.78** So the other part of it that is very, very, very important is: What is your reason for doing it? Is it just something you're doing for fun, or is it that you want to make a movie? You want to get this movie made.
- 1.79** So the style that you write it in, how you're going to write it, which we're going to get into today, later on, is really important. You've got to know the formatting. You have to know your reason for telling this story. And I don't care what it is. If it's set in outer space, like I said earlier, if it's set in the past, if it's cowboys and Indians, if it's rebels against Darth Vader, it's all about people.
- 1.80** I think the one thing that connects everyone is the human experience, because wherever you're putting a story, if you don't care about the people, what's the difference? We're all trying to learn about human behavior. That's why people write books.
- 1.81** That's why Dr. Peterson, the genius that he is, is so well known and renowned because he talks about human behavior. We're fascinated by it because we want to learn. We want to be better people, right? Or if we see something that's out in the world that we want to fix, that maybe outrages us. We want to try to educate people. You could do this better. You could live better. Look at what this character went through.
- 1.82** Everyone in their lives goes through tragedies. We all go through ups and downs. Like I said earlier, your dilemma is also what your character's dilemma is going to be. There's a problem. You get knocked down. You get knocked down again. How do you keep getting up? How do you move forward?
- 1.83** That's why the Rocky movie, what Sylvester Stallone did, connects to everyone, men, women, kids, adults, because it's a guy that was a nobody and wanted to be a somebody. But how did he do it? He didn't stop. He didn't give up. He didn't stop.
- 1.84** I could have given up many times. I was a bouncer in nightclubs. I worked in restaurants. I did side jobs. I delivered cheese. I worked in pizzerias all the time

thinking, "Well, I feel I have a gift for this writing because from when I was little, even in school, the teachers would always say, 'Oh, keep writing.'"

- 1.85** But I wasn't focused. I wanted to be an actor. I wanted to be a writer. I wanted to be a director. I wanted to be a baseball player. I wanted to do all these things that you dream about growing up. I also worked for CBS News. I started as a teleprompter operator, where you take scripts, you put them in the teleprompter, the newscasters read it. But I also then started editing the scripts and working with the writers.
- 1.86** To clarify, I didn't work for CBS News. I worked at CBS News. It was a teleprompter company called QTV that they used to bring in the people that just worked the teleprompters. But then, as I got to know the news people, and I would edit scripts for them, the anchor said, "You should maybe write. You want to take the writing test?" So I took the writing test, and I passed it the first time because I thought it was easy.
- 1.87** Well, you take the information off the AP wire. That was the UPI and AP, I think it was. And you ripped it and there was the news story. Then you had to break that news story down. Oh, this news story is worth 20 seconds of the anchor's time. This is a minute. Or there might be an anchor that had a long story, and you had to edit it with them. So I thought, well, you're not making anything up. You're just telling—at least that's what news is supposed to be; you're not supposed to be making stuff up. That might have changed a little bit.
- 1.88** So I passed the test, and I was going to start as a news writer. They hired me to start as a part-time. Then they said, "We'll give you a full-time job." And I was at a point in my life where I said, "If I do this, it's a great job, and I probably won't leave it because I'm going to be making money. I don't have to work at nightclubs anymore." But I felt restrained by just telling the truth or being locked into what was really happening. It wasn't creative enough for me. So that's when I moved to California, took a chance and came out.
- 1.89** But all writing, any writing that you do, is valuable. If you have nothing, you can start writing. If you go, "I can't think of anything. I woke up today at eight o'clock. I got up, went to the bathroom. I was hungry. So I started—" Just write it. Write it out. Write out whatever you're doing that day. If you're stuck with nothing.
- 1.90** If you have a character and you go, "My story is about this guy. I want to tell this story about this guy." Just start writing some of his dialogue. What does he say? What does he do? What's his everyday life? Where do we meet him in the story? Where is he in his life that we meet him? And then what happens, and what happens when?
- 1.91** Now, script writing, again, you got to grab—I told you, the Gene Kirkwood story. He won't go past fade in if it's not written right. But most scripts, you have to write something that grabs them [snaps his fingers] like that. You have to write something that grabs the reader because they want to watch this movie. So you have a two-fold

problem. Again, two-fold. You want to write a script that's entertaining, but you've got to make sure they want to watch this movie and this character.

- 1.92** So, do you start out with an explosion and people running down the street? How do you start your script? Whatever your character is, how do you get him into the place where he has a dilemma? Because every character has to have a dilemma that he has to overcome. I don't care what the story is. There's always a problem.
- 1.93** With Oppenheimer, you have a guy trying to invent something where he's tasked to invent something. How does he get there? How does he do it? What are the consequences of what he does? What will be the ultimate consequences of what he does?
- 1.94** There's problems. Scripts, your characters have to have problem after problem after problem after problem after problem after problem. And hopefully, you get them out of that problem at some point. Now, we love happy endings and "they lived happily ever after," is why there is the famous line.
- 1.95** Comedies. When comedies were first written, they all ended in a wedding. When the Greek plays—when they did comedies, Shakespearean comedies: weddings at the end of the comedy. That's how they thought of them. We think of comedies now, they're crazy, sitcoms, even Bridesmaids—it's about a wedding, right? That's the theme of comedies. Now, that's taken off and gone on to a whole different genre.
- 1.96** But comedy, tragedy. There's a reason we have—those are the two styles of writing. And what's a tragedy? Can a tragedy have a happy ending? Yes, it could, depending on where you want to take your characters. But again, what does a tragedy set up? Failure, rejection, hurt, good, evil. Why do bad things happen to good people? What happens when a good person gets put into a situation, gets imprisoned for something that he didn't do? The Shawshank Redemption. What about that journey? What happens to that person? What's his redemption? What's his going to hell, and then resurrection, escaping. There's deeper themes to all of this.
- 1.97** So it's important to know this history of filmmaking and of literature. But you could throw it all out the window and come up with your own idea that no one's ever thought of either, as long as it's entertaining.
- 1.98** You have a guy like Christopher Nolan, who took Memento, the editing structure of Memento, which was taken from the Killing that Stanley Kubrick did. And then Quentin Tarantino also took that to another place in Reservoir Dogs and even in Pulp Fiction. That movie was a different style. You're giving people some information, coming back. You're going to the front, you're going to the end. How did we get to that end? All that is a style. To me, mentally in a script, I don't even know how those guys wrote that because it's a big jigsaw puzzle, but obviously an interesting take. So there always can be a different and interesting take on any of this.

- 1.99** People didn't think about editing for a very long time. There was a film, a silent film, the Battleship Potemkin, a Russian film that changed editing forever, of cutting things together in a way that kept the suspense.
- 1.100** The film The Untouchables [1987] took a lot of its editing from the Battleship Potemkin, a [1925] movie. I think Untouchables was late '80s or early '90s. He took a whole sequence of the bad guys coming in, the good guys—they are the FBI. There's a baby carriage being pushed. All this action is occurring. The carriage starts going down the steps. Does he save the baby? Does he let the bad guy go? That was all taken from the Battleship Potemkin, a very famous sequence of editing.
- 1.101** And again, you're writing a movie, not a script. So do you incorporate some of those things into your script if it's very specific, because description of action is very, very, very important, how you describe the action. When we get into how you format that and what you do with it, I think to make it stand out more, because when the action stands out, dialogue is easier. I look at it like, just speak like you speak.
- 1.102** Now, the big issue is don't make everyone speak the same way you speak. And how do you have a separate voice for each character? Well, that's where you've got to know your characters well. You got to know the whys of you even having them there. And these are part of the problems, like I said, that you have to get through all this at the beginning. The more you think about it, the more you, if you're a note person, write the notes. If you're a spit it out person, like I said, just write it, and then you find things in there. You know what you're trying to get to.
- 1.103** I think you're not going to write a script unless you have a beginning, middle, and end. I think everyone who does that has the basic story. But the basic story isn't enough because it's the little things and how you thread all the little things together. And especially, as I mentioned at the top of this, act two. What are you going to do with act two?
- 1.104** So I'm going to have you, if you have questions at the end of each of our episodes, we'll call them, and feel free to ask me anything you want about what we talked about today.
- 1.105** You're sending your script out for people to read. How do you protect that script? What do you do? You may talk about it later. I don't know.
- 1.106** I'm going to talk about it later. No, I'll tell you. There's several ways to do it. You can register it with the Writers Guild. Nowadays, because of the Internet, if you even email it to someone, you keep a record of that, and you're covered. But you can send it to the Writers Guild and register it with the Writers Guild. You don't have to be a member to do that. And then also the Copyright Office, you have to go. There's a section in the Copyright Office for written works, and there's a section for screenplays, and you get assigned a number, and you copyright. Those are the ways to protect yourself.

- 1.107** There used to be an old way. We used to do it. You would mail it, certified mail to yourself and never open it up. So you have it. You have the record of that. It's in there sealed.
- 1.108** But the odds of it getting stolen, really, it's very, very rare. I mean, you'll find some things. I don't ever really hear of that happening much, but you still need to do it anyway. You copyright it, you email it to yourself. If you even email it to another person, those will all count. Certified mail, Copyright Office, Writers Guild of America, and register it.
- 1.109** In regards to the movies and screenplays that you wrote before the Green Book.
- 1.110** Terrible.
- 1.111** Well, how important were they to your process so that once you got to the Green Book, there was ease or a fluidity to it? Did you find that there were some key items that you learned along the way that made it even easier?
- 1.112** Yes. Of course, anything you do, you're going to learn from it. I got a bunch of little movies made. Several of them I directed myself. So the whole process was a learning process. And it's like, "Oh, this script, everyone likes this script." "Oh, you're only getting 200 grand to make it." "If it's not making it, how do I do that? Oh, I got to change this and that." There's always dilemmas, conflicts. And out of every script I've written, I learn more, I think, the next time. It's weird. I don't think I've ever changed the level of my writing. I think I'm the same writer in a way that I was when I started, but I just had my own journey.
- 1.113** I got smaller movies made. I got a chance to direct a lot of the movies. I worked on a lot of films. You see what everyone's job is. I was an actor always. I did theater. So the more you know, yes, it obviously helps.
- 1.114** By the time I got to Green Book, I at least had had some bunch of movies made that when a friend of mine, Brian Currie, came to me and said, "What are you working on now? What are you going to do?" We were talking about doing something together. I told him this story about my father, and he's like, "Are you out of your mind? You're working in nightclubs. We're bouncing. You have this story. What are we doing? Let's write the story."
- 1.115** So I thought, okay, I'll bring Brian in, and he'll write it with me because maybe I've held on to it so long that I should bring someone else so that I'm not just—because I'm writing about my family and my father, and I think I can look at it from the outside, but sometimes you want to protect things. So I thought bringing Brian in was good.
- 1.116** Brian then went to Peter Farrelly, told him the story. Peter, at the time, was looking to do something different. He was going to do his first film without directing with his brother. They still do things together, but at that time, they just wanted to do something each on their own. He loved the idea. I wanted to direct it because it was

about my dad. I said, "I'm protecting it. There's no way." But I met Pete and I thought, "You know what? If I put my ego aside and I go with Pete, I think it would be made on a much better level, on a higher level."

- 1.117** That was another thing. People said, "Why did you ask Peter Farrelly with the movies he had done in the past, Dumb and Dumber, There's Something About Mary—giant comedies?" And I said, "Well, he's a genius because his comedies made like a billion and a half dollars." Comedy is hard. It's hard to make comedies.
- 1.118** A filmmaker is a filmmaker. I didn't want to put him in a box. I don't want to be put in a box. Yeah, I wrote about my family. I write some Italian-type stuff, but I want to write an adventure out of space or a cowboy movie or whatever. I don't want to be locked in a box because of who people perceive me to be. So I thought that about Pete, and we came to an understanding: we would all write it together, produce it together. Pete was going to direct it, and I let the directing part go, and it was a great decision. I think I made the right decision.
- 1.119** But yes, you're affected by everything you do. So even if your first screenplay or second screenplay or third screenplay doesn't get made, it's leading you to the one that you're really going to click in and connect to it.
- 1.120** I think with the Green Book, like I said earlier, I had such a magnificent storyline. I had all the elements of the story. It helped us do it, but you still have to execute it, even with a great story. There's been great scripts that make lousy movies, lousy movies. You can kill a movie if it's not directed right or cast right. Like I said, everyone wants to change it.
- 1.121** We were lucky in Green Book. Nothing got changed. Steven Spielberg saved us with that. First, the script, they kept telling us, "Change it, change it, cut this out, cut that out." I'll go into this in more detail, but it was crazy. I just kept saying, "Well, no, it's not the same movie." And then, even when Pete made the movie, they wanted to cut 40 minutes out of the movie. Forty minutes out of that movie would have gutted the whole thing. Steven Spielberg said, "You're not doing it." So we got lucky there.
- 1.122** But there's going to be a lot of times, and I made a lot of movies, where you have the money guy who says, "Put my girlfriend in the movie and write her a part." "Well, this doesn't make sense for the story." "I don't care. Just do it. I'm paying for it." You get crazy stuff like that happening.
- 1.123** So, did I learn a lot of things? Yes. Did it affect me? Yes. And hopefully, if I can ever get another movie made, that one will be—now you're at a high bar I have to hit.
- 1.124** But yes, everything you do is going to affect what you do. It's like anything else. When you go to the gym for the first time, it's not pretty. It's not pretty. But if you quit and you don't come back, then you come back six months later, it's still not pretty. You've

got to stay in the gym. You're on a diet, you've got to be on the diet. All of that is discipline. It's discipline and hard work.

- 1.125** So you learn from every experience that you have, and especially with the writing of the scripts, if you can get outside of yourself and look in there and say, "Oh, this part I did good. I like this. This part? Not so good. How do I fix that on the next one?"
- 1.126** You talked about working with the team. Talk about that process. It's your story. It's your family history. But we're putting the words on the page, going back and forth. Who's doing what? What are those roles? And are they checking with you? Are you throwing things at them?
- 1.127** Well, listen, it's different in every movie. Sometimes, someone buys your script, and then you go, "Oh, my God." Like Brando says in *The Godfather*, "Look, they massacred my boy." You go, "That's not the script I wrote."
- 1.128** In *Green Book*, it was different because right from the beginning, we had an understanding: We're writing it together. We were producing it together. So I had a say in everything. Pete was very great about that. But Pete directed the movie. But even on set, I'm there. I was part of the casting. So in that one, I got lucky. But even then, a lot of other elements come in, people do different things, like the way they design a set. Is this exactly what it was? No, but we have to make it this way. You have to make concessions because there's a lot of creativity.
- 1.129** Then, when the actors come in, they'll have meetings with Pete, readings with Pete. Now, luckily, the actors, it wasn't really much. They loved the script so much that they said, no, they weren't really changing anything. But we were there. If there were changes of things, mostly when Pete was shooting it, the actors had their stuff down. I mean, I had a couple of geniuses working there, Viggo Mortensen, Mahershala Ali. Linda Cardellini played my mom. She was able to talk to my mom's brother, my uncles, my aunts, my cousins, my brother, me. She embodied my mother. She's Italian. She got it, all those family scenes. So that was a magical one that ended up magically succeeding in the way it did, although we got a lot of criticism. We'll talk about that, too, at some point. But in that case, I was involved in everything.
- 1.130** Now, there's been other ones that I'm even directing, but like I said, you have these obstacles. "Okay, I don't have the money to do this scene like that." "Oh, I wrote this, but I can't get an actor to really do it right." You're always changing. It changes from the script to when you're in pre-production, you've got to modify it when you're on the set, and you're watching it and going, "No, this doesn't work. Let's talk this through."
- 1.131** Hopefully, I had a lot of low-budget movies, so I tried to have a lot of rehearsals. I'm an old-school theater guy because low-budget movies—and again, now we're back in the movie making, but again, this all leads to movie making. Low-budget movies, you don't have the money or the time. You have to have that all set and done. So I like to have all the actors and the writing or rewriting or changing done before we shoot the film. But

it still will come up and happen. When you put it up there, you put it out there, it's not working, you've got to change.

1.132 But you're not making a movie by yourself. You're making it with a lot of people. Anyone could have an idea. Sometimes on a set, if a PA says something, "You know, Mr. Vallelonga, did you notice the blah, blah, blah?" "Oh, wow." A good idea can come from anybody. I'm open to any good idea.

1.133 You have to be open to change to a point, because if you change too much, you're going to wreck the whole idea. I wouldn't make this movie unless I made it the way I made it. I kept fighting, fighting, fighting all the elements that were against me. But luckily, with Brian Currie and Peter Farrelly, and then the other couple of producers they put on, and then the actors, everyone was pro the script and for the script. So let's end it on a happy note, because it may get unhappy later on. Thank you.

Lecture 2: Nobody Knows Anything

At a glance — 'Nobody knows anything' — the uncertainty of the craft.

- 2.1 Okay, here we are again. We're going to call this one "Nobody Knows Anything and Books You Need." When a Green Book came out— and I keep going to Green Book because that's the only reason I'm really here. When Green Book came out, it got a lot of great reviews, and then it got a lot of bad reviews. It turned. People loved it. People hated it. There were talks about, "Oh, he made that up. It's not true." There were controversies about it, that Dr. Shirley's family wasn't happy with it, that I'm a racist, my father's a racist, and all this stuff that was just put out into the press that were not true.
- 2.2 The background of that, and again, I'll go into it a little bit more, is that I got this story from my father, my mother, and from Dr. Shirley himself. He told me what I could say, what I couldn't say. He told me how much about him I could put in and what I couldn't put in. I could put in all the stuff that he told me. I could put in things about him and my father. But the rest of his life, he said, "I may write my own book." "I may make my own movie." He was friends with Spike Lee's dad, who was another fantastic musician. He said, "Maybe I'll have Spike Lee do my movie," which was interesting because Spike Lee was mad about the movie. But that's another story.
- 2.3 But the long story short was we got attacked a lot and we got a lot of praise. So it was controversial. It was a crazy time. There were a lot of attacks on movies attacking each other. I'm here because of those two statues. We ended up winning them anyway. But the script, everyone was talking about the script. Was it real? Was it true? What made it good? I guess, good enough to win.
- 2.4 So instead of reading you all the bad reviews, I recently found this analysis of Green Book by—he calls himself a production professional, screenplay consultant, and his name is Brian Smith. I'm going to read you this analysis. It may get a little long, hopefully not too long, but there's a reason why I'm going to read it, and I'm going to explain to you afterwards why I'm reading it.
- 2.5 This is his analysis of the screenplay of Green Book. He says, "I know I've been obsessing over Green Book lately. I wrote my thoughts here on Green Book winning best picture, but it should also be noted that it won best original screenplay. And I thought that a brief breakdown of the script was in order. Now, what was special about this script? What did it do that worked? What did it do that was unique? What did it do that would separate it from the other scripts that were also nominated?" Now, there were a lot of great scripts that year, by the way, as an aside, and we'll talk about that later.
- 2.6 He says, "One thing the screenplay for Green Book did that was special was that it took risks. Anyone who follows this blog"—his blog, I guess—"knows that I am a stickler for

story structure, especially for unknown writers. However, a good writer can mess around with story structure so that it doesn't necessarily hit all the beats at exactly the expected moments and still end up a terrific screenplay." Taking a step further, he says, "Most people who read this blog regularly will know that I advocate for a four-act structure." Remember, I was talking about three-act structures, but sometimes that changes.

- 2.7** He says, "I advocate for a four-act structure rather than a mere traditional three-act structure that most experts espouse. Green Book is actually very close to being three acts. I say very close because it does not have an Act Two B. It does have an Act Two B, although it's very short." I'm going to get back to all this of why I'm reading it to you. "I can confidently say this because Green Book follows a clear Hero's Journey outline"—remember I talked about outlines?—"which almost by default makes it a four-act story." This is all structure he's talking about. "That's the beauty of following the Hero's Journey model in your writing."
- 2.8** So there was a writer, Christopher Vogler, who has a book, who writes about this. He calls it the Hero's Journey. In his book, *The Writer's Journey*, he structures how to do a script in what's called the Hero's Journey.
- 2.9** "The Hero's Journey is flexible," he says, "and allows you to play with the structure. You can change the order of the stages of the journey as they did in Green Book and still have a tight and compelling screenplay. You can have some stages last longer than usual and make others very short, again, as they did in Green Book, and still have a structurally sound story with conflict and an effective dramatic arc. Here's an outline of the stages of the Hero's Journey and where they fit into the plot of Green Book."
- 2.10** He goes on. The first is called Ordinary World. He labels it. Again, spoilers. If you didn't see Green Book, shut this off. We'll wait. Watch it. We'll wait. Okay, you're back.
- 2.11** "Ordinary World: Tony 'Lip' Vallelonga, played by Viggo Mortensen, is a nightclub bouncer at New York City's Copacabana in the early '60s. We learn that the club is going to be closed for several weeks, and he's going to have a hard time getting by. We see that he's respected, tough, and resourceful (steals and then returns a customer's hat for profit and praise, covering a fire hydrant with a trash can when he parks in front of it, and winning a hot dog eating contest)."
- 2.12** By the way, if you saw the movie, he takes the mob guy's hat, and he takes it from the coat-check girl. And later on, he returns it to him, and the guy tips him \$100. Actually, he did that with Frank Sinatra, my father. He did it with Frank Sinatra. And when he returned his hat, they became lifelong friends after that. He never knew that he took that in the first place. That was my father. But because of legal reasons in the movie, and they didn't want to use Frank Sinatra's name, we made it a mob guy, which still you had to have the—I won't say the word, but you had to—to pull off something like that, my father, he didn't care about anything, so he did it.

- 2.13** "So we see he's respected, tough, and resourceful (stealing the hat, covering a hydrant with a trash can so he can park in front of it and winning a hot dog eating contest.) We also see he's racist when he throws away drinking glasses after his wife, Dolores, played by Linda Cardellini, offers water to two African American plumbers who fixed his kitchen sink."
- 2.14** That's another thing we're going to talk about, how to start a movie with your main character you dislike at the very beginning. But my father told me, forever, "You put that in. Otherwise, you're not going to see how I changed." So it was very important. So he's talking about that. So that was under his subtitle of Ordinary World. So you're seeing who your main character is.
- 2.15** "Call to Adventure: Tony's offered the job by Dr. Shirley, played by Mahershala Ali, to be his driver as Dr. Shirley's trio plays a series of musical engagements in the Midwest and the Deep South."
- 2.16** "Refusal of the Call: Tony turns him down when he's told he needs to do laundry, shine shoes, be a personal valet. He tells Dr. Shirley that he's not a butler. He turns down another job as muscle for a mobster," played by me in the movie, by the way.
- 2.17** That's another quick story. I played the mobster when he goes to see him, and I'm eating, and I'm saying, "You come work for me, blah, blah, blah." When we were casting, I was going to be in the movie. Brian Currie is in the movie. He plays the state trooper, the other writer. Pete never said to me who he wanted me to play, and I wasn't going to push upon him who I should play. I was just waiting to see. One day, he said, "All right, let's talk about you, the part in the movie. What are you thinking?" I go, "Well, I guess I'll play like one of the family members."
- 2.18** It's my family because my brother is in that scene. My real brother played Viggo's brother, my brother Frank played my father's brother. My brother Frank played my uncle Rudy. But the real Uncle Rudy, my father's brother, played their father. So he played my grandfather because he was in his 80s, and he looked just like my grandfather, and he spoke Italian. So he played the grandfather. Viggo is his son, my father, Tony. My brother was Uncle Rudy, young. On my mother's side, my uncle Louis, my mother's real brother, played his father. So I had real family members in the movie, which made those family scenes a little bit special because they were there when these things were happening.
- 2.19** Viggo Mortensen tells a story that when he first met all of them, I had him come and I had him eat all this food. My brother had a restaurant in New Jersey called Tony Lips, and Viggo wasn't sure if he wanted to do the movie, which I'll get into this also. But just as an aside, long story short, he met all my family, and then he called Pete up and said, "Oh, it was great," blah, blah, blah.
- 2.20** But yeah, "What a risk you're taking, Pete. You're casting all these guys that aren't actors as the family members. You're already doing a risk. This is not one of your crazy

comedies. Shouldn't you maybe—" He goes, "I love them, but I think they're perfect." Pete's like, "What are you talking about? Who's cast? What roles?" He goes, "No, the brother is playing his brother, the uncles are playing their grandfathers."

- 2.21** Pete called me up. I said, "Pete, listen, I've had this in my head a long time. First of all, my brother, he's a better—he should be Tony Lip. He was a car salesman. He used cars, new cars. He had car dealerships. He was acting all day, every day anyway. It was like my father; he had the gift of gab." I said, "My two uncles look just like their actual fathers. They speak Italian. We'll just have them yelling in Italian. It's going to look great. They don't have to know how to act," which is what happened. It made those scenes special, I think.
- 2.22** So where are we now? "Meeting the Mentor: There are two examples that meet the classic definition." Meeting the mentor is a category. "The first is when Tony meets the record label exec who pays him the money to give him the Green Book and lists the hotels and restaurants that Dr. Shirley can stay and eat at when traveling through the South. This is a very archetypal moment as they serve the classic mentor role of giving the Hero tools that he'll need on his journey. Then Tony meets Dr. Shirley's backup musicians, Oleg and George. Oleg will prove to be more of a mentor. Although his mentoring duties are limited but important, Oleg ends up being an archetypal shapeshifter, as well, as he not only acts as a mentor, but spends scenes both as an enemy and an ally." We're almost done with this.
- 2.23** "Crossing the First Threshold"—that's another subheading— "It's as simple as when they get in the car and start driving. That's the point where the adventure begins, and we cross from Act One into Act Two."
- 2.24** "Tests, Allies, and Enemies: This stage sets the rules and shows the reality of the two men not understanding each other. Tony fails several tests at first, like during Dr. Shirley's first concert, he plays craps with the other chauffeurs. He seems to fail another test when he steals the jade stone from the gift shop, but ends up winning when he keeps the rock and it ends up being a token. He passes a test when he makes the custodian in the Indiana concert hall get the right piano for the second concert." A little slap in the face for that.
- 2.25** "He passes another test when they share KFC, but fails when he throws his cup out of the car window, and Dr. Shirley makes him back up to pick it up." True story. By the way, every story in Green Book was true. Every one. This chicken story, my father told it on the tape. It's exactly the way you see it in the movie. Donald Shirley told me he was appalled when my father threw the thing out the window. Viggo Mortensen ate 16 chicken breasts while they were filming that scene. It was great.
- 2.26** "At this point, the two of them start to connect. Then there is the first night in Kentucky when Tony rescues him from rednecks in a bar. Each test becomes more difficult and raises the stakes. This is especially true as they move through the South, starting with

the first concert in Raleigh, North Carolina, when Dr. Shirley isn't allowed to use the bathroom in the house, though Dr. Shirley is helping through the house." Then the next section, "Dr. Shirley helps Tony write the letters. Dr. Shirley is not being allowed to buy the suit, and culminating with Tony bailing Dr. Shirley out of trouble at the YMCA, only to build Dr. Shirley's resentment."

2.27 "Approach: They're pulled over by racist cops on a rainy night and arrested." True story.

2.28 [Supreme Ordeal]: "They're sitting in jail, and Dr. Shirley chastises Tony for resorting to violence and not maintaining his dignity. Dr. Shirley calls none other than Bobby Kennedy to get them out of their current situation, then loses his cool on Tony when Tony accuses him of not being 'black' enough." Bobby Kennedy's story is a great—I'll tell you that later.

2.29 "The Reward: Tony writes his own letter. Shirley stands up for himself in the restaurant in Birmingham, and he finally plays his own music, which happens to be Chopin, to an unlikely yet adoring crowd."

2.30 "The Road Back: A literal road back as Dr. Shirley drives the car so Tony can make it home for Christmas Eve." He goes into a little bit more.

2.31 "Resurrection: Tony wakes up in the car and returns to his family, a changed man, no longer racist and with a broader mind of the world around him."

2.32 "Return with the Elixir: Dr. Shirley shows up at Tony's apartment on Christmas Eve, and a bridge has been built between the two."

2.33 He closes with, "Not only is this a very effective Hero's Journey that allowed the writers, Nick Vallelonga, Brian Currie, and Peter Farrelly, to play with the structure, but there is some sensational character work going on in the screenplay. One of the criticisms of the film was that Dr. Shirley is nothing more than a trope to allow Tony to overcome his racism. I disagree with that criticism for a couple of reasons," and he goes into his reasons about all of that.

2.34 Then the story goes on and on. He talks about the two of them a little bit more. "Overall, there's a lot of great technical screenwriting happening in Green Book. It's a well-structured story and has characters that change and grow in realistic and emotional ways. If you're an aspiring writer, this is a script you should study because it demonstrates both dramatic storytelling and effective character development. This is a script worth studying and was worthy of the Oscar it won."

2.35 Thank you for that very nice review and a very nice breakdown. Points made. A lot of thought went into that, the structure and breaking it all down. The problem with that is we weren't thinking of any of that when we wrote the script. None of it. None of it.

2.36 He says, "As Christopher Vogler explains in his book, *The Writer's Journey*, which describes the Hero's Journey, formatting style for a script, and how Green Book follows

that." I guess it does when you break it down that way, but we didn't plan it out that way. None of it. It never occurred to us to do that.

- 2.37** Now, I'm not diminishing what we did, but my point of it is that it fell into what this guy felt was a planned-out way to write a script. Now, I'm not taking away from that. We're going to talk about that again in a minute. But our formatting wasn't that. It was, again, through osmosis.
- 2.38** We had this story. It had a built-in beginning, a built-in middle, and a built-in end. We weren't thinking of where does act one or act two start. It happened just because it flowed into that. We didn't break down where's the character arcs, where's the hero's journey, all those things that were mentioned earlier, that this guy figured it all out, that it worked against that format, but we didn't do that. We just took all the great scenes. I talked about this script, about the story to Brian and Pete. I had the notes. I had my tape, my father talking about it. We had tapes of Dr. Shirley. I had written out basic scenes and outlines. We just started writing it. We didn't look at where's the arc? Where's the scenes? Let's move the cards. When we get into all that, I'm going to show you some of the formatting type stuff. But as I said, it just flowed.
- 2.39** That's why I was telling you about your first draft of your story. Just get it out because you've seen enough movies, you've read enough books. You know it's going to have a beginning, middle, and end. It's going to have an act one, an act two, an act three, just by osmosis. Does it have a sub-act Two A subplot? Does it have five acts? Maybe. That shouldn't be your focus.
- 2.40** Now, if you've never written anything and you really want to try to lock something in, a good idea is if it's a 90-page script, just break whatever length you think your script should be, anywhere from 90 to 120 pages. It's either 30 or 40 pages should be act one, another 40 pages to act two, the other 30 or 40 pages for act three. But it sometimes doesn't work out that way.
- 2.41** But it's a guide for yourself because sometimes I'm going, "If someone's going to look at this as an act, I think act one is done in the first 20 pages. I want to get the thing moving. I set up the problem. Let's get going. I don't need another 10 pages." So I don't follow that.
- 2.42** Whatever feels right to you because everyone's telling a different story. But there's a lot of books written on how to do this. Because I do it in such a bizarre, maybe, way, at the end of this course, maybe don't listen to one word that I have said and get one of these books or all of them, as we're going to discuss, and do it that way, whatever works for you.
- 2.43** But I feel the first thing you need to do is get your story out. You've got to get it out. Write it out somehow, some way. If it is a treatment, which is just basically in book form, writing it out. But as you're doing a treatment, write your description. This

happens, this happens. He says this. Any thoughts or ideas of going into dialogue? Like I said, we did it through osmosis. We just knew how it felt.

- 2.44** Now, osmosis is the process of gradual, or unconscious assimilation of ideas and knowledge, if you have it embedded in you. When I grew up, besides my love of film, I got a job as an usher in a movie theater. So I would watch movies over and over. In those days, the movie would stay in the theater for 9 months, 6 months, because you couldn't see it anywhere else. So after a while, even the greatest movies—most people—we got people working in the theater, but I would go in all the time, just keep watching them.
- 2.45** It's almost—I told you that my first film class was *The Godfather*, being on the set. And then when I did my little films, I had a high school teacher that had a film class, Joe Zahro. Everyone took that class as a senior because you could just go to sleep in it and not really do anything. But I took it. I loved it. And Joe Zahro was like, "Well, finally, I got a student that actually cares." The first movie he showed us, the first one he showed, they would screen it on 16-millimeter projectors in the classroom. And he had it all set up and he was by the lights. And he said, "Now, the greatest film ever made, *Citizen Kane*." He hit the lights. He was very dramatic about it. But when I saw *Citizen Kane*, I went, "Oh, my God, this could be the greatest movie ever made." I saw a lot of great films in that class.
- 2.46** But the point is, I watched lots and lots of film, and especially being an usher in a movie theater. I saw films over and over and over and over again. One time, I would say, "Let me look at just the story. Let me look at the characters. Let me look at the editing. Why do you pop to a close-up?"
- 2.47** See, that's another thing about filmmaking, the film of your screenplay. You could say a lot. Has everyone seen a Clint Eastwood Western? Go put on a Clint Eastwood Western. It's a lot of good ones.
- 2.48** You can write all the things you want. You can have half a page. But if you cut to a close-up of Clint Eastwood's face and his eyes just move, you know something's up, right? You say a lot. That's why film is the visual medium that it is. You can say so much with just a shot.
- 2.49** There's a famous example of *Lawrence of Arabia*—another movie you have to watch, must watch, one of the greatest films of all time. There's a battle between the rebels, and I believe the Arabs. It's a famous battle scene, and it's like 20 minutes in the movie. The line in the script was "The rebels attack." That's all it was, like three, four words, 20 minutes of the film. Again, a screenplay is different than books, different than outlines. It's all about how you write it.
- 2.50** I'm going to go into some books here that, like I said, books you should read, okay? You must read. I think you should have them. I'll tell you my experience with them. The first one we're going to talk about is by a gentleman named Syd Field. Screenplay: The

Foundations of Screenwriting, a step-by-step guide from concept to finished script. Mr. Field, his expertise in this book: "Why the first 10 pages of your script are crucially important? How to visually grab the reader from page one? What structure and character are the essential foundation of your screenplay? How to adapt a novel, a play, or an article into a screenplay? How to protect your work?"—as one of our questions was earlier. "Three legal ways to claim ownership, and the essentials of writing great dialogue, creating characters, building a storyline, overcoming writer's block, getting an agent, and much more."

- 2.51** This is a very famous book—still is. When I started, went out to Los Angeles over 35 years ago, this book was big then. It's still big now. I've never read it, but I heard it's fantastic. You should pick this up because, again, I'm telling you, I don't know if it will work for you. You might need the structure. You might be that type of person. This type of book does it.
- 2.52** My thing for me is, because I've got to get things done, I said this earlier, I want to just do it. To me, I think, "Oh, if I read this book, I could be writing." So it's taking up my time. Having said that, this is an excellent book. I have no connection to any one except one of the books I'll tell you about. So I'm not promoting anything in particular, but this is a very famous book on screenwriting.
- 2.53** With that, the next one—and someone asked me about this earlier, if I was even going to mention this—is a book called Story by Robert McKee, Substance, Structure, Style, and the Principles of Screenwriting, award-winning methods from Hollywood's master of the craft, much thicker than Syd Field's book, but basically covers a lot of the same ways. Formatting properly, three-act structure, four-act structure, five-act structure. I just happened to open it at structure and meaning.
- 2.54** A lot of big writers went to his seminars. He holds big, big seminars that he sells out. A lot of great writers have taken his classes and his courses. Maybe they should have had him here instead of me. I don't know. He's really good at what he does. I never read this book. I heard it's fantastic, though. I would say you should probably get it.
- 2.55** Another great book is quite honestly, an amazing, amazing book. This is Stephen King On Writing. This is fascinating. It's an amazing read because it's one of the best writers of our time. A Memoir of the Craft. It does give you the how-tos of writing, but he also tells personal stories of how he wrote things.
- 2.56** King is very big. This one I did read, very big on writing every day. He has a method to his madness. He makes sure he gets in a certain amount of hours every morning or writes a certain amount of pages every day. That's why I guess he's so proficient in how many books he's written, which is why I'm still trying to get another movie made because I don't do it his way. His way might be the best way if you're really just writing, getting up and forcing yourself to write pages every day.

- 2.57** That's one thing I do try to do now is when I'm in a screenplay, I try to get five pages a day. I've changed that to a point because if you stop, that stopping is going to continue. You're going to get lazy. It's like, "I missed the gym today. I'll go tomorrow." Something comes up, you missed the gym. No, you missed the gym two days in a row. That's how you have to look at writing, because there's nothing better to getting writing the end. Even if it's your first draft, it's the greatest release and relief in history to get to that end.
- 2.58** Like I said in the other lecture, you may have it all done. It's going to be obstacle after obstacle to get it done because you're going to go, "I thought I had this worked out in my head. This doesn't really make sense at all. But what do I do with this character? How do I move forward?"
- 2.59** I had a script I was writing. I hadn't made anything. I directed a couple of little movies, and I said, "You know what? I'm just going to make a movie." It was May. I said, "June first, I'm making a movie. I'm not writing a script until June. I'm going to start production on a little movie. I don't care if it costs, if I have to max out my credit cards." I didn't have a script. I didn't have an idea. I just said to some of my friends, "We're going to do something. June first, we start filming." I just started writing something. I ended up making it. I raised \$35,000. We made it on, obviously, video, but we sold it. It's a small little, crazy movie because I just wanted to shoot something with my friends, which we're going to get into that, too, when you have your script. But what does that have to do with Stephen King? Oh, I know—what I was just saying.
- 2.60** So when I was writing that thing, it was about these aliens, their planet is gone. They've got to find another planet, and they can get into human bodies, a little bit like *Body Snatchers*, a little bit. It took a little bit from that. This one alien gets into the body of a guy who was dying. They only were going into bodies of people who were dying. But he goes into the body of a guy who gets executed. He's a serial killer. Now the alien is inside the serial killer—again, I shouldn't be writing these types of movies. It's about him now going around. He still has impulses—his physical mind is still in there. He starts killing people all over the place, but the alien is inside.
- 2.61** Long story short, there's an FBI chasing—and this is FBI, a female FBI agent. I created this great character, and she was going to be my lead throughout the whole movie. She was going to deal with the whole thing. And the first time, she saves the guy because they need him to study the alien to see if they can get it out of this serial killer guy. So she gets him. She finally gets him, and she saves him from other people trying to kill him or take him. And she's with him in five minutes, and I go, "Okay, the rest of the script, I've got to have the two of them together." You have this serial killer alien with this FBI agent woman who's at the top of her game in this journey.
- 2.62** And I go, "Ugh, I don't know." I was writing it, I was writing the scenes. She's talking to him. And it just hit me. I just went in the middle of the conversation, I said, "You know what? He chokes her to death." This is on page seven. My whole script is about the two

of them. I said, "What if he just—because he's a serial, he can't help it, he just turns, and he kills her." Then he sits down like nothing happened. Now she's dead. He's trying to—but I just lost basically my lead character. What do I do? How do I write myself out of this problem? Which I did somehow, in some way. My point of it is, you get into these dilemmas, but by writing every single day, you're going to move it forward, move it forward, move it forward. But things change.

- 2.63** But this book, Stephen King On Writing—amazing. And let's talk about Stephen King a little bit more. Stephen King had many of his novels made into films. When they first started being made into films, he wasn't writing the screenplays. Most of those movies were terrible. Stephen King hated the movies from his books. Now, a massive big seller, Stephen King.
- 2.64** He couldn't understand why these movies were bad. And why were they bad? How many of you have read a great book, a great novel, seen it made into a film, and you go, "It's horrible." It's not the film. Because what do they do? They change it, right? They change it. They adapt it. And adaptation is a form of writing, too.
- 2.65** When you adapt a book, and I adapted one, and I tried to stick as much as—the book was so good, I just put the book in screenplay form. I give the writer of the book the credit. I mean, I'm adapting it, but it's not an original screenplay.
- 2.66** But why are those movies so bad? Why did he hate these movies until he started getting personally involved after a while, after so many years, and they got better? Rob Reiner, for example, made *Misery*, right? The script is written by William Goldman, who we're going to talk about in a minute. But William Goldman is a genius writer and stuck to the book. So you have one of the greatest writers of all time, and there are people in there—executives, producers, directors—who they're hiring.
- 2.67** I always said, why don't they just let him write the screenplay to his book? They messed them up, changed them. And that drives me nuts. It must have really driven him nuts because he's got a bit of a temper. But my point is, even one of the greatest writers of all time, they decided to rewrite his work. And he talks about all that in this book. Fantastic, fantastic book.
- 2.68** Then there's this book that I had never heard of until a year or two ago called *Save the Cat! The Last Book on Screenwriting You'll Ever Need*, I guess. *Save the Cat!*
- 2.69** I was being interviewed in Germany, in Berlin, for some film festival, like this, but with an interviewer asking me about it. And he said to me, "I have a question for you, and many of the German film critics knew I was interviewing you. So we all have the same question. Could you please talk about, did you use *Save the Cat!* when you wrote *Green Book*? Because everything is *Save the Cat!*, the way you did the characters and the plot points and the arcs, it's all *Save the Cat!* He goes, "It's exactly *Save the Cat!*" I said, "What's *Save the Cat*? What are you talking about?" He goes, "No, it's the greatest

book on screenwriting." He goes, "And you followed it. In Europe, everyone thinks, 'Oh, they use Save the Cat!'" I had never heard of Save the Cat!

2.70 I still haven't read Save the Cat! I guess we followed it, but we didn't follow it by using the book. Maybe it just fits into this guy's profile. I would like to read it just for the title. I think it's a funny title, Save the Cat! It's obviously getting a cat into a dilemma and then getting the cat out of the dilemma, I guess. That's what it means. I haven't read it, but then I asked around, and a lot of people say—this is by Blake Snyder. Again, The Last Book on Screenwriting You'll Ever Need. I've never read it, but I heard it's quite fantastic. So, another one you might want to look into.

2.71 But all of these go into what we were talking about earlier. Structure, acts, breaking down characters. Do you do the cards and write out every scene on a card, what's going to happen, all those types of ways to do it before you actually start writing. All valuable, all viable. I just don't do any of that.

2.72 This is a book that I met the author. It's called Meaning at the Movies by Grant Horner. I highly recommend this. This gets into writing in general, story lines in general, like I talked about earlier, like all the story lines come from Shakespeare, which I'll get into. And this is based on a Christian perspective and a religious perspective of how story lines mimic a lot of the Bible, which we'll get into, too. But this was a really great read, very intellectual read.

2.73 It's hard for me. The reason I don't read a lot of these books— even now, talking about writing or reading about writing to me can be boring. How do you really articulate how to write? What do we've got? We have six more hours of this that we're going to do. I'm not sure how we're going to get through it, but I'm going to try. But my point of it is: it's difficult for me to read about the process of writing. But these books here that I've discussed already are supposedly fantastic. This one I read on writing is fantastic. You might want to look at that, Grant Horner, Meaning at the Movies. I might use some of the things in this book later on.

2.74 But the best, I think, book ever written about writing and movies, although Stephen King's is pretty much up there, is Adventures in the Screen Trade by William Goldman. Has anyone heard of this book?

2.75 Okay. William Goldman is—let me get all his little information up here, so I give him enough credit. William Goldman wrote movies. He's one of the greatest novelists and screenplay writers ever. He won two Academy Awards, one for Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid, which was an original screenplay of his. Has anybody seen that movie? You know those movies? He wrote All the President's Men, which was an adaptation of the book. He wrote The Princess Bride. He wrote Misery, Marathon Man, A Bridge Too Far, the list goes on and on.

2.76 There was a rumor, I don't know how true it is, that he had read Ben Affleck and Matt Damon's screenplay, Good Will Hunting, that he might have given them some advice or

some tips on that, but they wrote a fantastic screenplay. But his name comes up all the time.

- 2.77** This book, very famous. It not only teaches you how to write scripts, but the ins and outs of Hollywood really well, what he went through. That's where we get our famous quote, "Nobody knows anything." It's a theme through this whole book, and it's something you've got to keep in your mind because it came true for me many, many, many times.
- 2.78** He talks about all the big movies and scripts that were written that were passed on, saying they were junk. Big studios: "Ee don't need that." Oh, it's E.T. It made a billion dollars. How many films that he was told no one's going to watch it. It's not good. It's terrible. Studios passing on it. Another one may be picking up the project, and it becomes hugely successful. The reason is, he goes, "Because nobody knows anything."
- 2.79** It is very, very true. It's all opinion. Most of the executives have never written a thing. They've never acted. They've never written. They've never directed. They've never made a film. They're in an executive position. Their job is to keep their job. If they green-light something, it better be good, because if it fails, it tanks, they're getting fired.
- 2.80** Most of the time, they don't green-light anything. They just ride along. They say, "Well, it's close." It's very difficult to get a movie green-lit by a studio. I'm an independent filmmaker. Everything I have done was independent. Even Green Book, to a point, was an independent film, and I'll get into that in another one. But that's the only time I ever worked with a studio. It turned out well. But even then, there was a lot of things going on with the studio.
- 2.81** William Goldman talks about when you get to the point now you're shopping your script, you want to get a movie made, who you're dealing with, how you got to deal with it. But the best thing I got out of this when I read it, and I got a lot of great things, quite honestly, is: Don't listen to anyone because nobody knows anything. It's just their opinion. You've got to believe in yourself and what you know.
- 2.82** Now, you can't go through life—if everything you've ever written, people say is terrible, if you've never really gotten anything sold or made, it's like an actor, you've got to reach a point. "I've never got cast in a part. I want to be an actor." You've got to come to some realization.
- 2.83** I don't believe in giving up on dreams. I never gave up on the dream. But I had moments along the whole way that kept me moving forward. Could I have quit? I thought about it, yes. For moments going: What am I doing? I'm giving up really a life. I don't have a real life. I'm constantly struggling. I'm doing this and this, fighting, fighting. But I believed in myself.

- 2.84** The other scripts, I could write. This week, I can write something. We're going to write something later on. We're just going to start writing a script. We can do that. Anyone could do it. I could write something, and even now, I could write something, and sell it and get it made. But to get a film made and a film of the quality of Green Book made, almost impossible. But it can be done. But I didn't give up. You see, some people, it happens to earlier in life. For me, it happened later in life, but I still didn't give up. But I had at least enough hints that maybe what I'm doing is okay.
- 2.85** The one movie I always had in my head that I thought, if I could just get this made. I didn't think of winning Academy Awards. I never thought of that. I just thought it would be a great movie, I think. And I did have some—not agendas, but there were some things I wanted to say about dignity, human beings, about how people can change, overcome obstacles, how everyone is the same. That gets dumped on a lot. Everyone's the same. That's why we like movies and books and novels, because it's about the human condition.
- 2.86** Everyone feels the same things. Everyone has ups and downs, highs and lows. People are in love, out of love. There's good, there's evil, there's catastrophes, there's sadness. That's why we watch these movies, I believe, because we want to see how do other people deal with the tragedies? How do other people overcome good and evil?
- 2.87** Goldman gets into all of that. One of the greatest things is it has the entire screenplay for Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid. When you read a writer like this, and a level of that screenplay—I advise getting books and reading screenplays to some of the great movies—when you read them, it'll change everything of how you write your screenplay, because some of them read like you're reading a novel, but yet it's still a screenplay. It can be done.
- 2.88** You don't need flowery descriptions, because like I said, the good scripts, you're only putting up on the screen what you could see on the screen or hear the characters say. It's a difficult task how to describe those things. But you could still put some passion into it. The dialogue obviously has to pull it in. You have to be like, you are in the room with these people. You're hearing them speak. What pulls you together? And what is the story? The screenplay for that movie is so brilliantly written. It's like you're watching the movie when you're reading it, and it reads like that. Read as many screenplays as you can read, and get your hands on; I would suggest doing that.
- 2.89** Adventures in the Screen Trade, Grant Horner's Meaning at the Movies, Stephen King On Writing, Save the Cat!—I'm giving him a plug. I've never read it. Syd Field and Robert McKee's books, all about formatting and what you need to do.
- 2.90** I think each one will affect you differently. This is written almost novel-like, and so is Stephen King's. Grant Horner's is a little bit more detailed into the process and what things mean and why these themes keep recurring in mostly all kinds of films. These

three are about how you format and the technical part of screenwriting, which is tough with something that's so creative that you want to be technical for.

- 2.91** I'll talk a little about the Green Book screenplay writing process. When I finally decided to do it with Pete and Brian, we got together, we ran through all the stories. I had to listen to all the tapes that I had recorded of my father. A good thing I did that when I was younger. I also showed them—so, I had tapes of my father telling all the stories.
- 2.92** Then I went and interviewed Don Shirley, asking about the same stories that my father told me because my father said—after I taped as much as I could get out of him, and they're fantastic tapes; they leaked some of them on the internet at one point. My father said, "You've got to go talk to Dr. Shirley because for A, you got to get his permission, and B, he could tell you his side of the story. I'm telling you my side of the story. You need his side," which, of course, was fantastic.
- 2.93** Dr. Shirley spoke to me, told me everything. Like I said in the other lecture, but he said he had terms of how he wanted to do it, that I could talk about their trip together, their time together. It was interesting how there were some stories, they said it word-for-word exactly how it happened. I was very blessed by that. But then I got his insights.
- 2.94** For example, when you see the movie, Dr. Shirley asks my father a lot of questions. He was a doctor because he was a doctor of psychology. He had a doctorate in psychology and a couple of other things—a brilliant man. He said, "When I met your father, it was like a case study for me." He said, "I wanted—I needed to know what is this guy thinking? It was unlike anyone that I've ever encountered." But he knew that on this trip, he was going to have a lot of problems and a lot of issues. So he needed someone to take care of him.
- 2.95** He said he would push my father's buttons by asking him certain questions and saying certain things that he didn't really mean. There were some things in the script, and I'll save some of this, but where we were attacked, "Dr. Shirley didn't say that, or he didn't mean that, or he said this." It doesn't mean he didn't mean it or didn't think it. He said things to my father on purpose and told him different information just to see how my father would react to him, which was one of the interesting things about their back-and-forth.
- 2.96** He found my father's life fascinating. He also found my father's life fascinating as far as the family goes. That's when my father told my mother—my mother made my father promise, "You have to write a letter to me everywhere you go." My father didn't want to write. My father didn't get out of the eighth grade. Pete Farrelly used to say he didn't get out of second grade, but he didn't get past the eighth grade. He didn't write anything. But he promised her that he would do that.
- 2.97** In those days, when you went to hotels, they had stationery in the hotels where they would give you the envelopes with the name and the address of the hotel and stationery with the hotel logo on it. My father would write her all these letters. In those

letters also was what they did that day, what they ate that day. "He told me to get this piano that day. The guy didn't have it. I had to smack him. He gave me his chequebook and said he trusted me with it." He goes, "I felt so honored that he trusted me. I protect him." All these things in these letters.

- 2.98** My mother one day came to me and said, "You're going to write this script one day." This is when I'm 15 years old. "I have something for you." She had the box of 96 letters that my father wrote. She had them all. It was all in there. I had those letters, which, thank God, she saved them. That was an immense help in the storytelling because we could go, "Oh, when they were in Charleston on this date, this happened."
- 2.99** In the writing of a script like this, people say, "What's true, what's not true?" I'm going to say here: everything in that movie is true. Everything happened. It's all documented. I have the tapes, I have the stories, I have the letters.
- 2.100** But was their creative license taken? Yes, of course, because you can't just— they were actually on that trip for a year and a half. The first part of the trip did end at Christmas, but they started in August. They were gone for a little bit longer. Pete wanted to put it on a shorter time frame, jam it all in and make a ticking clock, which is a device in the film. There's a ticking clock. He's got to get home or wants to get home for Christmas. So that was a device that we used.
- 2.101** So what we did was we took all the best stories and combined them into an order that basically happened as they happened. But we put some things together. There were a couple of things written. "Oh, this didn't happen. It didn't happen exactly like that. They were arrested in this town for something—" Well, they were arrested several times. Robert Kennedy called one time. So we combined a couple of the story lines. My father got arrested multiple times there. They brought in Dr. Shirley. A lot of it was as you saw in the movie.
- 2.102** If they just saw a white man driving a black man, that was cause to pull them over. There were these things called sundown towns that you don't pick up unless you're really listening to the film. If a black man was out in the sundown, what we call a sundown town, past sundown, he gets arrested, period. They were driving through one of those towns, just going through to get to the other side. My father never heard of a sundown town. He didn't see any signs.
- 2.103** So, there's a lot of that stuff that we combined. We took the best of all the stories. You can't repeat the stories. They're arrested 10 times. You can't put that in. We just put them all in, combined them, put them in the ticking clock. And that was our format of a beginning, middle, and end.
- 2.104** But again, we didn't consciously say, "Act one ends here, Act Two starts here." I mean, you could say like he did, yeah, Act Two started when they took off. On what page that was, I couldn't tell you. I don't know where Act Two blends into Act Three, because Act Two would seem to me would be a lot longer. It was only the very end when Don

Shirley finally says, "Let's go home." That's the very end of the movie. Did we follow that structure? We maybe had a normal Act One and a real long Act Two and a shorter Act Three if we're going to break it down like that.

- 2.105** But all of those things did happen the way you see them. I think that's what you said earlier, it's about people. I think that's why people connected to the movie, because if I made up stories that happened to them, then it would be meaningless, that movie. You could write a fictional account of that movie. You could make things up. It might be interesting. But the fact that it's true, truth is stranger than fiction, I think that's what endeared it to people, because this really happened to those two human beings.
- 2.106** And what did they do to get through it? How did they change each one of them? How did they bond? They became friends for life. They weren't best friends hanging out every day. My father had a family. We moved to New Jersey. But my father would go into the city all the time, have a lunch with Don Shirley, keep in touch with him. He brought me up there.
- 2.107** When I first described Don Shirley living above Carnegie Hall to Pete and Brian, they didn't believe me until we started finding some photographs of it. He lived above Carnegie Hall. He had floor-to-ceiling windows. He had a massive grand piano in the room, and he had a throne that was sitting up higher than everything else. He would sit up on that throne. When I went there, he put me on the throne. I sat on the throne. My father was like, "Doc, play him something on the piano. Play him a little something. Show him you know how to play the piano." Don Shirley's playing on the piano, I'm sitting on this throne.
- 2.108** I had eyewitness accounts, my own. I had my father's stories, my mother's stories when he was gone. I was only five or so when it happened. We played my character a little older, my brother a little bit older. That was because they said, "Well, we can't have kids too little running around to deal with them. Let's just make the kids older." But I was about five when it happened, but I have a complete memory of it because it was a sit-down about your father's going away.
- 2.109** My brother didn't really get it because he was three. But for me, it was your father's going to be going away. He's going to be away for a while, blah, blah, blah. I completely had that recollection of it and what my mother was going through, what it was like when he wasn't there, et cetera, et cetera. But all of that happened when he came home for Christmas Eve and he made it home. Everything you see in the movie happened.
- 2.110** Okay, check out these books. Watch as many of these films that I mentioned. We're going to get into a lot more detail in how to really get into the script. But about this, any questions from anybody? Yes.

- 2.111** Going back to the letters that your father wrote to your mother during the time he was off. I believe in the beginning of the movie, he was supposed to be gone for only two months. Then he was gone for a longer time.
- 2.112** Yeah, they actually were together about a year and a half.
- 2.113** Yeah. So, they developed this relationship. One of my favorite parts in the movie was when Dr. Shirley came to dinner at the end, and your mom whispered in his ear, "Thank you for helping my husband write these letters." I just chuckled at that because I knew it was coming, right? Because of mother—I mean, she's going to know how her husband writes, but the fact that she would love him either way, you had a blessed family.
- 2.114** Oh, thank you.
- 2.115** Yeah. Being able to read all those letters, could you tell where your dad was writing it, and then it moved towards, "I know somebody's helping him write these letters," where Dr. Shirley stepped in.
- 2.116** Yeah, it started getting a little flowery. Like I said, it took a while before he started helping him. But even the ones he wrote to himself, he was trying to express himself and say that he missed her and loved her and all that. But it was always, "How is—kiss the kids. I ate a steak today, and I had French fries. The ketchup was good." It was like that. Then it got a little bit better. And then he did it. At one point, he said, "I got it. I'm going to write it." So, he wrote some beautiful letters to my mom.
- 2.117** And he talked about issues that they had gone through. He really started getting more descriptive about how it was. He could read from his heart; he really was appalled by what was happening. This is too deep of a thing. He never said any racist stuff around us. He never put down anyone. We were around all kinds of people. He lived in the Bronx. There was nothing ever said.
- 2.118** But you come from a culture, there's certain beliefs you have, there's a certain clan, the Black people live here, the Jewish people live here, the Italians live here, the Irish live here, type of thing. It was ingrained in him. Like he said, "I've been around a long time. I know life's a little bit complicated." He told them. He worked in nightclubs. He worked around all kinds of people. He loved music, musicians. He would bring home all kinds of albums from the Copa, albums from Sam Cooke and all Black artists that he loved that music. But he still had this cultural way that he was brought up. I guess it was like, that's how everyone protected themselves, keep everyone else out.
- 2.119** But it wasn't until he really witnessed this type of racism to a man that he's getting to know that he is blowing his mind. His first reaction is, "What did he say to you?" Bang. That's what he wanted to do. And Don Shirley was saying, "I'm not here for that. I'm here to do this the right way. I have to keep my dignity," which you have to do. He learned from that.

- 2.120** I think Dr. Shirley also learned from him. He had some street smarts and ways of handling situations that Don Shirley never thought of. He saved him a lot, a lot of times. We show a couple of times in the movie, but he did save him a lot. That's something I'm going to get into later on, again, about what people call this movie and about my father's character and Don Shirley's character.
- 2.121** But having said that, yes, the letters changed. They took a turn, but then he started really being much more—he opened up about how to write to my mother, speaking about writing.
- 2.122** I'm Rocky.
- 2.123** Hi, Rocky.
- 2.124** A director like Tarantino emphasizes subtext a lot. How do you combine that into your writing style?
- 2.125** A director like Tarantino and a writer like Tarantino, again, one of the greats, right? Every movie he makes is special and fantastic. His writing is fantastic. But if you look at his writing and the movies he makes, what I talked about earlier, osmosis. Quentin Tarantino used to work when video stores first came out. He worked at one, like I worked as an usher in a movie theater. He watched everything. He's an encyclopedia for film and for writing.
- 2.126** He took all of that that he learned about the great movies, and he incorporates them. He does things sometimes purposely, I believe, as an homage to the great masters. But the greater films do have these subplots. It's not just—
- 2.127** Even *Green Book*, again, it wasn't necessarily planned to the point of what these books say, but we didn't just go write it, and that was done. No. We went through every word, every line, every plot point. We changed things, we arranged things differently.
- 2.128** Pete Farrelly wanted to move a couple of things, which we did because there is a lot of subplots in here. There's many stories going on. But ultimately, it's a love story, but it's a love story between—I would originally call this movie *Love Letters to Dolores* because I thought that sounded indie, and what does it mean? And it's about those love letters, but then those love letters connect also to Dr. Shirley teaching him how to write love letters. But it's a love story between my mother and father, but it's a love story between the two men. That has its own issues and things. How do we get that?
- 2.129** Tarantino, genius that he is, his scripts are amazingly readable, and he weaves a lot into his—that's why he takes a long time in between each one. He spends years writing his scripts, but he knows film inside and out.
- 2.130** Sometimes, my writing partner, George Gallo, and I have written a couple of things together. We're getting one. One is going to be made in the spring about the gangster, Carlo Gambino. When we write together, luckily, we have this backhand because I'll go, "You know what we need here? We need in that Sophia Loren movie, a dilly, the boy,"

and he goes, "Oh, yeah, the one blah, blah, blah." "Yeah." "You know that scene?" "Yeah, we need that scene." We have a way to connect over movies because we love movies.

- 2.131** In our writing, not that you take anything, I don't believe in taking anything, stealing, but moods and feelings and vibes and what we're trying to put across, you can reference something else that will help get you to the next step.
- 2.132** Because ultimately, like we're going to get into at one point, there's only so many story lines that are in everything, and we're going to connect to that, too. Knowing your film, knowing your scripts, knowing great literature, which we're going to get into also, is going to help you connect all the dots and make your screenplay deeper and better, hopefully.

Lecture 3: Writing in Practice

At a glance — Writing in practice.

- 3.1 Welcome back. Today, I might be jumping ahead here, depending on where this lands, but formatting is important as far as the actual script. Obviously, you don't have to do what I first did. When I first wrote a script, I got a book.
- 3.2 What's the typewriter settings to type it out? Final Draft is probably the industry standard. There was a Movie Magic Screenwriter. It was around for a long time. That was excellent, too. But pretty much now, Final Draft is the standard scriptwriting format. There's other ones that have come out. There's some good ones that allow you to do all kinds of things that you can't do in here, but now they've caught up. I have an older version of this. I haven't updated it. I'm in my Final Draft 11. I think they're on 14 or something. Maybe if they hear this, they'll send me the upgrade.
- 3.3 But there are the basic formatting rules. But having said that, it's all set in the Final Draft. So if you get this, you follow the blueprint. I'd make a couple of modifications on mine, and I will show you that after we do the basics. Based on the formatting, what goes where and how you do it, and what's the basic look of it, and what should you do?
- 3.4 We're staring at the blank page. What's the first thing we write? "Fade in." Okay, so there we go. Fade in. And whether it really fades in or not, it doesn't really matter. Now comes the next part. See where it says interior up there? That's automatic. The fade in, I write it on an action line. I'll get to all these. Action is where you write all your description. But in the case of this, I did that on purpose, making the fade in on an action line. Then you just hit your return button; it'll come down to an interior or an exterior. Interior is the location inside your first scene, or exterior is the location outside. This is called the slug line. All right. You have to know what it is because at the top of every scene, you need a slug line. You need to change it.
- 3.5 It's also very important to follow these rules and guidelines because, again, you're thinking more than just writing. And right now, all you've got to do is think about writing. Some people have no idea of this stuff. They write it out longhand; they just type it out.
- 3.6 But eventually, if you want your movie to get made, they take this Final Draft file, and then they put it in for scheduling and for character breakdown and day out of days and all the stuff that they pull the information from here. So it has to be in the right space, in the right spot in order for them to do that.
- 3.7 So right now, we went from an action line of fade in to an interior-exterior. So we're going to do this together. So, are we going interior or exterior? Who votes for interior? No one or two. So we have exterior, right? So we'll change it. Let's make it exterior. Exterior. Now we're going to put where it is.

- 3.8** Now we can go exterior, the Empire State Building, New York City, day. Or exterior, Scottsdale, Arizona, in front of the studio here, day. Or exterior, Copacabana, restaurant, night club in New York, night. So, someone pick an exterior, anything in the world. I'm going to make this up as we go along. I'm going to show you how you can do this. Now, usually, like I said, by this point, you should know what your script is about. But I'm going to show you that just by osmosis, we're going to do this together. Let's come up with something that's brand new that I didn't plan. I'm not planning anything.
- 3.9** So someone pick an exterior. Park? A park. Central Park? Which park? Central Park, New York. Now, this will be in capital letters. It will automatically do that. When you're on a slug line, it automatically will do that. "Central Park, New York City." I'm a bad typist. And then we're going to put day or night.
- 3.10** Day.
- 3.11** You're saying day. "Day." Okay. Now you hit your return button.
- 3.12** This next line is going to be an action line. We're going to do a description. So now we're in exterior Central Park, New York City, day. To make this easy, let's pick— our lead character is walking through the park. Do we want a male or a female? Of course, we're going to make it a female. And her name is Mary Smith. "Mary Smith." How old?
- 3.13** Thirty-eight.
- 3.14** "Thirty-eight." Pretty, normal.
- 3.15** Petite green-eyed.
- 3.16** "Petite green-eyed, walks through the middle of the park." Is she walking a dog? Is she by herself? Is she pacing? Is she running? Is she walking? We could say she looks anxious—that's why we have a spell check. I don't know how to spell either. "She looks anxious, her eyes darting around, as if she's searching for something." Would that make sense? Okay.
- 3.17** Now, there's a thing about action lines. You've got to have a little space. You probably don't want more than five lines without breaking it. And you always break it on a sentence. So each grouping of action lines—I call them action, just means description lines, really. It should end on a period, have a space. You can get away with six. But sometimes you see these action lines. That's not proper formatting for a script. You have to have breathability.
- 3.18** I like to look at it like you're almost writing. Again, you have to write what you see. So I look at it—I'm almost writing shots. I could put close up on her eyes: they dart back and forth. We can go into that type of detail. But that's almost, you're telling the director and the reader also the shots. Now, if it's real important that we see her eyes really close, we would put that.

- 3.19** But right now, you've got "Mary Smith, 38, petite, green-eyed, walks through the middle of the park. She looks anxious, her eyes darting around as if she's searching for something."
- 3.20** Another thing here is, and this is now changed, this is stupid stuff, but after a sentence, normally, when you write, you have two spaces. Some scripts do one. Some scripts do two spaces in description, but in dialogue, you only do one space. This could go either way. It looks better with one space. There's some people that freak out about that. It's the proper way to write it. It's just two spaces. We're going to use one space for now.
- 3.21** So now "she looks anxious, her eyes darting around as if she's searching for something." What do you want to happen next? What do you think she does? She sees something? I would put— but I'd like your input. She notices a little girl around five years old in a red sweater, the back of her, blonde. She runs over to her, right? She turns her around. A mother starts screaming. Should we write this out?
- 3.22** So I would write out. Let's get this going. Let's call a five-year-old girl. Well, another thing I have to do: Whenever you put a character, a new character for the first time that you see this character, you put it in capital letters. Because A, you're introducing a character, and later on, when they break the script down, they can count those characters and see who they are because they need to know who's in each scene. "She notices a little five-year-old girl wearing [a red sweater]"—we don't want it capped—" playing with a doll."
- 3.23** Back to Mary. Mary runs over to her, right? Isn't that what we said? "Mary runs over to her, turns her around. The girl looks scared. Her mother runs over." The mother grabs the kid and takes her away, right? What happens next? What is Mary—what are we doing with Mary?
- 3.24** Do we need to be more descriptive with the mother?
- 3.25** Describing—
- 3.26** How do we know that it is her mother? We don't have any video.
- 3.27** You're right.
- 3.28** Is that not important?
- 3.29** Well, I think there's some things, yes, you can't see that it's her mother, other than if we're going to have the woman run over and take her, "Hey, get away from her!", she pulls away. We could have the little girl say, "Mommy." The little girl is scared. It's a very good point. See, the rewrite is always important. So we'll have her scream "Mommy," it's better than describing it. A little girl.
- 3.30** Now, we could write her mother. We know it's her mother. Mother runs over. "'Hey, let go!' The mother pulls her away." I think as an opening, to me, depending on what—we can go any direction, we can still keep following this woman or not. To me, what I

would do right here is she pulls her away. We see Mary Smith's face. "Tears come in her eyes. She puts her hands to her head. She starts walking in circles," a high shot alone in Central Park. She starts crying. And we'll cut. That's a setup, right?

- 3.31** Okay. Angle—I'll put "angle." Whenever you want to really describe a shot, there's a few ways to do it. Close-up angle. "Angle from above: Mary drops to her knees." She looks alone in the middle of the crowd? Sits alone. Yeah. I'm going to put a transition now, which you just go up to the—this is where I'm old school. There's a button for this. There's a key. I'll just hit transition, and I'm going to put "cut to."
- 3.32** This is another thing: cut to's, you don't always need it. In this case, I want that smashed cut to this. We've just set this up. So obviously, we have a mother that's lost her kid. She's lost now, too. We see she's alone in full Central Park. I could probably describe that a little better, and I would probably put a little bit more description in there. But now we've set this up.
- 3.33** So now, is this a scene that we've just started with? So now I'd be interested in saying, "Well, what happened? Where's the kid? Who's the kid?" This could be a scene that we can come back to at the end of the movie. We can tell the whole story and get back to this scene. But we'll find out through the whole movie what happened to her daughter.
- 3.34** Or this could be the start of the movie, and now we go somewhere else, and we go maybe to another character, we go to another location. Do we include Mary in it? Is it a new character? Do we go to a police station, or that there's a police officer that handles missing children or something? We can also do that. What are we voting for? Where am I going? Interior, exterior? What's the next scene?
- 3.35** Going back to the very beginning of your action, of the very first scene, your description of Mary, would it be important to describe more of her? How often do you do that with writing your screenplays, or only when it's relevant to the character? For example, is Mary obese? Is she fit? Is she homeless? I mean— obviously, this is dependent on the character.
- 3.36** Yeah, it would depend on what we're doing. We have that she's petite, green-eyed. It looks like there's nothing—we haven't said that there's anything like that involved with her. So, we're looking at what looks like just a general young lady, 38-year-old lady running around Central Park. Now, I could put well-dressed. Maybe she's got a lot of money, which has something to do with this child being missing. We could put well-dressed. What's a great designer? Wearing Chanel? She would be out of place in Central Park or something. Would Chanel be a good choice? " Walks quickly," I would think. See, I would go back to all this anyway and redo it and fix it, depending on what I need and what I don't need. So in this case, we just add a little something.
- 3.37** But right now, that changes the vibe because she's obviously not homeless. She's got a lot of money. She's running around. She's quickly walking around frantically. She's dressed. You don't usually go to the park dressed that way. So we've just set up

something here that I think draws the reader in. Who is this? She just arbitrarily goes and grabs a kid. Who does that? Either you're crazy, or you're desperate. She thinks it's the girl. We're going to find more of that out later, but it's obvious.

- 3.38** The mother comes over, takes her away. Now she's like this, she's like this. So I'd probably go in, make sure that these things that I'm describing right now, because otherwise you'll just sit here watching me type forever. I want to keep moving it forward a little bit. But yeah, the description that you can see, and now we have everything here that you can see. And it was a great point about the mother. I could write "the mother." I just thought it was obvious when the mother says, "Hey, let go," and runs over. But the girl's screaming, "Mommy." We know now that's the mother when she comes over and gets her. So all these little things.
- 3.39** That's why I like writing it out anyway. Just write it out. Vomit it out. Get in there. Go back and look at it. Oh, I need to do that description better. I need, oh, I didn't really say this. Oh, yeah, put her in the Chanel. Really good.
- 3.40** Also, we're starting to build something that looks like a page of a script because you have a little white space. It's clear, it's readable. Certain lines, like I have "the mother grabs her daughter, pulls her away," because to me, that's one shot. That's in the shot. But then you're going to cut back. You don't have to say cut back, but you're visualizing. Now we're on Mary again. When I say, "Mary is visibly shaken," you're thinking of Mary's close-up in a sense, because we're seeing that she's visibly shaken. "She's starting to cry. Tears running down her eyes."
- 3.41** Then I am specific "from above" because it's high, because we want to make her look small. She's small in this big park, and she's obviously upset and crying. We know she's looking for her daughter. She can't find her. So that's how the description—and the description doesn't have to be long and flowering. These are almost little bullet points. But I think, and tell me if I'm wrong, I think we get what's happening in this first scene. In one scene, you're not even at the end of page one, and you're on a journey already with this person.
- 3.42** Now, she could be the mother that's looking for her daughter, as I just said. I just said it. She could be some fake thief who kidnapped a kid and then lost her, and she's posing as a mother with the rich money. We don't know who she is yet. I'd like to think of her as being the mother, but maybe that's a twist we find out later on, that she's not even her mother, and maybe she lost the kid. Maybe the kid got away, and she's just trying to get people, "I lost my kid." I don't know. I'm just throwing out ideas now.
- 3.43** But these are things that you would normally think out. Probably you're going to know that answer before you're writing this. But it also shows you that if you have an idea for some opening, but you don't know where to go with it, just write it out. Because we can go many places with this right now. There's obviously going to be some storyline about a missing kid. Was the kid kidnapped? Did the kid run away? Was there a custody

battle? Was the mother protecting her from an abusive father? Is she the mother? Is she one of the kidnappers? Now you have all these options open to you, depending on the storyline, but you have to think out this storyline. I'm trying to do a little experiment here to show you that you can do this. You can write it. If you're not sure, just go in and write it. Start writing something, anything.

- 3.44** All right, so now I wanted to get a page. We're almost at the bottom of this page. I don't know how much more we have to go through unless we write a whole script while we're here.
- 3.45** All right, so now we're in an interior police station. It doesn't have to be the same day. It could be night. It could be something else. What do you want it to be?
- 3.46** Early morning.
- 3.47** Early morning. If we already were in a day, so early morning the next day? We just went from a day to another day. I'd have to describe that, but let's see how—we'll see if we can make it happen. It's a different— police station, early morning. I probably wouldn't put next day here. Exterior. "Police station, early morning." All right. For now, we'll leave it. That might be a little issue, but that's a good issue to bring up. Sometimes you've got to get yourself out of a problem. So now we're early morning.
- 3.48** Who do we want to see here at this police station? Is it a detective who's in a missing person's division, or a kidnap—? Why are we in this police station? What character do we want to see?
- 3.49** I'm thinking we pan on the officer trying to get some response out of her.
- 3.50** So you want her in here?
- 3.51** I do, but we don't pan on her first. We open up with the officer trying to talk to her, almost like when you have that deafening sound, where you're being talked to.
- 3.52** So you're making a decision here, and we could do it. I'll tell you what I would do based on nothing. We've set this up. Like I said, we don't know if we're going to come back to this later on, or if this is how our movie starts. If we think we're going to come back to it later on, we can come to a character or a plot point of something that has nothing to do with this.
- 3.53** Now, my instinct here would be—and I've not thought of any of this, obviously, because we're doing it together. I wouldn't even go to a police station yet. I'd go to some weird house out in the middle of nowhere, nothing around it. And I would—this is just based on me. You see maybe a guy with a couple of kids. He's in a station wagon, but it's like he's getting groceries, and the kids are helping him carry them in. He looks like a father and his two sons are a boy and a girl. He goes into the house, and you hear some yelling and some screaming. Maybe there's a mother in there. We stay outside the house—I'm just making this up right now.

- 3.54** Then all of a sudden, out of the woods come all these SWAT guys. They bombard the house. The guy leading it, or a detective or a cop gets in there. They just kick down the doors. They're screaming. There's yelling. Kids are running. They grab the guy. They throw him down. The wife goes for a gun, maybe shoots it, bang, she gets shot. "My wife—" and these little kids are in the corner, and you see the cops grab the kids. And these were kidnapers that had these two kids.
- 3.55** And then we have our lead actor or actress come in, and you see who she is and what she does. She's part of a team that tries to find kidnapped kids. And then we take that storyline a little bit further. That's what she did. So now we will have her standing there. I think it's going to take too long to type, but I think you get the point of the typing.
- 3.56** So now we have her. So if we take her, and this first scene is going to happen later on, we've established who she is. So now maybe that was a rough one. Someone got killed, the mother. They had a shooter because she was blasting a shotgun. They got this guy. You see her maybe return these kids to the parents. All that homecoming, it's on the news. It's all this stuff. The mother and the father can't believe it. They got the kids back.
- 3.57** And maybe then we cut to her coming home to her husband and her kids and what's going on with her. She has to deal with her family. Then she gets a call. "Hey, you've got to get in here now. Something is up." And then we come back, and she's presented with this case of this other missing kid. But it's maybe a very high—it's a very rich person. And then she's got to go to Carnegie Hall or Central Park, and she's got to go speak to this person. They have tons of money, and there's no ransom note, but the kid's missing, and they tell what happened to that kid.
- 3.58** Or even better, we establish her, we get her home, we see her with her kids. The next day, we cut to a school, and somehow we see a kid, but it's a high-end school with lots of security, and it's rich kids going to the school in the middle of Manhattan for the higher-end people. Somehow, there's some raid—I'm trying to throw an action movie into this, too—and there's stuff going on, and this kid gets snagged, and he's gone and disappears. The next morning, she wakes, the phone's ringing. She's making breakfast for her kids. "You've got to get down here now." It's Joe Blow, the guy of New York, who has all the security in the world, and his kids just got taken. She has to go there and take care of that. Now this case has happened. So is that woman Mary? Is that character's wife? Or again, maybe down the road, we see, oh, no, she's one of the kidnapers.
- 3.59** My point is this can go in all different directions. So what we have here is the format for all of this. So even with this one scene, we've hit on everything. You have a fade in. Now, I do things—and many writers do this now. The slug lines are in caps because they have to stand out. Slug lines are also when they break down the script, where they put scene numbers. That's how they know: "Exterior. Central Park." So within your

description, for example, you can't go like, let's say we changed it. "She's visibly shaken and starts to cry"—I'm going to take this out as if we didn't do that. She gets up. "She walks out of the park, goes to a Starbucks, enters, sits down, makes a phone call."

- 3.60** Now, what's wrong with that description? What's wrong with it?
- 3.61** You've changed your location. You're in a new scene.
- 3.62** So what do you have to do?
- 3.63** You've got to create a new slug line.
- 3.64** "Walking out of the park"—okay, you can keep her there because we're in the park. So then it would have to be—we'd have to go down and make a new slug line, which we're going to do in a second. We go down, now we put "exterior." You have to go this extreme: "Exterior, Starbucks, Fifth Avenue. Day." We're still calling her the mother, right? "The mother, walking on Fifth Avenue, enters the Starbucks."
- 3.65** Then you have to get her inside. Now, this inside now, could be a jump cut. And by jump cut, I mean you don't have to always show every single thing that the person does. So now we've got her in the park. She walks out of the park. It's automatically a cut because we put her in a new exterior. Exterior one: Fifth Avenue. She's walking through, and she enters. We see her enter the Starbucks. Then we're going to put "interior, Starbucks." And if you can see, automatically, it's moving it to where it has to be. "Starbucks, day," where sometimes you could put—if it's continuous, it would be if now we see her at the door.
- 3.66** But I think we go exterior—I spelled this wrong. Starbucks. Maybe we should call it Starbucks. Then now we cut to "interior, Starbucks, day." Now we could have that she's already purchased her coffee. "The mother is sitting at a table. She picks up her cell phone, dials."
- 3.67** "Mother"—now we're doing something else. "Mother"—we're going to say "into phone." When someone's on the phone, you're supposed to say into phone. That's a parenthetical. It'll automatically move it there. Okay. So, what we did there was a jump cut, but it doesn't matter. We saw she's in the Starbucks. We don't need to see her ordering and getting the thing. It just cuts her at a table. Has her phone, there's a coffee in front of her, "I can't find her." Now, once again, is it the mother saying that? Is it the kidnapper saying that?
- 3.68** But we cut to another scene. We jump to another scene. We have a parenthetical here, which is a small description, especially when you're on a phone. And then I'd cut to the next day out in the woods, or it could be the same day. Wooded area, an old station wagon pulls up, there's two kids, a guy, what we talked about, right?
- 3.69** But what we have here on page one is something set up. Now, this is what I do, and many people do this. So, slug lines, when you look at it like this, you could see it, and you could see the names or caps. I like to bold them. I bold slug lines, and I bold

people's names the first time you see them in a script because it jumps out. A lot of people are doing this now. It helps. Again, this is not a script-writing thing. This is more for when they make the movie thing because they stand out.

3.70 Now, do you have to do this in this pass or like your reading draft? Not necessarily, but I still think it makes it easier to read because, especially when you go cut to another thing, we know that we're in another thing—when you get another scene, I should say, thing. Here's another character here, the mother, a new character, bold her. They stand out more, they jump out at you. You see the difference? I think it just helps.

3.71 It also helps to read because a lot of times, when everything looks the same, you forget things. Who's that? Where is it? What is it? So then when we come to this Starbucks, again, we would bold it out. But you can set this in Final Draft that whenever you do a slug line, it's going to bold it out.

3.72 There's also things you could do with slug lines—or scene headings, I should say, which are slug lines, scene headings, where you could put—see how over here, "She walks out of the park,"—there's two spaces between, if you can see up there, above Fifth Avenue. You could put it where there's one space. There's a lot of times when they say, "Oh, the script's too long," and I've forgotten to make them one space, and I just go through the whole script. You can do it automatically, "Oh, and just cut five pages out of the script." I didn't cut a word out of the script, but you could do that. They like a little breathing room between the new scenes. So again, technically, this is how I do it. And there are a lot of scripts that do it this way now, also.

3.73 So here we have a page one that we can work with. Right now, you have how you start, fade in. You have your first location, you have your first character, your first descriptions. It has a little breathing room. There's some white on the page because in a script also, it's approximately one page per minute. That's how you know with this formatting, one page per minute, approximately.

3.74 Now, I think I talked the other one about the Lawrence of Arabia line. One sentence was 20 minutes. So it depends on what you're doing. But for the most part, it's accepted that one page will be approximately one minute. So if you had 90 pages or 120 pages, no one wants to go over 120 pages. Even some people now, Hollywood, they don't want to—they go, "It's too long. It's too long." But then Oppenheimer comes out, it's three hours, and it's not too long. That's why "nobody knows anything." Remember, we talked about that? Nobody knows anything. "You can't make a Western. Those are out of date." Someone makes a great Western. Everyone's making a Western. Nobody knows anything.

3.75 But one thing we do now, approximately, if you do the formatting here, one page will equal approximately one minute. But if you just did this and you combined all your description and didn't put any spaces in it, you're throwing off the page count.

- 3.76** Not only are you throwing off the page count, you're throwing off the read. You need a little space to read a script. I don't know why it's different than a book, because there's a lot of movement going on. And like I said, if your description is describing almost shots of what you're seeing, which helps the reader see the movie, because as we said, you don't want to write a screenplay, you want to write a movie, make a movie, it helps with that type of imagery in the person's head.
- 3.77** So we can go on. Like I said, I would go from here, I'd go into the woods. Now we enter our man or woman that's going to be probably helping find this kid that we just met and get a little into her. And then you're on your way.
- 3.78** Where this would go? Like I said, today, we just came up with moments of things, we can go anywhere. He could go into the police. He could say early morning. Maybe I would go early morning, and it's the next day you're out in the woods with this guy who stole these kids. At first, we just see a family walking into our house, and then all of a sudden, they're bombarded. So we know what type of movie we're in. Someone's chasing after finding lost children. Any questions about this part so far?
- 3.79** How would you formulate the tone or emotion that the person is conveying in a dialogue in there? How would you say, maybe when she's asking, "I can't find her," she's calm, she just played an act like she's really the antagonist or something?
- 3.80** Yeah, no, that's an excellent question. So I just wrote, "I can't find her," right? I purposely thought—and again, I could be wrong now. It depends on what you want to give away. Do we want to give away anything? Can we say "into phone, monotone", "into phone, scared"? Because we could still trick the audience, maybe. If she's one of the kidnappers, let's say we're going with that. "I can't find her." She's still crying. We think she's crying because it's her kid. But that would go into this parenthetical here, "into phone, anxious, scared," "into phone, still crying, upset." That's where you would put those.
- 3.81** Now, that helps in a moment like this, because, again, in our case, we might be trying to trick the audience to think, "Oh, this is still a distraught mother." But if she was so distraught, maybe down the line, you think, "Well, she just walked into a Starbucks, and why is she not running—?" This could be a planned thing that you're setting up your audience for a reveal later on.
- 3.82** Having said that, a great actor, Christopher Walken—I had the opportunity, I might be doing a film with him, and we had a read-through of the film, and I had read this about him already. Christopher Walken, see those parentheticals? If I did put what you said, young man, "scared" or "monotone" or "no emotion," whatever he put in there, he doesn't want to see any of that. Christopher Walken, I asked him about it, and he told me, "I don't look at the punctuation, periods, question marks, sad, not sad, scared." He goes, "When they're written in there," he goes, "I just blank them out." Now,

Christopher Walken has his own cadence. He says things in ways that you would never think things to be said, but they're brilliant. So that's how he looks at it.

- 3.83** So a lot of people, actors especially, don't like that. But in this case, we're doing it on purpose for a reason, because we don't want the audience or the reader yet to know, is this the real mother? Is it not the real mother? Who is she? What is she? But I can't find her. There's a missing kid. Something happened. We're going to get into what happened. We probably want to know what happened. But we don't have to come right back. We don't have to be literal and come back to just follow this. Like I said, we can break away now to something else that we go, what are we watching?
- 3.84** And all of a sudden, there's cops and SWAT teams. Now, is that the little girl? No. We see him return those kids, or maybe it is a little girl. Maybe we throw the thing, maybe it's only that family that we just invented. Maybe they've got one little girl. They break in, they get her. We see this girl. They're driving the SWAT teams. The detective, we'll make it a female detective. She's got her.
- 3.85** You see her go to this house. It's a really upscale place. And then the door opens, and the mother and father are there. But it's not this mother. They're returning their kid to a different family. So it's not the kid. It's a different kid. That's how we set that up. And maybe she deals with high-end families that have big ransom monies or whatever it is. But we're also showing who she is and what she does. So then we follow that.
- 3.86** And then probably the logical thing to do is the next day when she's going to work or like I said, I would like to put a little life in it. You see her, here's a woman who saves kids, but she's having an argument with her husband. Her kids are running around. She's trying to get them ready for school. And she gets the call, "You've got to get in here." "What?" "I'm not talking about it on the phone. Get in here now." "The guy's so rich. We can't have this in the papers. We can't do anything. The kid's gone. There hasn't been a ransom note yet. Blah, blah, blah." Here's the facts. This is what happened this morning.
- 3.87** Then we can cut to what happened. We could actually— as he's telling her—we can actually cut to when the kid got kidnapped. We could do it then. We could just do the kid being kidnapped first, and then she gets the call. We see that scene first. There's a couple of ways to do it.
- 3.88** There's many times I've done a script where I put something here, and then after reading it, reading it, and reading it dozens of times, I wake up in a cold sweat in the middle of the night and go, "Oh, no, I've got to move that scene. I've got to move it over here." Because if you get into it enough, it's on your consciousness day and night. I'm thinking about it while I'm driving. I'm thinking about when someone's having a conversation with me, I zone them out, and I'm not really listening because I'm thinking about, "Where should I go with this mother character? Is she the kidnapper?" It's constantly on my mind.

- 3.89** Now, again, what we did here is not the norm. You don't just start a script not where it's going or what it's doing. But this is a pretty good idea so far. Maybe I'll use this, or feel free to use it if you want to start with this, as long as you give me some credit and some money after you're done using it.
- 3.90** No, but my point is that just with nothing in our hands, we created something. So the blank page doesn't have to remain a blank page. Write anything, anything. And obviously—I'm going to keep repeating myself—it's not going to be anything because you already have, you're all here because you want to write a script. Is that correct? I think if you're watching this, there's something you want to write. So you're already at a place where you have an idea.
- 3.91** This scene could be at the middle of the movie. This scene could be at the end of the movie. We can return to the scene. We could start with the SWAT team scene. There's lots of ways to do it. But if you know your basic story, just start with anything. You can go back to it. As this gentleman here said, you can go back and rework the description. As the young man said, we can go back and say, "I need a little bit more about the characters to really have the reader feel who they're watching here." All of it is about rewriting.
- 3.92** I like to do it, like I said, I spit it all out. But as I'm writing, sometimes, I'm obsessed. I get maybe 15 to 20 pages, and I know I've got to continue. But I keep going back to the 15, 20 pages. I keep doing what we're doing now: go back, look at it again, change the word, change the sentence. So, I'm rewriting as I'm writing. Then I'll go to the next 20 pages. Then I'll get it out. Like I said, with me, I'll write nothing then. I'm thinking about it for a week. Then I wake up at 2:00 in the morning, I pound out a bunch of stuff until I pass out at 6:00. Then the next day, I come back and go, "Oh, that's pretty good." Or, "Oh, what did I write? This doesn't work at all." "Oh, but this little section works." You don't know. You don't know.
- 3.93** I write with emotion and feeling. I like to think that Green Book shows emotion and feeling coming across the screen and coming across the page when people read it. That's how I write. I write about people. But that's why I said, you could also be putting the people in outer space if you want, in the future, in the past, whatever, as long as it's about people and people's emotions.
- 3.94** I think what we did here today, creatively, is that we started out, everyone could connect to there's a missing kid, right? So that already triggers an emotion. Now, are we going to find that kid? What happened to the kid? Are we going to find it? How are we going to find it? These scenes are all building blocks towards that. You could do things that, "Oh, I've seen this in this movie." You can write out things that you've already seen, but then you can adapt them. You can change them to fit your story. Because, as we're going to get into, talk about all the stories that have been told before, you're not really stealing. You're just, through osmosis, what you've seen and

heard, maybe great movies, great books, great literature, you can put that into your script.

- 3.95** So any questions about what we did here, again, so far? And then I'll take any other questions that you may or may not have.
- 3.96** How would you write a montage? Let's say, for example, the next scene after the Starbucks is a search sequence. You're going through a montage of different sequences, scenes, the police searching the forest, whatever.
- 3.97** All right, so there we are. "Exterior, old house"—we'll go with what we talked about—"wooded area, early morning." I would bold that out. Montages are done in various ways, and again, sometimes I see them when I read other people's scripts. If it's a montage of a bunch of different scenes—really, this would be more of an action sequence, what I did here.
- 3.98** A montage could be like you and I walking into a bar and getting a drink. Then it cuts to you and I going to a ball game and having a couple of beers and the game's on. You and I go bowling. You see them bowling. Maybe it's like two guys bonding or a new friendship. You see them at the office, they're doing this. And you're putting them one after the other. So it's a sequence that, probably in that script, you're showing these guys are becoming really good friends, let's say. That's a montage.
- 3.99** In theory, you have to put the interior, exterior for every one of those. Sometimes people just write them out, "Hey, we see them in here, and we see them in there, we see them in there," but you have to really break them up because they're all different locations. So that's how you would technically, correctly write a montage.
- 3.100** In an action sequence, you don't have to have dialogue. You just write out what you're seeing. But again, I like breaking up the pieces of the action. In this case—it would take me too long to write it, so I'll just say it. In this case, if we wanted to this action sequence, "We see an older home in the middle of the woods with an empty dirt driveway. An old station wagon pulls up. An old man gets out with two kids—a young girl, looking much too young to be his daughter, possibly, but a young girl."
- 3.101** "She helps him take groceries; he tells her to pick up the bag. They walk into the house. We don't move. Pan over to the left. Officers with guns coming out of the woods. Cut to the reverse. More officers come." The lead officer is our female cop. We put her name down. These are different shots of movement, "Close on her: we're going in. Wide shot: they surround the house. Close on her: she's with a guy. They rammed the door in. Interior house. People are running—" You start describing all those different shots in your head of what's going on. That's all within the same sequence.
- 3.102** Montage, if we're connecting all these different things that are happening to this group of people, it really technically should have its own separate scene heading, slug line scene heading. Because when you break down the script, if you're saying we're going

bowling, they need to know the number, we have to film the bowling scene. What scene is that? Scene 28. Scene 29 could be at the ballpark. That's a different location. It's a different place. When are we shooting that? Because you're not shooting everything in order, even if it's in a montage. You don't shoot it all together, things like that. That's how you would attack that and address that.

- 3.103** All right. I think I mentioned this, but as we just developed this, you could take the obvious next scene. When we first started, we said, "Let's go to the police station." She goes in there looking for her child or reporting the child missing. That could be the storyline, too.
- 3.104** But I say, think out of the box as much as you possibly can, because even if you're confusing yourself, like that time, I told you, I think in one of the other ones we did, lectures, that I boxed myself in with this character, and I wanted the character to be in the whole movie. I killed her just like that, because then I said, "Now what do I do?" And it changed the whole trajectory of the script. Great character. But then I brought her back in flashbacks of how she got to that point. I brought her back later on, which opened it up again because you don't kill that person. This is like the lead person. But I did it on purpose because it was a small—it was an almost experimental film for me. So do some things that are out of the box.
- 3.105** If you have a full story that you've got to get points across, yes, you have to hit certain beats and certain elements have to happen. Where they have to happen, why they have to happen, when they have to happen, that can change.
- 3.106** Another thing you don't have to do because it's a movie, you don't have to explain what's happening. I wrote a script once called *Deadfall* with Christopher Coppola, who's Nicolas Cage's brother. We wrote this script about conmen, and the whole point of the movie was that we wanted to make a newer version of the movie, *The Sting*. Did you ever see *The Sting*? Everyone knows *The Sting*?
- 3.107** *The Sting*, Paul Newman, Robert Redford. Amazing movie. That was their follow-up to them being in a film together after *Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid*. Paul Newman, Robert Redford. The next movie that they did together was called *The Sting* about conmen. I loved that movie. So did Christopher Coppola. So we decided to write our version of a sting. The whole point of *The Sting* and our movie was to con the audience. We not only wanted conmen stings going on in the movie. We wanted to con the audience so that when they got to the end, they go, "What? What did we just watch?" Not see it coming, type of thing.
- 3.108** So we did that. The script got attention right away, and it was getting made. And there was a company that became Lions Gate, but before Lions Gate, I forget the name of it. And they all loved it. "We're going to do this, we're going to do that." But then you get into the same thing of, "Can you rewrite it? Can you cut it? We don't have enough money. This is the cast that wants to do it, but we can't pay them." But we still had a

great cast in it. It was a really good cast. It was Nicolas Cage, Michael Biehn at the time. He was in The Terminator and Aliens. Excellent actor. James Coburn, the older actor, James Coburn. Peter Fonda. A lot of great people in the movie.

- 3.109** So after we—Val Kilmer was going to do the movie with his wife. I'll just tell the story. And three days before we're going to start shooting, Val Kilmer comes up to me and says, "Nick, what's with the changes in the script?" I went, "What do you mean?" He goes, "Look at all the changes. All the yellow pages. They change different colors as you change them each time. All these new yellow pages." He said, "You didn't write this. You didn't make the changes." I said, "No." He goes, "Okay." He gives me a hug. "It's great working with you." He goes, "Anytime you want me to read something of yours, let me know."
- 3.110** Now, this was on a Friday. We were supposed to start shooting on Monday. I'm like, "What's he talking about?" I don't even know what he's talking about. But I didn't know about these changes. They just went and made a bunch of changes. So he left the movie. He said, "I'm not doing it." He took his wife. Joanne Whalley-Kilmer was going to do that movie with him. Took his wife. So now they had to recast quickly.
- 3.111** So now they're making the movie. And we're making it. Everyone loves the script. "Oh, the script, the script, the script." And then they make it. And then the people at that company came to Christopher Coppola and I and said, "You've got to write a voiceover or we'll do it. We'll have someone do it." "Why? There's no voiceover in the movie." "Well, people don't know what's going on. We tested it. People don't know what's happening." I went, "Yeah, it's a con men movie. They're not supposed to know what's happening. We don't want them to know what's happening. If you know what's happening, then there's no point. You don't get tricked at the end, and there's no con, and it's just a flat telling of this story."
- 3.112** "Well, we don't understand it. We don't really get it." "But you get it at the end. It's explained at the end." "Well, that's a long time for them to wait." "No, that's the whole point. The last scene is when you get the shock. The audience has been conned the whole movie into thinking one thing when something else is happening. That's the whole point of this particular script and movie. No one had a problem writing it. When you made it, there was no voiceover. Why do we need a voiceover?"
- 3.113** So what did they do? They ended up putting a voiceover in it. [Gives a thumbs-down] for that movie. That one you don't have to watch. But they're actually—Nick Cage is unbelievable in that movie. One of the weirdest Nick Cage—if you think Nick Cage did some weird performances, as great as he is, this one was maybe the weirdest. That might be, if you're really bored, take a look at it.
- 3.114** But Christopher Coppola did what he could with the movie. Our hands were tied. They kept cutting the budget, and they kept making these changes. And that's when you talk about when it gets out of your hands, that some things just go wrong. You had a script

that everyone was talking about, and everyone wants to be in it. We had all kinds of these actors. Then they couldn't pay the actors that really wanted to do it. They didn't want to pay them. They wanted to make it for less money. Then they started making all these changes to it.

3.115 So again, as I told you earlier, writing a script is a battle. It's a battle the whole way through. Why was I talking about this? Does anyone know why I even brought this up? I just want to show you how things change all the way down the line. And I think I said this, we were blessed with Green Book that we didn't have to make any changes like that.

3.116 So you mentioned that your family members were in the movie as well.

3.117 In Green Book, yes.

3.118 In Green Book. Do you think that acting, screenplay, basically that artistry is genetic, or is it more of a learned skill?

3.119 A little bit of both, I think, obviously, an actor— again, it's the same type of thing. You have to be, I think, well-read, well-learned. You watch a lot of movies. Theater, take acting classes. But some things—everyone thinks they're an actor. It's amazing how if and when I ever get a movie going, how many people say, "Just put me in it. Just put me in it." I'm like, "You never did anything." "Who cares? You've got Italians. I'm Italian. Just a little flick of a pen, with a flick of a pen, just write me in, with a flick of a pen."

3.120 Especially because, like The Sopranos, you think every Italian guy on the planet wants to be in The Sopranos. James Gandolfini was an enormously talented actor. The actors on that show were enormously talented. It looks easy. It looks like they're doing nothing because they're doing a lot of something.

3.121 That even goes for writing scripts. When you get a good one, it looks easy because it flows so well and it's so easy. But to get it there, as we've seen today, there's a lot of work put into it. But acting, writing, all of it, I think you should know a little bit about everything so that you know what everyone's job is, and then you could write towards that end. That's it.

Lecture 4: In the Beginning

At a glance — In the beginning — starting a screenplay.

- 4.1 Welcome again. Thanks for being here. A lot of information today, so I'm going to be doing a lot of reading because as I mentioned before, there's only one Jordan Peterson. It's really remarkable. How does he do what he does? The genius is beyond comprehension. So I'm going to go to my notes for the most part today.
- 4.2 All right, so we talked about beginning screenplays, how to start them, why you've got to just get into them, and writing in general. And today we're going to talk a little about the origins of writing. Where did it come from? Because you all are here because you want to write something, right? "How did we get here?" is the question. I'm calling this, "In the Beginning: The Screenplay's the Thing," and there'll be a reason I'm calling this lecture that. All right.
- 4.3 So some of the most ancient versions of stories are epic, long narrative poems. That's how it started. Some of the oldest ones that we have found are all about a hero on a difficult journey or quest. And the examples of that are the Iliad and the Odyssey by Homer and Dante's Divine Comedy.
- 4.4 Now, the Iliad, attributed to Homer, is an ancient Greek fable and tale written in a poetic style. It details battles, heroism, tragedy, glory, fate, mortality, war, honor, and the role of gods or God in human affairs. It's considered a foundational work of Western literature, and it ends with the funeral of the Trojan hero Hector.
- 4.5 Now, Homer's Odyssey is a sequel to the Iliad—which he wrote first— eighth century BC, Greek epic poem. It tells the story of Odysseus, the king of Ithaca, and his 10-year journey trying to get home after the decade-long Trojan War and the constant battles he faced while trying to return home to his faithful wife, Penelope, and his son.
- 4.6 Interesting that here's one of the oldest pieces of literature that we have, a story that started being told verbally before they started finding it written down. So a lot of oral tradition was how a lot of these stories were told at the beginning, by speaking them. And here we are, Christopher Nolan is doing a gigantic, massive, movie of this story, which comes out in July. So the story still resonates. It still has all the themes that you want to follow. And it's supposed to be a very big movie. So go see it because we need to go see movies in movie theaters.
- 4.7 Throughout his journey to get home, Odysseus faces multiple perils and battles with all kinds of mythical creatures—Lotus-Eaters, Cyclops, the witch, sea monsters. And all the way, he's losing all of his men, all of his soldiers in the process. During this time, during his 20-year absence— 10 years away, fighting the war for 10 years, trying to get home —people are invading his home. They're trying to take his wife and consume all his wealth. And with help, he finally returns. He disguises himself as a beggar. He tests his

household and ultimately wins a contest, slaughtering all the people that were trying to take everything from him. So the poem combines themes of vengeance, intelligence over brute force, and ultimately a homecoming.

- 4.8 Like I said, these poems survive through ancient Greek and oral traditions. The oldest known manuscript is from fragments dating to the third century BC in Egypt. Now, the impact of the Iliad and the Odyssey is, like I said, we're still going to tell it today. It's like a cornerstone of Western literature, and it's influenced so many other pieces of literature. It's so influential that Christopher Nolan is making this movie now.
- 4.9 Back to the 14th century. Dante Alighieri's *The Divine Comedy*, was written in the 14th century, and that's also a foundational epic poem, and it chronicles a journey into the afterlife: the Inferno, hell; Purgatory; Paradise, heaven. The Inferno is part one, which would be an act one; the Purgatory would be an act two; and the Paradise would be an act three. Again, the basis for most stories and most scripts: act one, act two, and act three. So he created this structure.
- 4.10 And his piece blends Christian theology, classical mythology, and contemporary politics, and explores sin, punishment, and the soul's path to God. So this is a human quest to reach out to—something's out there. Something divine is out there. We feel sin, we feel sinful. We feel the need to fix ourselves, to fix our soul. So these are all themes; you find both of these in Greek literature and in Dante's work. They're all considered poetry, which is its own genre.
- 4.11 And genre is a [French] word for a "kind" or a "type" or "sort." And so it allows you to set up a category or subcategories of different types of writings in this case. So the subcategories of this genre are: historical novels or romance novel or comedy short story, Classic epic or Medieval epic or Renaissance epic.
- 4.12 And so then we move from these poems that were telling these stories to the genre of the novel, which begins in the 18th century. There were some just starting in the 17th century, but the novel is basically an 18th-century invention, and it comes to the full fruition during the 19th and 20th centuries.
- 4.13 The drama genre, however, is a literary structure of a script which is acted out in front of an audience. And this makes it different from every other genre because everything else you're reading; you're one on one with the literature. But a drama is specifically written to be done in front of an audience. So in the ancient world, the distinction was made between two broad genres of drama, which are plays, two types. The two dramatic subgenres are tragedy and comedy, which I'm sure you're all familiar with.
- 4.14 Tragedy, there's always problems for the lead character. In many cases, a number of the most important characters in supporting roles, they will suffer, and in most cases, die. In comedy, there are problems, but they slowly get worked out. And major characters do not die in comedy. In tragedy, they always do.

- 4.15 So these are the two base storytelling structures of all writing: comedy, tragedy. The happy ending and the sad ending. "They lived happily ever after." "They died miserably." This is the origins of the sad mask and the happy mask that you see now on theatrical playbills, and it's also the symbol of the Screen Actors' Guild: the sad mask and the happy mask. That's where we get that from.
- 4.16 Now, going way back again to Aristotle, he deals with tragedy in a book of his—Poetics—and it's considered the most important work of literary criticism in the ancient world. And he talks about tragedy and comedies—his second book about the comedies, they haven't found it all— but he says those are the two frameworks for all writing.
- 4.17 Tragedy is an imitation of serious action, moving characters from event to event to event. And like all drama, it has a beginning, a middle, and an end. Again, a three-act structure, just like a script. There's a setup, followed by a development of the problem, followed by some climax, and a resolution. And this core structure of tragedy is always the same, though with some variations.
- 4.18 The character discovers a problem, the problem is linked to the character himself—sometimes in the form of a personal flaw, such as his own ignorance or arrogance or lack of self control—and when the character gains full knowledge of themselves and of the situation, this is the moment when they fall even more. Aristotle describes this in his poetics that this dramatic structure is repeated all the way through all classical tragedies to this day.
- 4.19 In other words, the basic structure is that we start without knowing. You have a character that doesn't know what he's doing; he doesn't know what he's doing wrong. When he comes into more fuller or complicated knowledge, it's a worse disaster. It's a reversal of fortune. Knowledge leads to suffering. Because, for example, Aristotle uses Oedipus Rex, the ultimate story because it combines two crucial elements perfectly at the climactic moment. Something else you should read: Oedipus Rex.
- 4.20 Oedipus goes from ignorance to full knowledge, which means not not knowing at the same moment. He experiences the reversal of fortune going from high to low. And when the reversal of fortune and the coming into full true knowledge happens to him at the same moment, that's when the plot of this play is perfect. He's saying that change comes with knowledge. And when you get knowledge, you get pain because you realize what you've done is wrong.
- 4.21 In comedy, it's a different structure. In a classical sense, comedy plots are a series of episodes of comedy problems that lead to a widening or more universalized coming into knowledge, but that's followed by a solution to the problems. A lot of the real big comedies, the character is always having a problem with this, a problem with that, and it's funny. And then he figures out how to do it, and you have a happy ending. So this goes on to films like one of the first romantic comedy films, It Happened One Night,

which is an old black and white film, down to Tom Hanks and Meg Ryan-type romantic comedies. They all follow the same type of plot lines and the same type of formulas.

- 4.22 So sometimes formulas are good because formulas work. So that's why you see so many repeats of these type of themes. So in the comedies, the male and the female characters meet, they can't stand each other, they learn to work together to solve different problems, then they work together to solve mutual problems, they begin to bond, and they fall in love, and the enemy becomes the lover.
- 4.23 This is ironically similar to what Aristotle calls a tragic reversal. Problems are solved instead of leading to knowledge and suffering. Comedy and tragedy are opposite. The ultimate plot of Oedipus Rex: he's a man who's been searching for the murderer of his father, and then ultimately finds out he is the guilty party he is looking for when he makes the terrible discovery that he had, in fact, killed his father and married—unknown to him—married his own mother.
- 4.24 This all comes into—I remember when I first read this in college, they had us read this. I didn't even know what I was reading. I was like, what? The idea of this whole thing—you're dragged into this storyline—and he's looking for this, and then you find out he married his mother, he murdered his father, the thing that he was searching for his whole life. This is a tragedy. So his gaining more knowledge caused the tragedy to be even worse in his mind. His ignorant love affair between this mother and the son ultimately destroys them both. And the end of a tragedy storyline always ends in a death of somebody.
- 4.25 The one thing that links both tragedy and comedy is the absolute dependence upon irony. The word "irony" comes from a Greek word again, which actually means "to deceive" or "to lie." It's like a situation where maybe you say, "I tell you I'm going to borrow \$20 from you on a Tuesday, and I'll pay you back on Thursday." But I have no intention of doing that at all. So there's a discrepancy between my words, what I'm saying, and what I'm actually going to do. In the end, you lose money because you don't see the discrepancy. So it's a reversal of expectation. You're expecting me to pay you back. I don't do it.
- 4.26 Now we have a problem. And that sets up other problems, and it just snowballs into problems. So this is a deception or another form of not knowing something. Because had you known that, you wouldn't have done it. When you know and you realize, "Hey, he just lied to me, straight out lied to me. I'm never getting my money back." Now that opens up the door to another piece of, "Where does this story go? What are you going to do about it? Is this guy going to try to get that money back? Forcibly? What happens?"
- 4.27 So knowledge leads itself to more problems because when you realize the truth, when you gain knowledge, you understand more and you understand deception, it's not good. It leaves you in a very bad place.

- 4.28 So there's also dramatic irony, when you're watching a movie sometimes, when the audience knows what's going on, but the character doesn't know it. You see this a lot in horror movies when people say, "Don't open that door!" We know what's behind the door. Our guy doesn't know, or girl, doesn't know what's behind the door.
- 4.29 And that's also a trick used with horror films with cameras, because—again, we talked about yesterday, and again, I have no idea which order these things are going to go in—but when we talked about how what you write in a script also can change based on how it's shot. So a lot of these reveals might be in the film, but you have to describe that in your script. But when the audience knows what's going to happen and the character doesn't, it changes the vibe of the whole scene. So scary movies use that to build tension all the time. Again, something that's done over and over again. Why? Because it works and people like that type of stuff.
- 4.30 There's also what's called situational irony, where there's some kind of reverse in a situation. Like a prisoner escapes, he takes a new identity, he comes back into the prison, becomes the warden, and takes his revenge out on all the people that treated him badly in the prison. It's a reversal. Irony also can be put into subdivisions, divided to other kinds of genres.
- 4.31 The ultimate irony known to the Greeks when they were writing was cosmic irony. "Cosmos" means "order" in ancient Greek. "Chaos" means "disorder." Cosmic irony is when you come to the realization that everything in human life and experience is in fact, ironic. Our life is a series of chapters in a plot where we experience continual reversals.
- 4.32 If you just look at your own life, all of our lives, things happen that you don't expect, things happen that you never planned, things happen that you didn't want to happen. How do you deal with that? So when you're structuring a script, all of these things—the reason I'm going so far into this—they've all been thought out. They've all been put on paper. These are themes that resonate forever.
- 4.33 We also talked a little bit about the human condition—everyone feels the same things; everyone has the same dreams. Whether they're different dreams, everyone dreams. Everyone wants to do good in life. Everyone wants to make money, have family, have kids, pretty much. You want a good life. Why are all these obstacles put in front of us?
- 4.34 Well, there's nothing more important in a script than to put obstacles in front of your main character. Obstacle after obstacle after obstacle. And what I'm talking about here is it doesn't matter if it's a drama or a comedy. Those obstacles are what's going to drive your story. And how does your character overcome these obstacles? This happens constantly in tragedy, more so. But like I said, even in comedies, obstacles in comedies are funny. In tragedies, it usually breaks down the human spirit. And those examples are in *Death of a Salesman*, and in the climactic moments at the end of Shakespeare's

Hamlet— one of the greatest plays of all time, where all the characters at the end on the stage, they're all dead or dying. That's how Hamlet ends.

- 4.35 Which brings us to Shakespeare, William Shakespeare. They say—the big "they," whoever they are—they say that every storyline in any book, play, or film is taken from Shakespeare. He covered every type of story, character, and human behavior that there is with all of his plays and sonnets. Everything ever written after Shakespeare owes its origins to his writings. William Shakespeare was born in 1564; he died in 1616. He wrote 39 plays, 154 sonnets, and several long narrative poems.
- 4.36 Now, his works encompass all the things we talked about: tragedy, comedy, history, romance. He captured the full range of human emotions: love, ambition, betrayal, guilt, redemption, and the quest for meaning. His writing stands out for its psychological depth, its poetic language, and universal themes that transcend time and culture, as we know. Shakespeare is still Shakespeare to this day. But like I said, everyone pulls from Shakespeare. So they say all storylines are in Shakespeare because his plays cover all these possible human storylines—political power in Macbeth and Julius Caesar; tragic love, Romeo and Juliet; jealousy, Othello; redemption, The Tempest; and existential doubt in Hamlet.
- 4.37 Now, the idea that he took the full spectrum of human emotions and put it in dramatic form comes from the fact that he took all of the old writings that I discussed earlier and put them into his writings. But what really influenced William Shakespeare? Where did he get the idea for all these human emotions and follies and the drama of life? The Bible. He took it all from the Bible. Its author, depending on what you believe: God.
- 4.38 The Bible is a book of 66 or 73 books, depending—one book with [66] or 73 books, depending on whether you're Protestant or Catholic. And those books were written by 40 different authors over the course of approximately 2,000 years. Now, can you imagine that? 40 different authors writing all those different books over 2,000 years, yet it reads together as one book and connects all the books seamlessly. Nowadays, you can't get 10 or 15 staff writers to write a 5-minute monologue for a late-night comedy show, right? But here we have 40 authors over 2,000 years putting together a book.
- 4.39 Now, I'm not a theologian, and I can't compete with Dr. Peterson's great videos on this website about theology and all of his lectures about it. But I think it's important to show the history of storytelling. Whatever you believe or don't believe, the Bible is part of that history. It's a book you should read, whether you believe or don't believe it, because it really is where all these stories come from—stories, themes, as we're talking about. So it's important to mention how the Bible, the best-selling book of all time, influenced William Shakespeare and everything he wrote, which ultimately influenced every writer since, whether they realize it or not. So just bear with me a moment.

- 4.40 The Bible starts with the Book of Genesis, the opening line. And you need great opening lines sometimes in movies. We're going to talk about that later—there's some great opening lines from films. The Bible opens with, "In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth." Pretty good opening line. Pulls you in a little bit. I think the greatest opening line ever. Now, "Once upon a time," tried to give it a run for its money. And "a long time ago in a galaxy far, far away" is pretty close, if you're a fan of stories like I am. But ultimately, "In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth" is number one. And it seems simple enough. It's a very simple sentence. Or is it that simple?
- 4.41 Let's quickly break down the depth of this one line. There's a Christian apologist, his name is Kent Hovind, and he was debating the existence of God with an atheist named Reinhold Schlieter. And they were debating about: the existence of God, how the universe was created, was there a big bang? If there was a big bang, what caused it? The big theological issues of the day that deserve to be discussed and debated and talked about.
- 4.42 So Reinhold [Schlieter] asked Hovind this question, and I'm going to read what they said. "I'm sure you can tell me where God came from. In addition, please try to clarify how you can figure that a spiritual force can have an impact on a material universe to create it." He's saying, how did God, the spiritual being, create something physical? How could that have happened?
- 4.43 So Kent Hovind responded this way. "Your question, where did God come from? Displays that you were thinking of the wrong God, because the God of the Bible is not affected by time, space, and matter. If he's affected by time, space, and matter, he's not God. Time, space, and matter is what we call a continuum." And this is based on Einstein's theory of general relativity that we know is a scientific fact. "Time, space, and matter are part of that continuum. All of them have to come into existence at the same instant. Because if there was matter but no space, where do you put it? If there was matter in space but no time, when would you put it? You cannot have time, space, or matter independently of each other. You have to have them come into existence simultaneously."
- 4.44 Now, let's look at this first line of the Bible. "In the beginning,"—there's time—"God created the heavens,"—the space—"and the earth,"—that's matter. In one sentence, before science, before Einstein, before anything. So there's a lot packed in the opening of that one line. So when you're writing—listen, sometimes we write fun stuff, anything, you're writing just for fun, you're writing a horror movie, a comedy— but everything you write means something. Words mean something. Words are powerful.
- 4.45 So this leads us to the opening line of the Gospel of John, written 1,500 years after Genesis. John starts his Gospel about Jesus with obvious reference to Genesis 1. And he says, "In the beginning was the word, and the word was with God, and the word was God. All things came into being through him, and apart from him, nothing came into

being that has come into being." Now, he's describing Jesus in this opening. He calls him the Word and says that the Word created everything. Well, God used words to create everything. He spoke things into existence. "And God said, 'Let there be light.' And God said, 'Let there be matter.' And God said, 'Let me form the earth.'" And God said, and God said, and God said. So John is explaining how the spoken word was used to create everything.

- 4.46** Words have power. Words have meaning. Words can last a thousand years. Words can topple governments—The Declaration of Independence, great example of that. "We hold these truths to be self-evident that all men are created equal. They are all endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable rights. That among these are life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness." Words are powerful and important.
- 4.47** Now, in *Green Book*, my father's character, my father, in real life, he wrote letters to my mother while he was away for so long, and Dr. Shirley helped him write these letters. So the words he used in those letters were important. Dr. Shirley helped him shape those words, change the words, instead of saying, "Yeah, hi, how are you doing? It was raining today. I had a meatball sandwich. Kiss the kids. Have a good day." Dr. Shirley helped him to take those words and write something nicer, and better, and it affected how he spoke to my mother.
- 4.48** So writing is important. And as I mentioned, you might write a light comedy, nothing deep. But how you shape your words in your screenplay is deeply, deeply important. Every word counts. When you edit a screenplay—I go through the screenplay, as I talked about this the other day, over and over and over again. I try to get it down to the comma or period. Every word means something. And it almost never changes—the editing of the script and the words you want to say and put up there, it happens when you write it, it happens if you get a reading.
- 4.49** I highly suggest always having a reading of your script. Get friends, actors— people want to read scripts. Hear it out loud. You're going to change it again then because when you hear people speaking your words, you're going to go, "Oh, that doesn't even sound real. A person doesn't talk that way." Or you may go, "Everyone sounds the same. I need to change how everyone sounds. I can't have everyone speaking the same way." So hearing the words being spoken into existence from your page—it's coming to life—you're going to change it.
- 4.50** Then when you actually cast it and you have the actual actors, they're going to want to change it. They're going to say, "Can I say it like this? Can I say it like that?" So all your words are precious. They're special. And then eventually, when you even make the film, which is down the road, you're going to edit it, or the editor is going to edit it. So some of your words are going to be gone and changed and moved around.
- 4.51** But your words are going to shape the script. That's step one of everything. That's why we're here. Like I said, we're here to really make movies, but you've got to get that

script as tight as it possibly can be, because the better you hone your script, the less chances that it will be changed.

- 4.52** So back to Shakespeare. His life in England at that time was steeped in scripture, it was all about the Bible. The Geneva Bible, which came out in 1560, approximately was the most widely read text of its era, and its language consumed Shakespeare. It's even been said, there's theories that Shakespeare actually worked on the English translation of the Geneva Bible. So he was involved in that. And that would explain a lot if it's true. I don't have enough information about it, but I've read several theories about that he was actually involved in that translation.
- 4.53** So his knowledge of the Bible, the deep understanding of it that he had, was obviously a big influence on all his work, and those are all well-documented. His characters mirror biblical figures: Macbeth, echoes Cain; King Lear, Job; Hamlet, Ecclesiastes, despair; Prospero, evokes a Godlike reconciler. The themes of sin and redemption, like the Bible; he explores fallen humanity's path towards grace in plays like Measure for Measure and The Winter's Tale. He uses biblical imagery and language: references to light, darkness, shepherds, prodigal sons, judgment, resurrection.
- 4.54** His worldview: he reflects a biblical moral universe where human choice has consequences and divine justice ultimately prevails and mercy redeems. So again, religious, not religious, these are also human conditions that all exist wherever you go, no matter what you do. This is what everyone faces. So as I said, every story ever told flows from the Bible through Shakespeare to modern film, to scripts.
- 4.55** The Bible's engagements with its questions of morality, suffering, free will, and human relationships are still evoked to this day. Dostoevsky, The Brothers Karamazov—I said that wrong, I'm bad with my pronunciation. That wrestles with faith, doubt, morality, very big on Bible themes.
- 4.56** So again, a couple more examples. Hamlet talks about sin, the afterlife, divine justice. It talks about justice and providence, how people's actions—why they have problems, the fall. Shakespeare's characters faced corruption and innocence and tragic consequences of ambition or lust. And so some direct Bible influences in Hamlet. He says, "There's a special providence in the fall of a sparrow," and that alludes to Matthew 10:29, "Are not two sparrows sold for a farthing? One of them shall not fall on the ground without your Father."
- 4.57** Merchant of Venice, Portia talks about "the quality of mercy is not strain'd," speech, and that draws heavily on biblical notions of divine mercy. King Lear reflects the biblical theme of divine justice and reversal of fortune. Richard II, the King, imagines himself as Christ-like, betrayed and suffering unjustly—again, reflecting biblical typology. Shakespeare's rhythms and metaphors and proverbial style often echo biblical cadences.

- 4.58 His audience also was steeped in the scripture of the time. So the way he wrote his prose, the way he wrote his dialogue was in direct connection to how people were speaking of that era, and they were all speaking and reading from the Bible, the Geneva Bible, how that was translated—they were following that. So the Bible shaped Shakespeare's language, his moral imagination, his themes of justice and redemption, and direct imagery. He didn't write religious plays. They weren't religious. But he took biblical themes and allusions, and he gave his plays layers of meaning that his audience would automatically recognize. But those themes are still in there. Whether you get them or you think they're biblical or not, he smoothed them in.
- 4.59 A lot of times there's messages in movies. Again, we talked about Green Book, and I'll get into Green Book more extensively, but we were aware of the human condition. We were aware of the political things that were going on at the time in the south in the early '60s and what they were both facing. One man went down facing a battle to prove that he was worthy of being anywhere. A man who was a genius and a musician of talent and had PhDs, couldn't use the bathroom in the same place that he played. My father's character, living in a small world in the Bronx, the Italian culture, tribal culture, raising family, making money. "I had to make the money," it's all he had on his mind. But by going out into this world, it opened his mind and his heart and his soul.
- 4.60 Again, knowledge. Knowledge changes behavior. So both of them had behavior changes because of their knowledge. But there are themes in there of redemption and overcoming your past sins. And you can be forgiven. You can change.
- 4.61 Now we get to his influence on screenwriting. Shakespeare is the great blueprint. His mastery of drama, character, complexity, and universal themes made his plays a template for modern screenwriting. We talked about structure, mostly three-act structure. Sometimes, like I said, people say there's four acts, there's five acts. It's basically a three-act structure, no matter how you look at it, whether act one is 30 pages, act two is 30 pages, act three is 30 pages. Act one could be 40 or 50 pages, act two could be 30 pages. Act three could be 10 pages. It could change.
- 4.62 But basically, we talked about: you get your character up in a tree, now he's stuck up the tree. How are we going to get him down from the tree? And then ultimately, you get them down. There's three sections to every script you write, pretty much. Subplots, subsections, yes. But the three-act structure is basically that, and that all comes from Shakespeare. He perfected that.
- 4.63 He gave us complex characters. Shakespearean protagonists are flawed. They're torn by ambition, doubt, love, vengeance. Exactly what a great film tries to do. You want to follow a character, a character that's going through something, right? Good or bad, mostly bad; you want to follow the characters that are bad. So Tony Soprano, Michael Corleone, and Walter White from Breaking Bad, they're direct descendants of Hamlet, Macbeth, and King Lear. They are tragic characters, and they follow those themes.

Whether you know it or not, those storylines, that's where they're coming from. And some are done purposely. There's some good writers out there that plan it.

4.64 You don't realize it, but that's what you're getting, the Tony Soprano character. Why do we love this guy? But yet he's a monster. But yet we still love him and follow him because a lot of his life you go, "Yeah, I can understand why he would do that." But what he's doing is wrong. And ultimately, no matter what you think, even though he's trying to work things out his way, it ends bad. Same with Michael Corleone and same with Walter White.

4.65 So these are recent characters that we follow, that we love. But ultimately, all of them are tragic characters because their sins come back to haunt them. You don't get away with that type of sinful nature, ever. Unless you get into repentance, and that's another storyline. Did any of them repent? Did any one of them ever feel really bad for what they were doing? They were drawn into it, but they did it. They didn't have guns to their heads. They made choices, and we all make choices as people.

4.66 And these are interesting thoughts when you're doing a character—like I said in one of the other ones that we did—sometimes do something different with your character. Change something completely. Throw them off into something that you didn't expect, because now you put them in another problem.

4.67 You got to get your characters into problems and out of problems. That's what keeps the script interesting. Why do we watch suspense movies? Because we don't know what's going to happen next. You don't know what's going to happen. Something good could happen, something bad could happen. Comedies too. You go, "Are these two going to get together? Or really, is it the third guy over there that she's going to fall in love with?" Because sometimes there's something else going on.

4.68 Keep your audience guessing, your readers guessing. And in a way, keep yourself guessing. Because sometimes you go into something and you're so, "I got this. I know what this is." And when you get in there, it changes. It changes when you start writing the dialogue. It changes when you start writing the scenes.

4.69 We were going over where this is going to be placed, we were going over a script. We created a script right here in the room, right? And we didn't know where it was going to go. I had no idea. I was asking questions. Everyone was giving some input, and we changed it. Then we were like, "Okay, it should do that." But then we all thought, "Oh, no, but what if it does this? What if it changes right here?" By page two, we were changing where we thought this story was going. So you have to be open to that as well when you're writing your scripts and your story lines. Of course, you got to go in having something planned and in some things you've got to follow the formula.

4.70 But the point of all this is that Shakespeare, because of his influence from the Bible, affects screenplays to this day. He bent genres. He mixed comedy, tragedy, and supernatural elements. And modern films do the same thing. Like Tarantino, his dark

humor. Marvel movies, even with comedy and tragedy and supernatural forces, gods, and people from other planets. There's adaptations of Shakespeare—West Side Story is basically Romeo and Juliet. I think there's a film called Ran, which is King Lear. 10 Things I Hate About You, it's like Taming of the Shrew.

4.71 So we regurgitate all this material over and over and over, and a lot of people don't know it, but I wanted to give you a background because these are things that you could read yourself or just look up and get information about because it could affect your writing. You may go, "Oh, I want this character to be like Lady Macbeth." And if you study that and you know who Lady Macbeth is, you're not going to copy Lady Macbeth, but you're going to have the vibe of Lady Macbeth: a treacherous woman that's out for power.

4.72 So his structure of stories. He came up with stories of deliverance, Exodus; redemption, the Prodigal Son—apocalypse, a big ending, grand cinematic storytelling—The Ten Commandments, Ben Hur, The Matrix. The Matrix echoes Christ-like sacrifice. If you follow the storyline of The Matrix, it's a very Christ-like story, the lead character. When you start watching all three of them, it's all based on biblical stories. Or you just watch it as a great sci-fi action movie, which is a fantastic trilogy that they had. But where did they get that trilogy?

4.73 Neo is the chosen one. Neo is the savior. Luke Skywalker, the chosen one—or is Darth Vader, the chosen one? One of them is the chosen one. Because sometimes they get the chosen one wrong, who they think it is. But these are themes, again, out of the Bible. In the Godfather, Fredo, what does he do? He's Judas: he betrays his brother. In the Godfather—betrays him. Comes from nowhere, the most beloved brother. And then in Godfather 2, what does Michael Corleone do? He kills his brother: Cain and Abel. So all of these themes, like I said, come from the Bible, they come from Shakespeare, and they're constantly used over and over again.

4.74 Some screenwriting techniques that Shakespeare passed down: monologues, voiceovers and soliloquies—like Taxi Driver and Apocalypse Now—montage, opening narrative—Lawrence of Arabia is a good version of that. Goodfellas, even a mob movie has these type of themes. So from the Bible and Shakespeare, screenwriters inherited moral weight, mythic archetypes, and epic scope. And from Shakespeare, they inherited dramatic structure, character psychology, and human universality. And together—the Bible, Shakespeare—they shaped the DNA of Hollywood storytelling and screenplay writing.

4.75 So now I would like to know if anyone has any questions.

4.76 I'm curious for you, as a screenwriter and a storyteller, if any of the themes from the Bible were particularly ones that you were drawn to as well.

4.77 I'm very drawn to it. I like studying theology, and as I grow older even more and more. But I found myself, too, sometimes—it's just like I was telling you—you learn things

through osmosis, and you don't even know you're using it. I enjoy—and we're going to talk about some films that I love and want to have you guys watch—I like making people feel good.

4.78 I want, now more than even before, I want to write something that has a happy ending. I want something that shows a moral victory, deliverance, redemption-type of thing. Like in *Green Book*, that feeling that you had at the end of *Green Book*, if you saw it; another film I'll talk about, *It's a Wonderful Life*, that feeling you have there. *Cinema Paradiso* is another example of that.

4.79 But in my day, I've written mob stories; guys are getting killed and whacked all over the place. I've written a horror movie. I've written action movies. But through all of them, these themes, whether I realized I was doing it or not, seep in. Who's the good guy? Who's the bad guy? What moral judgment is falling upon these people? Do they get what they deserve in the end?

4.80 I think if you're going to show corruption, you're going to show the mob world. Let's just use that for an example. I'm a fan of all those shows. I love that genre, but I don't agree with the characters in them. They're doing terrible, terrible things. But that makes it interesting, too, because I grew up in a culture of all Italians. My father, as we saw in the movie, ran the *Copa*. Our neighborhoods were run by mob guys. They didn't care who the mayor was, who the governor was. They were running it.

4.81 Now, they're running it with a good intention. Everyone was safe. There was never any crime. No one's coming into the neighborhood to do any crime. But they also were doing what they do. We don't want to know what they're really doing. We just want to know the good stuff. When you meet these guys, and I had family members like that, friends. And guys, when I was little, I just thought, "Oh, that's great. My uncle, he's a nice guy." And then you find out, well, he runs this, he does that. And that goes to a lot of people that you meet. Because life is complex. People make choices.

4.82 So that's what's interesting is that I'll meet guys now that knew my father and did different things. I don't judge them in the sense of: God's going to judge them. But when you meet them one on one, you think, "Oh, that's a great guy." But then you hear, "Oh, they did X, Y, and Z." So it makes for interesting characters in a movie, in a story, because partly you pull for them, partly you like them, partly you love them, and then partly you go, "How could they be so—?" Because when the switch goes on, and they have to do something, they do it without thinking. How does a human being do that? How does someone kill somebody because someone else stole something from them? This happens all the time. What's going on in the heart and the mind and the soul to have a person do that? Well, that makes for an interesting character.

4.83 So to get back to your question—I think I went off a little bit. Yes, the themes in the past of movies and scripts that I wrote, I liked to put these type of themes in there, consciously or unconsciously. But now what I'm doing moving forward is trying to

consciously put those type of themes in there and discover and go through that type of human condition.

4.84 I'm curious about, for instance, the Green Book was a real-life story that just happens to fit into these thematic archetypes. [Yes.] I can see it would be easier to do that if you were creatively creating a story, creating a character, versus applying the principles to real life. When you sit down with the blank sheet, does that go through your mind as you're processing that it's going to either fit into this or it's not? Could you then, as a creative, morph the character towards one of these things versus in your real-life application of your dad's story, let it flow, and it just happens to fall into that genre archetype?

4.85 Okay, we're going to do one lecture strictly about Green Book, but I want to answer that question here first. Because that was a true story, and I had the story my whole life, and I always knew, I have to tell this story. I already knew that it had all those themes. In this case, it had everything in it. It was a softball pitch to hit it out because it had the beginning, middle, and end. It had two great characters. It had the odd couple.

4.86 And it had these themes of redemption, of change, of how you can learn and change and grow. And people aren't the same, and you shouldn't put someone down for something they did in the past. We all have done things in the past. We all change and grow. I was talking about how knowledge in the tragedies, the more you know, the more you realize a lot of things and things go bad. But knowledge also opens up your mind and your heart and your soul to being a better person.

4.87 In the case of Green Book, when I pitched the idea to Brian Currie, for example, it blew his mind. He saw what the movie was. He saw how these themes—we didn't have to state it; we didn't have to say, "Oh, look, this is this type of character," because it was just there. And when he pitched it to Pete in his way, and then Pete wanted me to pitch it to him; Peter Farrelly, he knew what he had. We all knew what we had. So it was built into that because it was a true story.

4.88 Now, if you're going to sit down and write a story—I got to wonder, what was in Shakespeare's mind when he said, "I'm going to write Hamlet," and the whole theme of Hamlet and what it is, it's about life and "to be or not to be" and killing yourself or not killing yourself. And what does it all mean? He obviously designed this to be a specific way. So it all depends on what you're trying to write, what you want to write.

4.89 There's not really a solid answer to your question in the sense that: yes, Green Book, I had the basic story and outline, but you knew that it touched upon all this stuff. You're writing something from scratch. You have to discuss with yourself: Why am I writing this? What am I trying to say?

4.90 And again, sometimes they don't want to say anything. They just want to write a fun comedy. You want to write a great action piece. You've got an idea in your head about these bank robbers that we think they're these evil guys, bank robbers, but then you

find out they're robbing a bank to get money to give to the orphanage, like The Blues Brothers, right? So it all depends. Everything is different. Everything changes. That's why even with all the same themes that we're saying, this is the same themes over and over again, but we still have new fresh product.

- 4.91** Everyone here, if we were doing this over the course of a year, and I gave you an assignment, and I gave you all the same—without telling each other—I'll give you the same storyline. I want you to write something about these bank robbers. We think they're bad people, but they're doing it to save an orphanage. And I tell you all of that. There's how many people here? Every script will be different. Every story will be different. Who's using a male protagonist? Who's using two men? Who's using two women? Who's using a male and a female? The whole story would be different from everyone. But the themes of it, the heart and soul of it would be the same.
- 4.92** But what are you going to come up with? What are you going to do with your own story? Like I said, once you face the page, even though you've mapped a lot of things out, it's not on the index cards, it's not in your treatment, it's going to be what's on that script. So that's going to change.
- 4.93** But can you plan it out? Certainly. I think that it's mind-bending to a point. I think you can have an overall vision of what you want to do, what themes you want to put in. And I have done that, too, because I've written some crime movies where you want to take someone on a journey from point A to point B to C, D, E, F, G, until you bring them around to something else. And hopefully there's redemption at the end of a crime story. That's what I think. But someone else may just go, "No, let's just kill everybody and make this a badass action film and not think of themes," right?
- 4.94** So it's different every time, is the answer, and it could go either way. In Green Book, we were given a gift of the story. And like I mentioned earlier, I'll probably say it again, we had tapes of my father telling the story, I had my mother telling me the story. I had the letters from the story, I had Don Shirley telling me the story. So all of that together lent itself to what it was. And now it was our job to execute it, which I think we did pretty good.
- 4.95** Sometimes, you can take the overall theme of redemption and just have someone go through all of the obstacles and redeem themselves. But what happens if you take a character that is not redeemable? There are parts of our stories in which, well, this character is just not there, and it's not a tragedy. You know what I mean? It's like, what do you do with characters like that?
- 4.96** How do you weigh—the second part of that question is: How do you weigh their personal—you know how sometimes the story is about obstacle, obstacle, obstacle, obstacle, but then there's a major thing happening? Like, every case in a detective-type of thing is like you resolve the case, but you have an enemy that is out there. And then

how do you get those other things mixed in the regular day-to-day story? Does that make sense?

- 4.97** Yes, it makes sense. Well, that's the problem you face, right? And you mentioned that maybe you have a character that's not redeemable, and that can be very true. But the idea is everyone is redeemable. So if you have a character that never gets redeemed in your film, he's just evil straight through all the way through. Even that character has a backstory. Why are they evil all the way through? What happened to them?
- 4.98** What really pushed them so far that there is no coming back? There is no redemption. There is no, "Well, I hate God because"—he may have, "There is no God. So if there is no God, I can do whatever I want. This happened to me. I'm going to do what I want. What's the difference? We all die," if that's your character. So you can write that character. And there are people in the world like that. When you hear about dictators and the real evil people, the Stalins and the Mao Zedongs of the world over the course of history, you wonder why. Where did they get that mentality? What drove them there? But even that, it should be in your story because we've got to see what takes a person that far.
- 4.99** Ultimately, as I said, I think everyone is redeemable, the Bible talks about that. And the thief on the cross, one of them said, "Hey, if you're who you say you are, get me off." The other one said, "No, leave him alone. He's innocent. I know who he is. Just Jesus, please remember me in paradise." And Jesus says, "Today, you will be with me in paradise." Because he had faith and he believed. Now, he didn't go to church, he didn't give to charity, he didn't take communion, he didn't do anything at all. But there was still hope for him when he came to the realization of who he was. He was a sinner, and Jesus was his redeemer. So again, whatever you believe or don't believe, those themes exist everywhere. Everyone can be redeemed.
- 4.100** So if you have a character that can't be redeemed, why? Then I'd want to know why. I'd want your script to tell me: Why can't he be redeemed? And then ultimately, do we feel bad for him? They go, "wait, that happened to him? Yeah, maybe I'd go crazy like that, too, if that happened to me." But why can't he be redeemed? Does he want to be redeemed? Does he just say he can't be redeemed? Does he just hate everything and everyone purely? I don't know how that would work. That would be up to you to put that out there.
- 4.101** So an unredeemable character is a valid character, but how did he get there? And why is he so unredeemable? That would be what you have to do to make us follow that person, right? And tell that story, whatever it may be.
- 4.102** A character like the Joker in *The Dark Knight* is an unredeemable character, but we don't see a consistent backstory, and at the end, he's just defeated. How do you think about a character where we don't actually know why—besides wanting chaos—so he doesn't actually have a consistent backstory. So we don't know why, but he just wants

to obliterate the world, and we just see his downfall at the end. How would you write something that, or do you think that that's a compelling character?

- 4.103** Well, I think it's a great compelling character, and it goes back to what we were just talking about. How did the Joker get to be the Joker? I think in the Christopher Nolan films, the actor, Heath Ledger, who played the Joker, passed away, and I think they didn't want to replace him; I think they were going to explore that a little bit more with his backstory. And as we've seen now, they made Joaquin Phoenix the Joker. They explore a backstory of a guy who was put down, beaten, beaten up a lot, treated badly.
- 4.104** Now, to get to the point that you want to destroy the city and everyone in it. Again, Batman, mythical character. Batman is there to save the people, but he's the Dark Knight; he's got issues himself, which makes for a great character. But the villains that he faces, who are they? So the Joker, like you said, if it's not explored, you go, "Well, why is he doing this?" But they're now recently starting to do backstories. I think in a lot of the comic books, they give them backstories. It just depends on which version you're watching, and maybe you don't get the backstory.
- 4.105** But I agree with you. You need a backstory. You need to know why. Otherwise, it's just flat. We know there's a good guy and a bad guy, and the bad guy is the bad guy. But I think it's more interesting—the bad guys are more interesting than the good guys, usually, because how did they become bad guys and why?
- 4.106** To address what you're saying, I'd want to see that. I'd want to see more of the Joker's backstory. I believe—I read something somewhere—they were going to explore that, but unfortunately, he passed away, so [Nolan] didn't want to replace him with another actor, and they changed a little bit of the trilogy. I could be wrong about that, but I read something about that.
- 4.107** But yeah, the villainous characters, the evil characters, those are the ones you want to really explore and learn more about. So if you're writing something like that, or the young lady is, that's your job. Let's hear about it. Let's know the whys, because I think that makes for a more interesting story all the way around. All right, well, I think we got—somehow I got through that, I'm not sure. Great questions, and we will pick this up in the next hour.

Lecture 5: What Should We Watch?

At a glance — What should we watch? — study and taste.

- 5.1 Okay, welcome back. Again, forgive me for reading. I'm going to do more reading. I wrote my notes. I wish I had them all in here. But today we're going to talk about favorite movies, because like I said, no one wants to write a script. You really want to write a movie, you want to get it made. So everyone has their favorite movies. I'm going to name a bunch right now, because when I was compiling this, I could have named hundreds. I'm probably leaving out amazing ones that, after I film this, I'm going to go, "Wait, how did I not mention that? How did I not mention that?"
- 5.2 These are in no particular order of the favorite scripts and films that I think you got to see. You got to see every one that I mentioned and more. And you'll probably give me a list of ones. So in no order, on the waterfront, Mary Poppins, which is the first movie I ever saw, Mary Poppins in a movie theater. My mother took me 5 days in a row. I was done. I love Mary Poppins. I wanted to be Dick Van Dyke.
- 5.3 The Bicycle Thieves, Vittorio De Sica, an Italian film. Cinema Paradiso, another Italian film with an amazing ending, much like It's a Wonderful Life and how we structured the Green Book ending to be. The Cinema Paradiso, It's a Wonderful Life type of feeling at the end is what we were going for. Cinema Paradiso, beautiful film. Braveheart, Passion of the Christ.
- 5.4 Midnight Run. I don't know if you've ever seen Midnight Run. It changed the genre of buddy films. My good friend George Gallo—honored to be his friend, and we're writing together now— he wrote Midnight Run, and it was Robert De Niro's first time ever doing comedy. He had never done anything comedy. It was Robert De Niro and an actor named Charles Grodin, who was an amazing actor and had an early success in the '70s, and then he hadn't done anything for a while. So they thought, who's going to see this movie? Robert De Niro doesn't do comedies. Charles Grodin hasn't done anything in a while. Yet, obviously, they stole the movie. It's an amazing script, action, comedy together, the themes in it. George Gallo really changed the way buddy comedies and action films were made after that.
- 5.5 All of a sudden, all the action movies that were serious action movies wanted to be funny and become comedies. George also ended up writing Bad Boys. So amazing writer. But Midnight Run took screenplay writing for action films into a different direction. So it's an important film to see. George wrote and directed another movie called [Trapped] in Paradise, a Christmas movie, again, bringing up an It's a Wonderful Life type of vibe. That's with Nicolas Cage, really funny movie. Family Man, another Nicolas Cage movie. Excellent movie.
- 5.6 Bronx Tale, written by my friend Chazz Palminteri. Again, a true story about him and his father. And again, these true stories lend themselves to sometimes great movies. I

mean, *A Bronx Tale* was Chazz's story of his life, and he turned it into a one-man play, which he still does to this day. If you ever see it advertised, he goes around the country. It's amazing. He stands there by himself with a chair, and you are riveted as if you're watching a film for two hours. He's just an amazing actor.

- 5.7** But what he did with the original play is what Robert De Niro saw, and then made a deal with him right there backstage. "We're doing this movie, I'll direct it. I'll play the guy". And then Chazz wanted to play his character, and Chazz fought, much like Sylvester Stallone did to be in the movie, turned down lots of money, and finally got it. An amazing, amazing movie, *Bronx Tale*.
- 5.8** *The French Connection*, a William Friedkin classic. I don't have *The Exorcist* up here, but another William Friedkin classic, all Friedkin's films with *The French Connection*, especially. And for screenplay writers, *The French Connection*, there's a sequence in *French Connection*. That movie is so good where nobody says anything. Is that proper language? Nobody says anything for 20 minutes. But yet you're riveted in the movie. They're following someone.
- 5.9** So how do you write that in a script? How do you keep that relevant in the script? Or is it written like I talked about *Lawrence of Arabia*? *Lawrence of Arabia*, the rebels attacked the Arabs or something like that. One sentence, a 20-minute battle sequence. In this case, in *The French Connection*, they're following a guy for 20 minutes, and there's barely any dialogue, if any at all. So again, the filmmaking connected to your script, but it had to be in there to begin with. So how do you write that? That's why it's a great film to watch. Online, you can get a hold of these classic scripts, and you should read as many as you can get your hands on.
- 5.10** *French Connection*, *Serpico*, Sidney Lumet movie with Al Pacino, *Dog Day Afternoon*, another Sidney Lumet movie with Al Pacino. Now, Sidney Lumet has a long history. I have another Sidney Lumet film in here, *12 Angry Men*. Amazing, amazing films. Amazing films. I can't even name them all. Watch as many Sidney Lumet films as you can. He has a great book. I should have brought it in the other day about filmmaking. I think it's called *[Making] Movies*. An amazing director, probably doesn't get enough credit.
- 5.11** I'll tell you a quick story about Sidney Lumet. I should have saved this for later, but I'm going to tell it now. Sidney Lumet was doing a film based on a Vincent Patrick book called *Family Business*. Vincent Patrick had written *The Pope of Greenwich Village*, which I'll tell you about later. I was in that movie, too.
- 5.12** Now he's doing *Family Business*. It was supposed to be about Italians, a grandfather, a son, and a grandson who get together to pull off this heist. The Italian family was played by—the grandfather was Sean Connery. His son was Dustin Hoffman, and his son was Matthew Broderick. All great actors, and actually a really fascinating movie.

Again, a lot of spoilers here. You've got to watch these movies. If you haven't seen it, you don't want to hear the rest of the story, stop, turn the movie on, and come back.

- 5.13** In that movie, at the end of the movie, Sean Connery is in a courtroom. He's getting sentenced by a judge who's always hated him, and he's found guilty, and he gives him basically 20, 30 years in prison, but he's an old man. It's basically a death sentence, what he gives him.
- 5.14** I got cast in a small little role. I was the guard in the courtroom. I'm the courtroom guard in the back. I thought I was just going to stand in the back. But no. When he gets arrested, I have to go cuff him, and I have to walk him off. Easy enough. I'm going to cuff him and walk him off.
- 5.15** So Sidney Lumet comes up to me and goes, "Listen, we're going to do a certain type of shot here. " You go, when you cuff him, you're going to do it over here. You're going to pull his arm over. I need his arm in a certain spot. I'm going to do a close-up. You're going to see the cuff going on his wrist with Dustin Hoffman's face right behind it. And I'm going to get Dustin Hoffman's reaction to seeing his father being taken away."
- 5.16** I thought, okay, so here's the setup. The camera is showing me. They had to stand in there for Dustin Hoffman at this point. Do it here. They had to stand in for Sean Connery. Let's try it. I cuffed this stand-in. I brought him over as I'm doing it over here. The actor was there. Okay, great. Do it. Now they bring in Dustin Hoffman, Sean Connery. We go to do it. They told Sean Connery what was going to happen. I come down, the judge says, "Guilty, blah, blah, blah, take him away."
- 5.17** I walk down. I go to get Sean Connery's hand. He does it like this [pulling his hand away in resistance]. "Cut, cut, cut." "You're going to have to try a little harder than that, son," Sean Connery says to me. I'm like, "Oh, okay." He's not giving me his wrist. So I said, "Well, they want me to put—" He goes, "That's your problem." So Sidney Lumet goes, "You got it, Nick?" I go, "Okay. All right." Action comes down, Sean Connery. Boom, boom, boom.
- 5.18** I take the cuffs out, and I should say, I have the handcuffs on one of my hands because I have to walk him away handcuffed. So I have the cuffs on one side of me. So now I grab his arm, I yank it over, and I go like this [demonstrates the cuff won't close]. Because his wrist was like this. I couldn't get the cuff— I couldn't get it on his wrist. "Cut." "Nick, what's the problem?" I go, "No, he's got a big wrist." I couldn't get it on his wrist. So they go, "Well, try it. Try it." So I said, "Mr. Connery, do you mind?" He gives me his wrist. And there was one section of his wrist that, if I put it in the perfect spot, I got one click, and it was on. So Sidney Lumet goes, "Okay, you got it? See? It fits." I go, "Yeah, but it's—" "Ready? Let's go. Action." I go over here. I'm trying, turning [demonstrates the cuff won't close]. "Cut."
- 5.19** Dustin Hoffman is laughing. Sean Connery is like, "You've got to do it. You have to get it done." I can't do his accent that well. So Lumet calls me over. He goes, "Listen, you've

got to get this right." Now, all of a sudden, it's all on me. I'm an extra. I thought it was just going to be standing in the back doing nothing. Dustin has been getting there. "It's actually okay because I don't see it in his face," he goes. "But at any moment, at any take, he could have the emotion that I need. And he—we may only have it for one take, and then we're going to lose it. I can't lose that moment. You've got to do it, right?"

5.20 So I go, "Okay." Next one comes. "Action." I grab his arm, I pull him over, I turn it, I twist and click, and I hold for a minute. And then Dustin Hoffman—when you see it in the movie, you see—his look and his face and Lumet, he was like, "Pull his wrist out and go." Pull it out, go. "Cut." Amazing, amazing, amazing, amazing.

5.21 I'm like, "Oh, my God." I couldn't believe it. So now I'm walking. So Sean Connery, I'm like this with Sean Connery [shows they are handcuffed together]. He just starts walking around. He's talking to Sidney Lumet. And Sean Connery goes, "Take the cuff off." So I go, "What?" He goes, "Take the cuff off." I said, "I don't have the key. The prop guy wouldn't give me the key. I asked him for the key." "What do you mean you don't have the key?" "I don't have the key. I can't take it off." "Where's the prop guy?" He calls the first AD. "Where is he?" And he goes, "He's—"

5.22 Now, we were in New York City. Those are the days you shot in real locations, upstairs in a real courtroom. He's down on the street somewhere in the prop truck. He's getting something. So now Sean Connery is out of his mind. He's walking around, he's screaming at everybody, and I'm like this, following him around, following him around. I see him fuming. And at one point, he is just standing, and he goes, "I can't believe what's going on." I said, "Mr. Connery, just do me a favor. Now would not be a good time to go to the restroom." Made him laugh, broke it up a little bit.

5.23 And then the guy came tearing down the hall. I mean, he was sweating with the key, and Sean Connery took the key, and he said, "He holds the key, not you. I don't want to see you again." Then I had the key because we had to do— Then I dragged him across. We did a couple of other scenes, but that's my Sidney Lumet Family Business story.

5.24 So where was I? Sidney Lumet, watch that movie. You'll see me do that. French Connection, Serpico, Dog Day Afternoon, Green Book, one of my favorite movies, Schindler's List, The Magnificent Seven, and The Seven Samurai, that The Magnificent Seven was based upon. I love those movies. Unforgiven, Clint Eastwood Western, 12 Angry Men, as I mentioned, Sidney Lumet, The Star Wars trilogy, the original first three one that they did. Face/Off, the classic John Woo film. Amazing. Gladiator, Alien, Aliens, Casablanca, you have to see. If you're writing screenplays, you've got to see Casablanca. All these movies, really. Back to the Future, Psycho, City Lights with Charlie Chaplin, Apocalypse Now, The Conversation, The Shining, Dr. Strangelove, 2001.

5.25 I'm probably saying movies that you would all know, but sometimes people—you don't remember the movies. When I was writing this up, I didn't remember. I'm trying to think of all movies that affected my life and wanting to get in the business. 2001, Butch

Cassidy and the Sundance Kid, which William Goldman wrote that we talked about. The Sting, The Hustler with Paul Newman. Amazing, amazing film. Amadeus, another beautiful, amazing film. Sunset Boulevard with William Holden. Lawrence of Arabia. There's a bunch of Frank Sinatra movies I like. Everyone talks about Ocean's 11, which of course, is great. But there's a movie, Robin and the 7 Hoods, which is a fantastic musical. The classic musical, Singin' in the Rain, then Grease, Saturday Night Fever, and many, many more, and four that we're going to talk about coming up right now.

- 5.26** So if you haven't seen those movies, see them, look up, if you could find the scripts on them, do that as well. And now we're going to talk about four of the big ones that I think need to be discussed. And I'm not mentioning a lot of newer films because my background is the classic films. I think you have to have a background in classic film, classic scripts, because there's a reason these movies still resonate today and still, like we talked about, the reasons that biblical stories, Shakespeare stories, Greek tragedies all still resonate. But these films formed what we have now, and they set a standard for filmmaking that I think we all should try to emulate and follow.
- 5.27** The first one we're going to talk about is Citizen Kane, a 1941 film. "Rosebud"—an opening line, one of the greatest opening lines in screenplay and film history. Now, Citizen Kane is regarded as one of the most influential films ever made. It changed the way screenplays and films were structured. It had never been done like this before. It was written by Herman Mankiewicz, who we talked about the other day, and Orson Welles, mostly Mankiewicz, though, but with Orson Welles overseeing the whole thing. And it didn't follow the traditional linear storyline, act one, act two, and act three. It broke that barrier.
- 5.28** It begins with the death of—again, if you haven't seen the movie, turn this off, go watch the movie, because I'm going to give a lot of spoilers. It starts with the death of its lead character. It opens with it. And then it goes into multiple fractures, multiple recollections of different people that tell the story of the man. And they all have different, various stories about this guy.
- 5.29** It's about a reporter going around asking questions about him. And each person he interviews gives him a different side of this man. It's very complex. It's not in a linear fashion timeline. You could see him old, you could see him young. It's not told boyhood on. So you don't know what to believe because some people are saying one thing, some people are saying another thing. And that's another thing that was a new unprecedented approach in film during that time.
- 5.30** Rather than asking what happens next, the screenplay asks who Kane truly was. It unfolds as an investigation, not into a crime, but into a soul, into who is this man on the inside. And the reporter's quest for the meaning of Kane's final word, "Rosebud." Why did he say "Rosebud"? And that's what keeps the audience, the whole movie, why his last word was "Rosebud." That's the spine of the story. That's the heart of the story. And ultimately, you get that answer at the very, very end. But even then, it doesn't

answer all the questions. It just tells why he said it. But it does harken back to the innocence of his youth. And that's why he said those words.

- 5.31 It's not about wealth or power. It's about loss. It's about his life, his life's ambition, and his downfall by his own ambition, that he rose to such a high power, but that's ultimately that same rise is what takes him down. Each flashback that they show of him reveals how his pursuit of control pushes people away, and he's surrounded by all these possessions, but he doesn't have any intimacy or any real relationship with any human beings anymore. He's destroyed marriages, relationships, friendships, all in this pursuit of gain.
- 5.32 It was modeled after William Randolph Hearst, which became a very big thing because Hearst realized that that's what he was doing. The influence of the film itself, you can't put a price tag on it. It introduced, like I said, nonlinear storytelling and editing to mainstream American cinema. And it demonstrated that structure could be manipulated and changed, and the viewer will still want to watch it. So modern films and television series that rely on fractured timelines, like Memento, does this, Pulp Fiction. They owe a lot to the screenplay and film of Citizen Kane.
- 5.33 Its cinematic style, like I said, they talk about the cinematography, and the filmmaking aspect of itself, we could do a whole lecture on that. All the things that Orson Welles did to change how you film the movie. In movies up to that point, you rarely, if ever, or maybe never, saw a ceiling in a shot because most movies were not shot on real locations. They were shot in studios. So you have your wall; they didn't build ceilings. Ceilings were for the lights, which is like we have here. But he did things. He wanted ceilings because he wanted shots. They had to dig a hole in the studio floor so that he could put the camera low enough to do a shot. He wanted a shot looking up at this man coming forward. You needed to see everything.
- 5.34 He changed how you shoot films. He did design camera movements. He designed how the camera can be moved. Most of the time, it was just steady. Eventually, a Steadicam was developed on Rocky, but he was changing even what to do with cameras and lenses to distort and to make you feel something.
- 5.35 Before Citizen Kane, American screenplays largely followed a predictable grammar. The stories moved forward in time. The protagonist wanted something concrete. Obstacles arose, and resolutions were clarified at the end. But Citizen Kane did the unthinkable. It kills his protagonist in the opening moments. Charles Foster Kane dies before the story truly begins when he whispers the word "Rosebud." And from that point on, the screenplay does not ask what will happen next. It asks what his life meant. So this structural decision is not just a gimmick; it's the thesis of the film. The whole storyline is based on this.
- 5.36 By beginning with the death, the screenplay removes all forward momentum as its narrative engine and replaces it with memory and investigation. And it's other people's

memories of who he was. We're not really seeing—we don't know if everything they're saying is the truth. Everyone has a different perspective. And the story unfolds through this reporter's investigation, but the reporter himself has no arc. He's not like a protagonist. He doesn't really gain anything. He's just used as a device. He asks questions, the other people tell him the stories, and he fragments and puts it all together.

- 5.37** Every person in the report or interviews remembers Charles Foster Kane differently. To one, he's an idealist, to another, he's a tyrant, to another, he's a lonely child trapped in a man's body, but the screenplay doesn't really give you answers to any of this. It's just putting it out there for you. It's almost there for you to decide. There's no authoritative voice that's going to solve this puzzle for you, that's going to give you all the answers. So what it does is it proposes that life is unstable, identity is unstable, a person is not one thing. He's made up of many things, and that may depend on who's doing all the remembering.
- 5.38** We just talked during the break about a review of the Napoleon film by a historian. I just got this information from Nancy here. She told me this story. He reviewed the film Napoleon by Ridley Scott. And he was talking about how everything was untrue and it wasn't right. And he's a historian and he knows. And then when Ridley Scott read this and was asked about it, he said, "What does he know? He wasn't there. Who says that my version is not how it happened? He doesn't know. He investigated it, so did I." So it's all perspective. What do we know? What are our versions of history? We try to hope that historical documents are eyewitness accounts or eyewitness of eyewitness, but we don't know.
- 5.39** In this case, you're taking along this journey to find out who this man is with every single person telling a different version of who the man is. And another thing that's talked about this screenplay, that one of its great achievements is its refusal to psychologize Kane in obvious ways. There's no explanations, monologues. There's no scenes in which he himself says, "Oh, when I was a kid—" nothing articulates his trauma. It just has a structure.
- 5.40** You see, when he's young, he has an idealism, as we all do when we're young, when we want to change the world, we want to be better. "Oh, the old people, they don't know what they're talking about. We know better." Everyone thinks they know better. But as you get more knowledge, as we talked about in the other lecture, your views change about everything. Your life changes. All these things happen.
- 5.41** So you see him as a youth with all this youthful hope. Then you see him later on in the scenes where he's bitter and isolated when he tries to buy love instead of really being loving. He loses the women in his life. So the larger his empire becomes, the smaller his emotional world becomes until he's totally isolated with nothing. I mean, it's an amazing piece of work.

- 5.42 So Rosebud, when we see what it is at the end, I won't say it in case you haven't seen it. I've said a lot already. But it doesn't excuse his behavior, even when we find out why he said "Rosebud." It doesn't offer any moral closure to anything that he may or may not have done. The audience learned something about him when they see why he said that. But during the course of his life, he really doesn't learn anything about himself. He doesn't change. This is just his trajectory. He doesn't confess to anything. He doesn't apologize for anything. He doesn't think he did anything wrong. So the meaning of his life is revealed privately after his death, unseen by those who search for it. This is a devastating choice.
- 5.43 It reinforces the screenplay's central argument: understanding of a life for a person sometimes comes too late. We don't all know what happened in a person's life that makes them do what they do. We were talking about villains in movies, right? Why do they do what they do? Because that's why—judging people, yeah, you can judge their actions or what they're doing, and we all have to be judged by our actions. But everyone has a past. Everyone has incidents in their life that change who they are and what they are and why they are. So that's what this is saying.
- 5.44 Interesting that the production history of Citizen Kane is almost like what happened in the movie. Orson Welles was only 25 years old, he had never directed a film at all, and he was given unprecedented creative control by RKO Studios. And the whole studio system, I was shaken by this, that they were going to let this young guy—he's writing it, he's acting in it, he's directing it. And the budget was big. He was doing whatever he wanted. Like I said, he's digging holes in the studio floor. They had no idea what he was doing.
- 5.45 When it came out, the screenplay, it leaked that it resembled the life of newspaper magnate William Randolph Hearst. Hearst realized, "He's mocking me. He's writing this about me." He responded with all kinds of force. He had advertisements banning the film. He owned lots of newspapers, so he wrote all bad articles throughout the whole country. He threatened theater owners if they showed the film. He was trying to suppress the release entirely. He was threatening the studio heads also. So Citizen Kane, as great as it is and as classic as it is, struggled commercially. It didn't really make a lot of money. It was eventually admired, but it wasn't embraced by the people at that time.
- 5.46 But the screenplay changed the course of screenplay writing. It opened up that other genre, as we talked about, to something that no one had ever seen before. And then, like a lot of films, even if It's a Wonderful Life also, later on, it started getting all the recognition that it deserved. So the screenplay demonstrated that a film could be intellectually demanding, structurally complex, and morally ambiguous, while still being emotionally compelling, and it legitimized nonlinear storytelling and unreliable narration as a character-driven inquiry, a serious cinematic tool.

- 5.47** So for screenwriters, *Citizen Kane* remains foundational because it teaches a permanent lesson: structure is meaning. How a story is told is inseparable from what the story says. By refusing simplicity, the screenplay achieves depth. By denying closure—you don't really get a lot of closure at the end of this movie—it's still achieving a truth because it's putting it out there saying, "You decide who was this man, which stories were true, which weren't."
- 5.48** Was he the cause of all his own dilemmas? Was he the cause of his own pain? His choices changed his life, all the pain, all the suffering. But look what he achieved. So how much more could he have achieved if he made other decisions? Was it greed? Was it anger? Was it the quest for love? I mean, I feel when I watched that, he just wanted to be loved. He wanted the innocence that he had when he was a child, and he never could get that. He never got it from the women that he chose and loved. And ultimately, he was alone.
- 5.49** There's a fantastic shot in that film of him when he's in his giant mansion, and he's walking down a hallway, older. And I don't even know how Orson Welles did this. The whole thing was mirrors that had mirrors that had different slots in it. And he hits a point when he's just dejected, walking, and it's like a hundred of him walking alone by himself. And so *Citizen Kane* is a story about a man who gains everything the world can offer, but dies spiritually bankrupt.
- 5.50** The Bible parallels Ecclesiastes. It's about the vanity of gaining everything, the futility of power, the emptiness of achieving anything without love in your life. Kane gains the world, loses his soul, not through complete wickedness, although he had some evil things that he did. He did what he wanted. But gradually, his emotion and his spirit and his heart eroded during the course of his life. So the story is a warning, not about wealth itself, but about what happens when possessions take the place of relationships.
- 5.51** So going back—that's a biblical parallel. Shakespearean parallels are equally strong, especially with *King Lear*. Like Lear, Kane is a powerful patriarch. He's undone by misjudgment, flattery, and pride. He mistakes loyalty for love. He mistakes his control over people for actual emotional connection. He thinks they're there really for him when they're just there because he's paying them because of his wealth and who he is. And though he mistakes loyalty for love, he tries to control everyone's loyalty and everyone's love. And though he's surrounded by people because he has an empire, he still dies alone. So both *King Lear* and Kane not with triumph, but with recognition that comes too late to save the man at the center of the storyline.
- 5.52** So it's about loss. It's mistaking power for love. He starts his life not as this powerful person, but he starts his life as a child who's yearning for love and chasing love. And he's innocent at the beginning. Innocence gets corrupted. We see him as a little boy playing in the snow. It's like he's in Eden, if we're going to do the biblical comparison.

- 5.53** He's poor, but he's whole, he's happy, he's loved, he's carefree, he's free. And when he's taken from that moment, when he's removed from his home to be somewhere for financial security, he experiences what in scripture and in Shakespeare would be described as a fall. So both Shakespeare and the Bible warn that wealth can estrange the human soul from what matters most in life. In the Gospel of Mark, Jesus asked a question: "What does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul?" So he is a cinematic embodiment of that line.
- 5.54** He acquires newspapers, influence, political power, property, a palace. But the more he gains, the less human connection he retains. And by the time he reaches what he calls Xanadu, his empire has expanded outward and his inner life has collapsed inward.
- 5.55** So Citizen Kane, like I said, one of the greatest films of all time, one of the greatest scripts of all time. It's a must see for anyone that's writing scripts or anyone that knows film in general. So that's Citizen Kane.
- 5.56** So we go from Citizen Kane to one of the next films that I love and watch over and over again. Can't get enough of it. It's a Wonderful Life, 1946, black and white. Frank Capra, amazing director. All his films are fantastic. It's a Wonderful Life is sometimes thought of as a sentimental holiday movie. But underneath the warmth of its love and the sentimentality of it, there's a very emotionally tormented screenplay under there that lifts it and takes it to a whole other level. I mean, it's so deep, the story lines of this and the themes that it discusses, we'll get into now.
- 5.57** So remember, it was a Christmas film, but it's a disservice to that. Like I said, beneath its familiar imagery and warmth lies one of the most emotionally rigorous screenplays ever written. It was written by Frances Goodrich and Albert Hackett with a lot of Frank Capra's involvement.
- 5.58** It's a morally demanding work. It deals with a lot that was going on in its time. Poor people, Americans trying to overcome a depression to rise up, housing, loans. This is when America was being built up, when people needed loans, when families needed neighborhoods, needed towns. So all of this is going on underneath a story that's really about despair, exhaustion, false hopes—dreams that don't come true, and the terrifying possibility that a good life may feel indistinguishable from a wasted one.
- 5.59** It's a modern morality play, deeply rooted in biblical theology and shaped by Shakespeare and dramatic structure. It does not just tell a comforting story about what ends up with kindness. It wrestles with despair, sacrifice, and all the things we've talked about with the Shakespearean and biblical themes. It's like Hamlet's soliloquy, "To be or not to be." He's talking about what is a life worth if it never becomes what it dreamed of becoming. George Bailey, the character played by Jimmy Stewart, he has a crisis, a big financial crisis. As we know, if you've seen it, stop the video, watch it.
- 5.60** But it's not just financial. He believes his life has been wasted, misdirected, ultimately rendered meaningless, and that belief places him squarely within both the biblical

tradition of lamented sorrow and the Shakespearean tradition of tragic self-recognition. He thinks his life is meaningless and worthless and meant nothing.

- 5.61** So the biblical framework of the film is established immediately. The film starts with a shot of the stars in the universe. And we hear the voiceovers of some men in charge up there, wherever they are, that want to send one of their angels down to Earth to help a man named George Bailey, who is about to take his own life. The angel that they choose, Clarence, will get his wings if he saves George. So first, they give Clarence and us a backstory about George Bailey.
- 5.62** We meet George Bailey as a boy. We see even then he has big plans for his own future. He dreams of travel, education, and significance beyond the small town. Even as a boy, he wanted to get out of there. He's going to live a big, big life. But at every decisive moment in his life, as we will see, his plans are completely interrupted and change. When he was about to go off to college, his father dies. He has to take over the family business; he can't leave yet. When he finally was going to leave, and his brother was going to take over, his brother was needed somewhere else, getting married and starting a family with his wife. George's plans always change because maybe a business crisis arises or a neighbor requires help.
- 5.63** Now, these interruptions are not presented as random misfortune. They form a pattern for him. It echoes the biblical teaching that human intention is real but not ultimate. Scripture consistently affirms that while human beings make big plans for their future and their paths, it's God who directs their steps. We never know what's in store for us. We can plan, plan, plan all we want, and those plans can go all over the place because all the planning in the world, we don't know what life is going to throw at us.
- 5.64** So George Bailey's life becomes an illustration of this truth. He has never allowed—and he's prevented from leaving Bedford Falls, the town that he's grown up in, that he's wanted to get out of his whole life. He just can never leave. He just can't get out. He's prevented because his presence there serves a greater purpose than his own fulfillment of his own wants and needs. He didn't recognize that about himself, but God kept him there for a reason.
- 5.65** The opening scenes in heaven reinforce this theological theme in the movie because it talks about divine providence. There's people up there, there's gods up there. They're sending an angel down to fix and help George. And prayers offered on George's behalf mirror the biblical theme of intercession prayer, that we can pray for other people and to try to help them. So the film treats prayer seriously with no sentimentality.
- 5.66** And Clarence's assignment is not a joke to him. He wants to go down there and help George Bailey. He wants his wings, but he also wants to help him. And angels coming down to help people are all over the Bible. Angels appear to Hagar, to Elijah, to Mary, to Peter. Clarence is sent in a moment of crisis, as is with all of those biblical characters or people, not to remove suffering from George's life, but to put it in a different

perspective. And show him, "I can't change your circumstances, but I want to just restore your understanding of your life and what it meant."

- 5.67** This becomes especially important at the moment of George's deepest despair. He's standing on a bridge contemplating suicide. He's about to take his own life. Elijah in the Bible asks God to take his life. Job curses the day of his birth. Jonah begs for death rather than to continue to obey God; he can't handle it anymore.
- 5.68** So despair in the human heart is not trivialized here. It's met with revelation. The angel does not scold Elijah. He feeds him. God doesn't crush Job. He expands his vision. In the same way, Clarence does not argue with George's pain. He shows him the truth that George cannot see, that the value of his life is not measured by dreams fulfilled, but by the lives that he touched.
- 5.69** So this leads to the film's central biblical affirmation that the worth of a human life cannot be calculated by worldly success. And the teachings of Jesus consistently invert conventional measures of value. The shepherd leaves the 99 sheep to go find the one. The kingdom belongs to the poor in spirit. What profits a man if he gains the whole world and loses his soul, like in *Citizen Kane*?
- 5.70** George Bailey has not gained the world, and all the things the world has, but he's preserved souls, saved people, protected families, and quietly upheld human dignity. The tragedy is not that his life lacks value, it's that he cannot see his value. That's the tragedy of this film.
- 5.71** I can go on and on with this. You've got to see it. It speaks for itself. It covers so many Shakespearean and biblical themes. But it's an amazing, amazing ride. You have your evil man, Mr. Potter, and you have all these things that go wrong with George, and you're constantly saying, "When is he going to get out? What's he going to do?" So the whole thing about *It's a Wonderful Life*—it is a wonderful life, whatever your life is, if you can understand how you affect other human beings. That's *It's a Wonderful Life*.
- 5.72** I tried to have an ending like that in *Green Book*. That's what we were shooting for. I don't think anything can touch *It's a Wonderful Life*, but that's the type of feeling we were going for. Like I said, you get that feeling in *Cinema Paradiso* as well.
- 5.73** The next film we're going to talk about is *The Godfather*. So another great opening line: "I believe in America." You're watching a mob movie, and you're saying, "I believe in America." Why does he open with that line? What is this character who has come to Don Corleone for a favor? Why does he start with that? Because immigrants came here because America had hope, America had laws. America gave people dreams that they could follow. And he starts telling Don Corleone about how he believes in America. But yet the system has failed him. His daughter was taken by these men, beaten, raped, and they let them go. That's not right. How is that justice? That's why he has to come to Don Corleone for justice.

- 5.74** The Godfather is often said is the greatest gangster film ever made. It's one of the greatest films ever made, period. Because the screenplay is not really about crime. It's about much more than that, as we'll see, again, going back to the themes of Shakespeare and biblical themes. It was written by Mario Puzo and the director, Francis Ford Coppola. It's a family tragedy in the tradition of Shakespeare.
- 5.75** It's really Shakespearean in its scope. It uses organized crime as its dramatic framework to tell about the fall of a man. It's a moral tragedy. He adapted this novel, The Godfather, and he has a great book about how he—blanking on the title of it—how he took that screenplay, the book of Mario Puzo's The Godfather, and turned it into a screenplay. It's fascinating. You see the whole script, you see his notes in the book. It's really an amazing way to see what he put into making this.
- 5.76** Now, he's adapting something, but he was someone who wanted to adapt the book. We talked about this also of how sometimes you read a great book, and it's not a great script. He wanted to make this book a great film. So he adapted himself. He went in with Mario Puzo, the original writer, and they did what they did. It's a great learning tool for writing scripts. If you can get a hold of it, just look up "Francis Ford Coppola, making of the Godfather script." I think it's called something like that.
- 5.77** So basically, it's about handling the ancient questions, again, that we were talking about. Kings, sacrifice, corruption, questions that are thousands of years old. What happens when a righteous man inherits a fallen kingdom? Can power be exercised without destroying the soul? Is loyalty a virtue, or is it the beginning of moral blindness? All biblical and Shakespearean questions.
- 5.78** Again, the screenplay opens not with violence, but with a request for justice. Bonasera's plea to Don Vito Corleone establishes the moral universe of the story before a single gun is fired. This is a world in which the formal institutions of justice have failed. You failed these people. So the law to them is meaningless. If you're not getting real justice, what does it mean to be here? But power— Don Corleone's power, that's personal. You can go to Don Corleone. His favor will replace what we call rights, the rights that you think you have, but you don't sometimes have when this injustice is done.
- 5.79** For the very first moment in the very first scene, it teaches the audience that this society, this insular family of a mob family, of this society of mob families, it shows how they function, how they take care of their problems amongst themselves. They do it quietly. The wedding scene is among the biggest, most efficient first acts in a script ever.
- 5.80** In cinematic history, within one single extended scene, the screenplay introduces just about every major character in the film. It establishes the rules of power. It defines the central themes, family loyalty above all else. Violence, honor, and obligation are intertwined from the very beginning. You see who everyone is in this tremendous

opening scene. Michael Corleone, played by Al Pacino. His arc is the heart of the screenplay. It's all about him, really.

- 5.81** Because when you see *The Godfather*, when you first see it, you think they're talking about Marlon Brando's character, Don Vito Corleone, but ultimately, *The Godfather* is about Michael Corleone. So it's about his arc. And Michael, even though he has this family, believes he can remain morally separate. He can love his family. It's what they do. "That's my family, Kay. That's not me."
- 5.82** But with every choice that he makes or gets pushed to make, it draws him deeper, deeper into the very world he rejects. So his tragedy lies not in his corruption, but his acceptance of the inevitable. As much as he wanted out, which he says in *Godfather Part III*, "Just when I thought I was out, they pull me back in." At this point, he wasn't even in yet. He's out, but his choices pulled him back in because he still was deep-rooted in his loyalty to his family. We see him in the wedding scene, very restrained. We see he's not a part of this. He explains to his girlfriend at the time, who becomes his wife, Kay. Michael believes in his moral distance. He believes he can stay away from all of this.
- 5.83** So the screenplay—it's been said—its genius lies in how it constructs inevitability without removing choice. Michael is never forced into this dark world. He steps into it willingly, one decision at a time. "Well, I'll do one thing and I'll be done. Well, then I've got to do this other thing. Oh, they killed my brother now, too. I've got to do that thing." So everything he, in his mind, rationalizes as necessary, even noble, because he's protecting his family. Someone has to do it.
- 5.84** So the reader of the script or the audience, they understand Michael's logic. You can almost go, "Yeah, you can't blame him for what he's doing." But I think deep down, every time he does something, there's going to be consequences for all the choices that he ultimately makes.
- 5.85** I can go on and on about this movie. Again, the biblical and the Shakespearean references are all there. I can get into the plot. I can get into how it changes. But I think we know the basic story of this.
- 5.86** *The Godfather* reshaped how cinema portrays power, masculinity, moral ambiguity. These men make their own rules. They protect their own families, which then you could say that they're wrong. They're thieves. They're criminals. But then you could say that the government does the same thing. But when you don't get justice from the government, where can you get justice? So that's what this is about. But it's about the fall of someone. Again, it's about: if a man gains anything, what good is it if he loses his soul?
- 5.87** We talked earlier that he gets betrayed by his brother, Judas. Later on, in part two, I think of them as all one movie. Later on, he kills his own brother, thinking that it's the right thing to do because it's the right thing to do, but is it the right thing to do? But he

does it. There's your Cain and Abel connection. And ultimately, he falls. We see him alone by himself.

- 5.88** Once again, like Charles Foster Kane, he's in this big mansion in the middle of nowhere, but everyone is gone. In that final scene in The Godfather Part II, he has a flashback of when everything was good, when he was at a table with his family. But no, he's alone by himself.
- 5.89** So I have some Godfather stories that I will get into in the next hour. But we've got to get one more movie in before I do that because I was in The Godfather when I was a little kid. I don't know if I mentioned that yet. So I'll tell you about that. So I was on that set, and I have a bunch of stories about that.
- 5.90** So I want to get to my last amazing film in this section: Rocky. How could I not love Rocky? Rocky, Sylvester Stallone. It's described as a sports movie, but that really misses everything, the whole point. Boxing is not the subject of the story. It's just where the story takes place. Rocky is about self-worth, your calling in life, your identity, moral victories. Again, themes that are in both the Bible and Shakespeare. The film is timeless because it's structured like an ancient story.
- 5.91** With Stallone, I think he did this all purposely. You feel for this man, even though you don't know why, not because of all these punches that are thrown that you're following this, but because of all the truths that are revealed in this film.
- 5.92** So he introduces Rocky as a man of no social value. He's a failed person. He's a failed boxer. The thing he does, the only thing he does is boxing, and he's not good at it. He's a small-time debt collector, poorly educated. He's mocked and basically invisible in the world. He's alone in a crappy little apartment with two turtles, and that's his life. He can't even get a young woman who's shy and introverted that probably no one tries to talk to him. He can't even get her to talk to him. He's really the bottom of the barrel.
- 5.93** This is also a pattern, again, we talked about in scripture, the lowly being chosen to rise to great places. Your heroes don't come from the richest, the most handsome, the most beautiful, the most powerful. Heroes can rise from anywhere. You talk about David and Goliath. David is a little shepherd boy.
- 5.94** No one wanted to fight Goliath. They thought he was nuts. He was going to get killed in one second. But somehow, through God's providence, he defeats Goliath. You would never pick him to be your hero. But even David, if you get into that story, David has a fall. As blessed as he was, he still found a way to fall. He commits murder because he's having an adultery with a man's wife. As much as he was blessed, he still falls. So the human nature is rise and fall.
- 5.95** But we love to watch movies about people like Rocky because he had nothing, but he rose up. Through all these problems that he had, he rose up. He had an opportunity.

The apostle Paul writes that God chooses the foolish things of the world to shame the wise and the weak things to shame the strong.

- 5.96** Rocky is not chosen because he's the best fighter in Philadelphia. He's chosen because he's one of the worst fighters in Philadelphia. When he's chosen to fight Apollo Creed, the champion, Apollo Creed represents the exact opposite of who Rocky is. He's celebrated, he's articulate, he's wealthy, he's a public figure who's loved.
- 5.97** So it is a David-and-Goliath story. Rocky is chosen because they just think, "Yeah, I'll knock him out and I'll hold him up for three rounds and get rid of him." But Rocky doesn't seek glory. He just wants to be seen. He doubts himself. He doesn't think he's going to win. He says, "I'm going to go there. He's going to beat the crap out of me. Yeah, I'll do it. Okay, I'll do it because that's who I am. I'll do it." But it's about his love story. It's about Adrian.
- 5.98** The thing about Rocky is he doesn't win. Everyone forgets this. He loses. But he wins. The genius of that to get a character because you're in that theater. I remember the first time I watched it, it was with my brother. It's huge. Theater packed with pretty much all Jersey guys screaming their heads off, all Italians. And everyone's crying at the end, like I am now. Because he doesn't win, but he wins.
- 5.99** And that's the genius of Sylvester Stallone. Life isn't about how other people perceive you. Life isn't about wealth. It's all good if you could be successful. I found a little success late in life, but I was shaped by films like this and how it made you feel. Rocky was important to guys like me because it said, "If you fight, if you don't give up, you can do it. You can do it." Okay. I don't know if I can even talk about it anymore. So any questions?
- 5.100** In Rocky, the turtles were Cuff and Link.
- 5.101** Yes, Cuff and Link.
- 5.102** You were talking before about Green Book and how it would measure up to It's a Wonderful Life. But I feel that the letters to Dolores from your mother also paralleled Zuzu's petals in a way.
- 5.103** Yeah, well, that's right. I never thought of that. Thank you.
- 5.104** Brought hope and love.
- 5.105** Yes, yes, yes, yes.
- 5.106** Yeah, and appreciation of your life, and to remind you that you're doing the right thing and you're in the right time in the right place. Yeah. So I guess I don't have a question, but just a comment.
- 5.107** Oh, that's nice. Anyone else?
- 5.108** I have a question about It's a Wonderful Life and its biblical connection. So in the Book of Job, we see that God lets the devil mess with Job's life because the devil's like, he's

only believing because his life is so good, and everything gets destroyed, and he still believes. In screenwriting, particularly, how do you maintain that belief or energy to push forward, even when people don't believe in you?

- 5.109** Like I said, and I'm going to get into my journey, not that I think it's important, but it might help answer questions like that. This type of stuff is dreams. You dream about this. But to dream about it, to be successful and to change the world or to be rich or powerful, I never thought of it that way. This is what I was always compelled to do, I felt. I don't know why I had this want and need to tell stories. I know I loved hearing my uncle. He told us stories all the time, and I couldn't believe he would tell these great stories. We couldn't stop listening to him. And then by reading so many books and watching so many films, and how it made me feel, I'm like, you can make people feel something if you make them feel good.
- 5.110** In the case of Rocky, he doesn't—and I got to meet this with him a couple of times. The effect he's had on so many people. You don't realize, and that's the same thing with It's a Wonderful Life, you don't realize the effect you have on people.
- 5.111** So all I can say is you fight, keep fighting. Dreams are great, but it takes a lot of work to make dreams come true. So to answer your question, you want to follow your dreams? Work as hard as you can at it. It's like saying, I want to be a bodybuilder, but you don't go to the gym. You've got to be in the gym every single day. And you may not see the results all the time. Sometimes you go, "I'm on this diet. I'm not losing weight. I'm going to the gym every day. I don't look like Arnold Schwarzenegger." Well, you've got to keep doing it.
- 5.112** The same thing goes for writing. If this is your dream, if this is what you want to do, do it. But maybe the dream doesn't come true the way you want it to come true. But maybe writing something does something to your soul. It changes you, how you think about life, and it may affect something else down the line. Keep fighting, keep trying, and work really hard. It's all about really hard work and not giving up.
- 5.113** I think I'm going to go a little bit more technical. When you're thinking about bringing those feelings to your audience through your screenplay, how do you do that? Do you think that—do you use a lot of dialogue? Do you use a lot of images? What is it that you feel—what are the techniques that you can use to bring feelings to the audience?
- 5.114** I'll answer this quick, and we can get into it again later on. But I think we all have it in us because we know what affects us. Obviously, I can cry at the drop of a Rocky quote. We know what makes us feel something, right? So I know what makes me feel something, the great movies that make me feel and why and what the human condition is and seeing people rise up. That affects me a lot.
- 5.115** For me, it's also theology and my faith. I like to see people that can do better in their lives. So any way to help someone, any way to, in my small way, whatever it might be,

if I can even do that, I don't even know if I can do that. But I try to be nice to people. I try to help people.

5.116 So in the writing, to make people feel something, it's like a horror movie. You're going to go in there. If I just said, write a horror movie, well, you have preconceived notions in your mind what a horror movie does. You know you're going to make people jump out of their seats, you're going to scare them, and you do that with your script, you do that visually. There are techniques to do it. To make someone cry, to feel emotion. Well, we all cry, we all feel emotion. We all have human instincts, love, and we all want to be loved, and we all want good lives. So I think everyone shares the same emotions, no matter what part of the world you're in.

5.117 I mean, Green Book was seen all over the world, wherever I went, when we went on these tours and to show the film. People loved it in different languages. It didn't matter because we all speak the same language in a sense, which is love. And that's what I tried to do with Green Book. Thanks.

Lecture 6: The Professional Path

At a glance — The professional path.

- 6.1** So we're going to be a little less formal on this one. I won't be reading anything, which means I have nothing pretty much to say. But I'll give you guys a little background on how I got here, because everyone is at a different stage of their screenwriting process. So I'll give you a background on that. And feel free to ask me any questions during the talk. Just break right in for questions. We don't have to wait till the end. Break it up. It'll probably take up some time. I'm trying to eat up as much time as I can without boring everybody.
- 6.2** So people ask me, what made me do this? I don't know. I have no idea. I just know that as a kid, my mom said, I would never stop talking. I wouldn't shut up. The only thing that would shut me up was if she put me in front of the TV, and then I would stop, and I'd be fascinated by that. I grew up in a family of Italians, Italian music, Italian culture.
- 6.3** A friend of mine, Robert Davi, says, "Growing up Italian, you had three portraits in the house, pictures on the walls. You had a picture of Jesus, you had a picture of the Pope, and you had a picture of Frank Sinatra." That's how we were brought up. My father being the Copacabana guy, Dean Martin, Frank Sinatra, Connie Francis, an Italian singer named Jimmy Roselli, we were all playing that music all the time. So art and culture were always there. Music was always there. Live music, who was playing a guitar, they were always singing songs.
- 6.4** And my uncles, my mother's brothers, John and Lou, were storytellers. My uncle John, especially. Every time we were together, families. Those are days when cousins and relatives would eat meals together all the time. There would always be 10-15 people having lunch or dinner. And he always would grab the kids and tell us stories, mostly to scare us. Tell us these stories about some guy on a hill. But I was always fascinated by the stories. It sucked me in. And I would always be like this. I wanted to know what was going to happen. And so I always wanted to say, "How do I tell stories like that? I want to tell stories and people wanting to hear the rest of it."
- 6.5** So luckily, I had parents that allowed me to feed this creative thing I had. I was a voracious reader. I didn't even get into as much the type of books that I think you need to read. I read everything. I used to read a book a week. And again, it depends on where you are in your life. It's hard to sit down and read books now. When you're younger, you have all the time on your hands. There was no internet, there was no laptops, there was no tablets. There was some TV, three channels, but you had to read, right? So I read everything.
- 6.6** So books like The Three Musketeers, for example. I couldn't stop reading it. It was a movie in my head, The Three Musketeers. It has to be read. You have to read that

book, The Count of Monte Cristo. I read history books. I read about the Revolutionary War and the Civil War.

- 6.7** I have a Daniel Boone movie that I've got in my head for my whole life. I read the history of Daniel Boone, his life. Besides loving the show, it made me want to read about him. There's a great book called The Trial of Daniel Boone that I want to maybe turn into a film one day. I still haven't done it. I've wanted to do it since I was 10. So who knows what's going to happen in life, where it takes you. But I still, I've got to make that Daniel Boone movie one day.
- 6.8** So reading, I think, is very, very important. As if I just said a genius line. Of course, reading is important, but it's important for screenwriting because the more well-read you are, the better you're going to be. Because you may not have the life experiences.
- 6.9** I don't want to keep picking on him, but he's got a lot of life experience in this room. He has less life experience in this room. So sometimes, like I got lucky, you write what you know. So I happen to know a family story. You may want to write about something that kids your age are going through that none of us can even relate to. We wouldn't even know how to write that story. He's going to write a story about something that happened when he was 25 years old that's affected what's happened to his life now, and why the gap in time, how it changed his life. You don't have that yet.
- 6.10** And it's not that you can't, because you can write movies about anything and anyone. We can write a movie about Martians on the Moon 200 years from now that we find are like robots or something. You can make stuff up. You don't have to be a murderer to write a script about a murder or a murderer or a criminal. You don't have to be a thief to write about a criminal. You can make it up.
- 6.11** But the ones that I think resonate and make you feel is when you are writing about something that has personally affected you, or even if it's interwoven into a fictional character or a fictional story, put some of what you've lived into that because that's what's going to make it ring true. That's what's going to make people want to watch it or keep watching it or study it, I believe. So everything I write, there's something personal in it.
- 6.12** Now, I've written crappy scripts. I've written decent scripts. I've written scripts that I think still that should be made. I've had scripts made that I go, "Why are they making that? Oh, do we need this script?" I'll go into my bed, dust off something, "Here, let's make this now." But you've got to do what you've got to do, especially if this is the main thing that you want to do in life.
- 6.13** Is it something you want to try or a hobby? But if you want to make this your career, in a sense, start writing what you know. Put in what you feel. We were talking about how you make people feel something. Well, you can't force making someone feel something. But if you felt something, if you can get it on paper properly, you can probably make someone else feel something, because as we've talked about over and

over, these themes are all the same. Every human emotion, everyone has. So someone's going to be touched by it, and everyone probably is going to have felt that same thing at some point in their life. So use what you know, write what you know.

- 6.14** As a kid, I had, luckily, a loving family, a happy childhood, but I just loved fiction. I loved movies, and I loved the way stories made people feel something. And I always wanted to make people laugh, make people cry in a good way, scare them if it was a scary movie, but have their attention. I don't know why I had that in me to do that.
- 6.15** So by reading all these books, again, the osmosis of that, there's books that I read that I forgot that I read, but I can guarantee that somewhere in me, I pull something out from one of those things. So I mentioned, what did I mention? The Three Musketeers and The Count of Monte Cristo. Those were big books in my life.
- 6.16** Another book that I think is very, very, very important is A Christmas Carol. I was going to do a bunch of time about A Christmas Carol. I'm not sure if we're going to have enough time to do it. But that book, the way it was written, it's another change of how literature was done. It's very important, I think, to read that. Again, biblical themes, Shakespearean-type themes. But he took that book to another place. When you really get deep into what the storytelling is, it's quite magical and fantastic. So A Christmas Carol had a big effect on me as well.
- 6.17** But all the books I read—and I loved history. That's another thing. The more history books or biographies you read, the more you see people's actions. Why did this person achieve what they did, whatever that book may be about? Biographies, I think, are very important because you're writing about human behavior. You have a character, characters, that you want to put them apart from the other characters. Why is this character different from this? How am I using the characters to move my plot along, to tell my story? So all the reading you could do, all the films that you can watch, all of that affected everything I ever had to do.
- 6.18** So when I was in junior high school, I was writing. I luckily had a great teacher, Mr. Lou Alou. Mr. Lou Alou was his name. And he encouraged me. He saw my writing, encouraged me. I had another, Mrs. Barber, that encouraged me. She was a teacher of English that saw that I had this love for writing. So luckily, I was always encouraged to do it. My parents encouraged me, and I just tried. I wrote lots of different things. I wrote a little book when I was small. I put that together. I won a little award for that in school. I don't know why I was compelled to do it. I just did it.
- 6.19** So when I went to college, I went to college for communications because I thought, "I want to be an actor. I want to be a writer. I'd like to be a director." And again, I wanted to be a baseball player. I wanted to be a lot of things. So you don't know what you're going to end up. Still, I thought, "I don't know if I could ever really do it."
- 6.20** But I was around entertainment so much because of my father and my father running the Copacabana. Did I tell a story about Francis Ford Coppola, right? I told that story

when they went in there, and they found my father, and we auditioned for The Godfather. So my father then became an actor. He was in a lot of movies after that, and we'll talk about that, too. And then I wanted to be an actor, too.

6.21 So I got to the Screen Actors Guild. I would go into New York City. I'd audition, I'd do plays, lots of plays, lots of theater. See, because even if it's not screenwriting, it's all part of it; it comes back to the screenwriting. When you're reading other people's plays, if you're acting, if you're directing, if you're whatever you're doing in the arts, it's going to help you when you do your screenplay.

6.22 Everything helps you. It's like a big pot. Throw everything into the pot. Everything that you've had, consciously, unconsciously, it's going to go into the pot. So by acting, I'm interpreting other people's scripts, I'm directed by other people, I'm performing. Because when you're writing your script, you're performing. You're putting yourself on there. People have to read your script. So it's your performance as we talked earlier. It's up to you to get that character and those characters going. If you don't do it, they're not going to do it. They're just going to be in a computer somewhere, your character left there going, "Get me out."

6.23 All of this led me to—I was a communications major. I wanted to be a film major. I almost went to NYU. I almost went to USC. I stayed in New Jersey, William Paterson University. Communications degree, because at that time—this is how far I go back—they were saying, "Oh, film's over with." It's all going to be video, and it's all TV. So forget films. Films were dying. They always say films are dying, just like we've been going through this period now. Films are dying, but somehow they don't go away.

6.24 As a matter of fact, now there are easier ways to make films. Let's say you want to make a little film, or you want to make a short film, you want to try something. You go, "Let me write a 10-minute script and just see how it works." Get some actors, get them together, make it with your iPhone. You can make films now much easier. Back then, even the video cameras were these giant things you had to carry around and were very expensive. Now, you can shoot something with an iPhone. There's no excuse not to get something made or shoot something. Just test it and see if it works.

6.25 It doesn't matter if you fail, it doesn't matter if it's good, bad, it doesn't really matter. It's like your scripts, too. Any script, you have 10 pages, get some friends, get some actors if you have people like that around you. Read it, hear it out loud. All of this is a valid process to move yourself forward.

6.26 So, for me, now I'm in communications. I'm doing theater while I'm in college. I did a lot of plays. I was writing, and then I was writing for the newspaper. I was studying journalism. I think I mentioned at one point I ended up working at CBS News. Maybe that's my writing. Maybe I do reporting. I did sports reporting. I wrote some magazine articles.

- 6.27** I had a friend of mine who really turned out to be a big music producer. And one day I said, "Let me just interview, and maybe I could write an article about you." I did, and he got into the biggest music magazine that there was. In the 20 years, they picked their top 20 interviews. They would have an interview a month. I was one of the top 20. I did that when I was 19 years old, which was a great achievement for me. I was very pleased.
- 6.28** But I felt restricted in that type of writing. I wanted to see—could I do it? Could I work for a newspaper? I did sports reporting. I reported on high school football. I did it. I wrote this magazine article in a big magazine. I did it. So I was showing myself, "Oh, I can do it. I can write." But is this really what I want to write? And it wasn't. I wanted to write movies, not scripts. I wanted to write movies.
- 6.29** So I got my communications degree. During that time, I lived in New Jersey, but without traffic then, it was only 20 minutes into New York City. So I was constantly going to New York City, studying acting and doing a lot of extra work. I got into the Screen Actors Guild and would be an extra in every single production that was going on in New York. They needed a cop. You get a cop uniform back then. "Oh, yeah, I have a cop uniform." They knew who had cop uniforms. So I played cops. I played mob guys. I did whatever, mostly just background work. Eventually, I get a line here or there and build myself up.
- 6.30** But when I first started, I'm on sets. That was the first thing I thought, "I'm here on the set." I was on sets with huge movies. I told you that story about the family business. I was just an extra. I thought I was just going to stand in the back of the room like this. Next thing I know, I got Sean Connery dragging me around with handcuffs on.
- 6.31** So those are great experiences because anytime you can do that, too, get on a set, do extra work. I don't know where you guys live. If you're in LA, sign up for Central Casting. Try to be an extra in a movie. Why? Because you can watch how the movie is made. You want to make a movie, you should know how a real movie is made. It's not boring. The people that would go to sleep on the bus, I wouldn't. I'd be watching constantly. And you'd be surprised.
- 6.32** When you're there and you're watching, and if you ask, "Can I stay here and watch this?" Most people are pretty nice. It depends on if the director is a real dictator. But I had a lot of directors and first ADs say to me, "Yeah, hang out, watch it." Occasionally, they say, "You got any questions?" And so they encouraged me. And by watching, again, through osmosis, I was learning how to direct movies and how the movies were made. Just by being there, by experiencing it.
- 6.33** I had a lot of crazy moments. I had done a play, a Broadway touring, they were touring with Grease, and the play had not been done since the movie came out with John Travolta.
- 6.34** So when I was an usher in a movie theater, I watched Grease a thousand times because—we mentioned this earlier—when you're in movie theaters back then, the movie was

in the theater for a year. So I would watch it all the time, watch it all the time. I knew it inside out. I would do the dances. And I went for an audition for it, and I got the role of Danny Zuko, the John Travolta role, believe it or not, I was much thinner and I had a lot more hair on my head. And I was doing that play.

6.35 Then there was a casting agent in New York that did a lot of the background extra work that I did and called me one day. I had finished doing the show. And she said, "You were doing the John Travolta thing, right? You're the same height as him. How tall are you?" So I told her. She goes, "He has a stand-in, but the stand-in can't do it for a week or two weeks. I can get you. You could be John Travolta's stand-in on this movie." I'm like, "Yeah, I'll do that." "You sure?" "Yes."

6.36 So now all of a sudden, the movie was *Staying Alive* with John Travolta and Sylvester Stallone directing it. So now I'm on a set with John Travolta and Sylvester Stallone. And I'm standing in for John Travolta—same height as him. I had the same type of hair, whatever. And I'm going, "Okay, look where I am. How did I get here? Two guys, I got posters of them up in my room."

6.37 Stallone calls me over at one point. He's telling me what to do, walk through this. They would do a camera thing. And I go, "I'm talking to Sylvester Stallone. He's directing me." And then we did it. And then John came in, Travolta, and he said, "Nick, come over here. Show John what we're doing." I'm standing there, Stallone, Travolta, and me. And I go, "Either this is the greatest moment of my life, or this is God saying to me, 'You can do this.' I'm with two of my idols." Crazy. So I got to know John a little bit by doing that. And I guess we'll say this: I'm about to direct a movie with John Travolta.

6.38 Here I go again. Just kick me or something. Stop me. From being his stand-in on a movie, now I'm going to direct him in a movie. So it's crazy how you can't tell how life is going to lead you to that. My point is, being there, oh, you're an extra. No, you're a stand-in. No, I met John Travolta. I met Sylvester Stallone. It led to something 40 years later, but it still led to something.

6.39 So I had all these experiences on movie sets. I told you about the family business one. I told you about *The Godfather* experience I had as an extra. But all of these moments taught me something. It made me want to write more. It made me want to push more. It made me want to push harder. So I'm taking acting lessons in New York every day, three, four times a week.

6.40 And there was another movie that I got into. It was called *The Pope of Greenwich Village*. And the reason I got into *The Pope of Greenwich Village* was that my father got cast in *The Pope of Greenwich Village*. Does anyone ever see *The Pope of Greenwich Village*? You've got to see *The Pope of Greenwich Village*. Mickey Rourke, Eric Roberts, Vincent Patrick, book and screenplay.

6.41 So this is a famous movie for guys like me because it was a New York street thing. And this is when Mickey Rourke was at his height, Eric Roberts was at his height. But that

movie was going to be made first with Al Pacino and James Caan. They were older in the book, and they were signed onto this movie. And the movie then was being directed by someone named Ulu Grosbard, who's a big director. My father gets cast in this role—you'll see in the movie that he played a different role. But at the time, he got cast in the big mob boss role.

- 6.42 So I had to take him up to the production office one day. I drove him into the city, and I'm just sitting there by myself with the casting director, a lady named Joy Todd. She's coming and doing her thing, and she goes, "Who are you?" "I'm Nick." "What are you doing here?" "Tony Lip's son." "You're an actor?" I go, "Well—" "Here. Study this. Tell her when you're ready and come in and see me."
- 6.43 They give me the sides. They call them the sides of the script for this part. Now, I had read the book, so I knew what it was. The character was the brother of Al Pacino. So when I was 22 or 23 years old, like I said, I had a lot more hair. I was really thin, Italian-looking. I had an Al Pacino vibe to me, I guess. And I go in, I read it, and she goes, "You're on hold for this role, Al Pacino's brother. We'll get back to you."
- 6.44 So what happened to that movie was the cast changed. The money went away. They rebooted the movie. My father's role changed because they had to get more names in the movie. They went with a younger cast, Mickey Rourke, Eric Roberts, two amazing actors. That role that I was going to be Al Pacino's younger brother got cut out because it would have been Eric Roberts' younger brother, but I was almost the same age as Eric Roberts, so they didn't have that character. But they still put me in the movie.
- 6.45 So again, I'm on the set of that movie. I did a couple of scenes. They mostly got cut out. You see me in the movie, I'm in there. There's a famous stickball scene in there. But also there, I meet Eric Roberts. I met Mickey Rourke. I met some of the other actors on the movie. I was there for a long time. I'm watching how the movie got made. So all these experiences got blended together.
- 6.46 Prizzi's Honor. Who's seen Prizzi's Honor? Anyone? Yeah, good. No? Yes, yes, right. Prizzi's Honor. Write it down. You've got to see Prizzi's Honor. Jack Nicholson, Anjelica Huston. I was taking acting lessons by an actor named Bill Hickey, who was amazing. I was studying with this woman, Julie Bovasso, who played John Travolta's mother in Saturday Night Fever. And then she was also in The Verdict with Sidney Lumet. Julie Bovasso from the Actors Studio, amazing actress. And she had said to me, "Oh, you should also take some lessons by Bill Hickey."
- 6.47 He was in a place called HB Studio in New York City. All the actors went there. They had dozens of acting classes for pretty cheap at the time. And Bill Hickey was a renowned teacher, and he would always have this big pint of, it said it was soda water, but somehow I think he had something else in that bottle. And he was an amazing guy. Bill Hickey is in Prizzi's Honor. He plays this old Mafia don. Amazing.

- 6.48 But Jack Nicholson was there, and I got cast in that movie, too. And so you're on a set with John Huston, Jack Nicholson, Anjelica Huston. I was sitting by myself, and I saw one of the ADs walking around. I was in the wedding party, and they picked five guys. They go, "Come over here. Come over here." They had us stand around. And John Huston is standing a bit away.
- 6.49 John Huston. You know who John Huston is. Do you know who John Huston is? Okay. John Huston, *The Treasure of the Sierra Madre*. Just look up John Huston movies and start watching them. And you know Anjelica Huston? No, that's his daughter. If you don't know her, we're in big trouble. But you've got to start somewhere. John Huston was a great, great, great director and actor. Have you ever seen *Chinatown*? He played the old man in *Chinatown*. That's John Huston. But he was also a fantastic and renowned director.
- 6.50 So I see John Huston talking. He points, but there was a bunch of us. The AD says, "Come with me," to me. I'm like, "Oh, okay." He pulls me aside. John Huston said, "I have this scene. This guy's going to light this whole building on fire." He goes, "But you're in the wedding party, but I don't really need to see your face, but I just think you can handle doing it." So I go, "Okay," I got cast with my head chopped off in the scene because he just wanted to see that and see me in silhouette. But he chose me to do that. So now, again, I'm standing there.
- 6.51 They changed my clothes so we could do that sequence, brought me to a different part of the set where they were going to shoot it. And John Huston is telling me this. I go, "John Huston is directing? I'm being directed by John Huston." Again, going onto a movie as an extra, the background. Now I'm with John Huston directing me. It didn't matter if it was that one day. I'm just watching him, what he did. And again, if I wasn't there, none of these things would happen. And all of them kept pushing me forward, going, "There must be something. I keep getting picked for this or that."
- 6.52 Even though it's small stuff, I keep getting chosen. And there were some movies I had nothing to do. I was just an extra background like I was supposed to be. But even those movies, I would watch what people did. I constantly would watch what people did. So during that period—I can't believe I'm still talking; I'm boring myself to death—during that period, I started writing scripts. I wrote my first script about these kids that get into trouble. I wrote another script about young guys my age of thinking, "I can act in these movies." A couple of comedies they were.
- 6.53 The first script I wrote ever almost got made. I think I was 18 or 19. It almost got made by a man named Sonny Grosso. He had a production company in New York. Sonny Grosso was actually the cop in *The French Connection* that was played by Roy Scheider. The real Sonny Grosso was a detective. He eventually started a production company and started making movies. He made a lot of movies in New York City, some pretty big movies, and his company really liked my script.

- 6.54** I went in to talk to him about it. He knew my father. When I go in, a lot of times I would go in, everyone said, "Your father's Tony Lip." Everyone knew my father somehow. I don't know how everyone knew my father. He said, "But I didn't call you in here because I know your father, because I think this is really good." He goes, "But I don't get it. There should be cops and people getting killed." I go, "Well, it's a teen comedy. It's about a guy getting out of college looking for a job." "I know, I know. But it's really good. It's really well written. It's really good. But I don't make these type of movies. But I wanted you to come in here because I wanted to tell you it was really good."
- 6.55** It still showed me, okay, the first script I wrote, he goes, "If I made these type of movies, I would make this movie." He goes, "But you should get this around." And I tried a couple of things. I never got that one done, but I kept writing. I said that he validated, at least me writing a script. Maybe that script doesn't get made, but maybe my next one will.
- 6.56** I think I told you a story. I think the next one I wrote was the one I wrote and sent—I found Arnold Schwarzenegger's agent in some directory. That time, it wasn't online. I found a directory of agents in Hollywood, and it said his agency was ICM and his agent's name. I cold-called. I got someone on the phone. I said, "Yeah, I have this script." "Okay, here's our address. Send it to us." Arnold Schwarzenegger's agent called me up. I'm like 19 years old. I'm in my room by myself staring at my Rocky posters, and he calls me up on my house phone. They read the script. It didn't happen, but they read the script.
- 6.57** So again, my point is, you have to try. You have to say, "Well, it's impossible. You can't get to Arnold Schwarz." He was at his height. But the guy called me. He said, "I like the script." And I think I told this before—"Is this set up anywhere? Do you have financing?" I'm like, "I'm going to go to McDonald's in 5 minutes. I'll get a slice of pizza. I have no financing." But I kept—it made me keep trying. So I kept going and going and going, acting, writing, doing plays, making short films on my own. That's what I say now, you have no excuse to not do that. Editing my own stuff, I learned how to edit.
- 6.58** Then I met some people in New York working on a film. There was a director, he needed a script. He had a title and a basic idea, and he asked me to write it, and they brought me to California. This was late in life for me. By 30 years old, usually your career is—I was still knocking around like I was a 17-year-old idiot, and I was 29. But I came out, I wrote the script. They paid me to write it. It almost got made.
- 6.59** But while I was in LA, I got cast in a play, a pretty big play, with an actor named Richard Schiff, who won an Emmy for *The West Wing*. It was him and I. They were doing a play in New York at the Met with Sean Penn and Harvey Keitel and Lorraine Bracco and Madonna. It was a play called *Goose and Tom-Tom*, written by David Rabe, a big playwright who wrote a couple of big movies also.

- 6.60 They were doing the LA version of that. I got cast in the Harvey Keitel role. Richard Schiff got cast in the Sean Penn role. Richard Schiff went on to win [an Emmy]. He's a massively big actor right now. And it was him and I doing that. So I got cast in that. I was there doing that. I got some small part on a TV, a guest-star show. So I was out there to write the scripts, but I was starting to work.
- 6.61 Next thing I know, I called home one day, and my mother said, "Your father's gone." I said, "What do you mean, my father's gone?" "Oh, he left. He took your car, and he went into your room and took a TV and a computer, and he's driving it out to you in California." So he comes out, and he goes, "Yeah, you can't come back." He goes, "Your mother's losing her mind that you're gone, but you can't come back. Don't come back. Here's your car, here's your TV, here's your computer. Stay here and follow your dreams." So they encouraged me to do that, which was great.
- 6.62 I did the usual thing. I'm writing scripts, I'm acting, I'm working nights, and I started writing some scripts. I think the first one was Deadfall, which I discussed. I wrote it with Nicolas Cage's brother, and that got made into a pretty big movie, but they changed it a lot. I think that's what caused it to not do so well.
- 6.63 Then all of a sudden, I was back to, okay, I'm going to go back working in a nightclub. It's not like you get, "Oh, my dream. I got this huge movie made with all these people." It was one of those, "We can't pay you a lot of money, but you want to get made or not?" "Okay, don't pay me. Just make it." It was one of those because you have to do that. You've got to get something done. But I still had that done. So it got me some other writing jobs.
- 6.64 It got me to do another small film by a producer named Cassian Elwes, who's one of the most prolific producers in Hollywood. He's the king of independent films, and he ran William Morris for a long time. The independent film division made a lot of sales of movies at film festivals. He gave me my first opportunity to direct a movie that I wrote, a small little thriller. I'm still working with him to this day. He's going to work with me on that John Travolta movie that I was talking about. So I got that little film made, where I directed a film on my own.
- 6.65 But I realized, it's another studio. They make me change this, change that. I felt it was killing the script. It was a small movie with a small budget, but I still was aspiring to make something good, which then led me to make another movie.
- 6.66 I wrote a movie that I could shoot in 12 days. I raised, somehow, \$200,000, and I made a little movie like that. That might be one of the best little movies that I made. I went to a bunch of film festivals, but I still had to keep going back to doing a part-time job, working in a nightclub. I just didn't give up. I just said, "I'm going to keep doing this now." That lasted a long time. Along the way, I'd occasionally get this movie made, sell this script a little bit, make another movie.

- 6.67** All of it, I was thinking, "Okay, this is leading me somewhere. Should I quit?" Many times I wanted to quit. Many, many, many times. I didn't get married. I didn't have kids, all the things I thought are important in life that I wanted to do. But this career, for whatever reason, was compelling me to just follow it.
- 6.68** I thought, "Well, I'm not successful enough to get married or have kids. If I have to sleep on a couch and I still wanted to make a movie, I can't put a wife through that or a family. I would have to get a regular job. I wouldn't do this anymore." So it would hit me. I go, "I have to make a decision. Do I want to do this anymore?"
- 6.69** I kept wanting to—so long story short, I kept going, kept going, kept going. Many, many times, as I mentioned, I wanted to stop. So ultimately, I didn't stop. And that was when I took Green Book, and we're going to do a whole full lecture on just Green Book alone. So it's about fighting. Is it worth it? It happened to me late in life.
- 6.70** I'm still trying to get movies made. I haven't made a movie since Green Book. That's seven years ago, almost. It's almost seven years ago now. So I'm still writing off of this, which luckily, that opened a lot of doors for me as far as doing writing jobs. So it's been enabling me to keep going, but still tough. I think of myself as an independent filmmaker. I'm not really a studio person. I'm not affiliated with a studio. I'm still out there on my own, trying to raise money and get movies made. Now with a little bit of a backdrop. So here I am. And again, questions?
- 6.71** I think we all face, at times, when we want to give up because we're putting everything, our all, blood, sweat, tears, every single day, sacrifices. How do you particularly cope with the downs? Because sometimes it can be so overwhelming. You're just like, "Why am I doing this anymore? Why do I continue to audition and read and write and do all these things?" I mean, it usually passes when I do it, but how do you particularly cope with that, to get yourself out?
- 6.72** For me, the only way is faith because it goes back to scripture again. I don't want to keep coming back to these things, what it does. If you're asking me, it's like anything in life. A lot of tragedies. Everyone has tragedies. Everyone has things that go wrong all the time. So whenever something is really bad, or I start feeling sorry for myself—"Why, why, why, why, why?" I read the Book of Job. "Why?" "Why? Where were you when I created the heavens and the earth? Where were you? What have you done?" It centers me.
- 6.73** For me, I go, "You know what? I'm blessed. Even when things are bad, I'm blessed." There's always someone worse off than me. There's people that don't have food, there's homeless people, there's whatever. Everyone has death in life. You have to know that that's going to come. That doesn't mean you can't grieve and you can't be horribly hurt by the loss of someone. But friendships go, relationships go, people die, people pass away.

- 6.74** Obstacles, you think you're going to—I had a movie set up, and we're about to start, money falls out. You go, "How do I keep moving forward? But how do I not keep moving forward?" I put it in God's hands, pray about it, fight through it. If you can have the same level—if you can keep it this way [gestures a steady, level line]. There's ups, there's downs, but I try to keep it like this [gestures a steady, level line]. "Okay, what's God got in store for me today? Try to be the best person I can." Oh, someone just hit me in the back of the head with a baseball bat. Yeah, I go down. I go down. But it's like Rocky. He goes down. He's got to get up. Got to get up. Got to pull yourself up.
- 6.75** Otherwise, what's the point? You've got to keep moving forward. You can't accomplish anything good if you stop. A lot of bad things can happen for a long time. For a long time. I don't expect, I didn't expect to win those. That's a gift. But that doesn't mean every day I'm going to be winning those. Like I said, I haven't made a movie since then. But that doesn't stop me from wanting to make a movie. It doesn't stop me from trying to make a movie. I just keep taking the steps.
- 6.76** But faith, for me, is what's important. That's what keeps me going. It keeps me grounded as much as possible. But I'm human. I get mad, I yell, I scream, I do that, but I do it less when I bring myself back to, "Wait a minute, stop. God's in control." Just be the best I can be. Do the things I have to do. Keep writing, keep working, working really, really hard.
- 6.77** Work really, really, really hard. The fact that you're here shows you're taking the time. I don't know if I'm going to teach anything; maybe you should take a better class than mine. But it shows that you want to learn. You want to take in as much as you can do, because ultimately, all this that you're hearing from me or anyone else or any of the books I said, read these, any of the films that you see, it's still ultimately, you've still got to do the work.
- 6.78** I find myself procrastinating all the time. I have to stop myself from procrastinating. I go, "I know I've got to write today. I have to do this. What's on YouTube? All right, well, let me just read a little Bible." No, I've got to write. It doesn't get written unless you write it. Like I said, you've got to start. Just get in there and write.
- 6.79** But I'm human, too. I could talk about it and tell you guys to do it, but I do it myself. "I don't know what to write. I can't write anything." But then I just force myself. I just force myself to do it. So again, it's working hard. It's taking each day one by one. There's a reason Jesus says that yesterday is gone. Tomorrow, you can't count on. Deal with today. Be the best person you can be. If you have this dream, if you have this aspiration, and even if it's just a hobby and you go, "I want to try to write a script," then make it a priority. Take the time to do it.
- 6.80** Do the Stephen King thing. I'm not good at that, but Stephen King said, "Get up in the morning, set aside two to three hours or one hour, and just write something for the one hour. But do it every day." Because in two to three weeks, you're going to look at

all these pages that you have that you would not have had if you skipped that one day. So that's how I try to do it anyway, until I get really upset. But yeah, that's basically it.

- 6.81** How did you sell yourself as a writer? How did you sell yourself as a director?
- 6.82** The directing thing, listen, I just made little films, and then, at one point, when I did that—it was called *A Brilliant Disguise*, I think, was the movie, after I made *Deadfall*, I knew I have to direct my own films at some point because you can't control—or if you're just writing, it gets out of hand, right? I'm not going to direct everything I write because some of them I'm only writing to just maybe make some money. But I do care about everything I write. Pretty much I want to direct everything I write.
- 6.83** So at one point, I just said, "I'm directing the movie." It was at Cassian Elwes. I thought, "Okay, I'm going to have this big fight because I want to say, 'Cassian, I need to direct this movie.'" I've never directed a movie before, but I knew I needed to direct the movie. I thought, "How am I going to fight him? What's the story I'm going to give him? How am I going to defend myself?" I went to his office that day, and I said, "Listen, I really think I should direct this movie. I mean, I wrote it, I think—" he went, "Okay." He goes, "Yeah, okay, you can direct it." I go, "Don't you want it?" He goes, "No. It's all right. You can direct it?" I said, "Yeah." He goes, "Okay, you're the director." So that's how it happened for me.
- 6.84** But I still face that. With some bigger budgets, they say, "Why are you directing?" Well, now I've directed enough stuff, and I have reels, and I have bigger actors that I've directed before and worked with some good cinematographers, and the things look good. The content is good. So now I have reels, like an actor has a reel—I should show the director's reel.
- 6.85** But after this, I'm just not going to show it. I just say, "I'm directing the movie. If you don't want me to direct the movie, then I'm not making the movie with you." I've reached that point. But if you want to direct, if you think, "Oh, I'd like to direct my own screenplay," but you've never directed anything, direct a short. Write 10 minutes, get it done, get it done on an iPhone, get it done, maybe get some people together. Shoot it, edit it together, cut it. You have something to show.
- 6.86** Even if it's a stand-alone type of thing, I say do 10 minutes of something, or it's a piece of 10 minutes of a script that you eventually want to do bigger. Just do it, direct it, have it. "All I want to do is direct." "Well, what have you ever directed?" "Here you go. I directed that. I can do it." So it's like anything else. You can't show that you're a writer if you don't write the script. You've got to just do it. You have to have something to show. That would be my advice for that.
- 6.87** That leads right into my second part of the question, which is, having worked with a number of well-known directors and well-known actors before, well, before right here becoming a writer and now also becoming a director, what have you learned as well as

maybe even changed about how you direct actors, especially with the content that you write?

- 6.88** Again, I think being an actor myself, luckily for me, or the one I was allowed to act, but doing a lot of theater and acting and being directed by other directors, I understand actors.
- 6.89** So I, for the most part, try to leave them alone. If I'm casting them, that's half the battle. I mean, John Huston, the guy you've never heard of, he said that 90% of his casting process is finding the right actor. He trusts them. You've got to let them bring—they're not going to say the lines exactly as you have them in your head, but that's okay.
- 6.90** My direction to actors is that I like to have rehearsals. Sidney Lumet was big on rehearsals, Francis Ford Coppola was big on rehearsals, because I like to rehearse it as a play anyway. Because if there are questions about dialogue or does something rewrite, I'll have readings before that.
- 6.91** But even once I cast my actors, you still want to have rehearsals because once you put it up on its feet, and the guy's walking around, and people are talking, and who's moving, you go, "Okay, maybe we've got to change that dialogue. You don't even have to say that line because the way you smashed the chair down, I got the line." All these things start to change. But you have to let the actors bring what they bring.
- 6.92** Different people do it different ways. I talked about Christopher Walken telling me how he doesn't use any stage directions in the script. He doesn't follow periods or commas or anything. He just does his own cadence to the lines. It may be a question, and he doesn't even say it as a question. But he's a brilliant actor, and that's what makes his character so special. What he brings to it, the difference he brings to it.
- 6.93** So I think as a director, you have to have the understanding of once you've cast the people, then you've got to let them go. Then occasionally, you've got to nudge them this direction, nudge them that direction.
- 6.94** I saw Gene Hackman—I think it was on Johnny Carson or Jay Leno—one time talking about directors. They asked him, "How do you feel about directors? You go in, film a movie, and there's a director telling you what to do." He goes, "The most I'll take from a director is a little louder, a little lower." He goes, "The rest, I know what I'm doing." So how do you direct them?
- 6.95** But it is different. There's a couple of great actors. I worked with Tom Berenger and Louis Gossett Jr. Do you know Tom Berenger and Louis Gossett Jr? Look them up, watch the movies. Both of them, I was directing them, two separate movies. But those are the only actors that I just said, "I'm not saying a word to them."
- 6.96** Then Berenger, the first time, was like—I saw him doing the character, and it was a little different than what I expected, but I'm like, "Okay, let me go with it." But I could

see he was struggling. So this is when we were filming, because with him, I didn't have access to do rehearsals. He just came. But a great actor whom I respect. Just a great actor. I'm not saying a word to him. I'm going to go.

- 6.97** But he said to me, "How do you want this, this guy? How do you want me to do it?" I'm like, "What do you mean?" He goes, "Tell me. I want you to tell me." I was afraid to tell him. Because how am I going to tell Tom Berenger what to do? He goes, "No, tell me how you want him." I go, "I just think he's pissed off all the time." He goes, "Okay." Then he did his performance, which was amazing. An amazing performance.
- 6.98** Lou Gossett Jr., the first day on the set. Honored. Lou Gossett Jr., Academy Award winner. What's the one he won the Academy Award for, Lou Gossett Jr.? Yeah, look up that movie. So he's sitting there. We're about to do the scene, and he said the same thing to me. He goes, "What do you want?" I go, "What do you want?" He goes, "No, what do you want?" I said, "I want you to do whatever you want." He goes, "Okay, I got it." Then he was amazing. But he did want me to tell him something. He even wanted to hear me say, "Bring to it what you bring to it." I mean, what am I going to tell Lou Gossett Jr.? How can you even talk to an actor like that?
- 6.99** So I try to do that with all the actors. It doesn't matter how big they are. I try to give them that respect. But occasionally, you have to guide them. You have to move something. If a scene is not working right, you have to correct it and modify it. You are there to direct. You're directing the cameras, but you're also directing the performance. You've got to direct if some of the dialogue doesn't work right there and then.
- 6.100** But that's why I think rehearsals are important because you can get rid of those type of issues a lot once you put it on its feet, once you hear it. Remember, we were talking about the spoken word, how powerful the spoken word is. Because you're writing the words is one thing, but then when it's coming out of someone's mouth, it changes just about everything of how you handle it.
- 6.101** If you have the luxury of doing rehearsals, on low-budget movies, you usually don't. On low-budget movies, many times, you're there the day that you have to shoot, you meet the actor for the first time. You've never seen them before, you've never talked to them before. That's in low-budget films. That's just the way it goes. But you've got to trust the actors. I do have the respect for the actor. Hopefully, then I can just concentrate on the cinematography and working with the DP and then getting the performance.
- 6.102** That's a whole other thing. How do you get the actor's performance? We're going off screenwriting, but I always try to have two cameras, maybe three, because sometimes when people are talking to each other, something's happening between us. But if I only have a camera on you, but my character or the other character is doing something really good, and I go turn around on him, and he doesn't do it that way again. So I try to capture the feelings that the actors bring together. We'll put them on the screen

together, make sure I get a shot of the two of them all the time, hopefully try to cover them each together in a take so that if they overlap, there's a mistake, they talk over each other. If you do that separately, you can't cut around that. But you want that realism of talking over each other. That may be doing something to the scene.

- 6.103** So you have to let the actors do what you've got to do as a director. You have to make sure you cover them responsibly because if they have a moment, like we talked about that Dustin Hoffman moment when Sidney Lumet said to me, "He's going to do it, and we've got to have the shot. You cannot not get that handcuff on that wrist when Dustin Hoffman has his moment, when he hits it." Because Sidney Lumet knew, "Hoffman is going to bring it. I've just got to capture it." That's when you're making the film. Those are the type of responsibilities as a director that you have to do.
- 6.104** So the first film that I want to make is an Italian mob movie.
- 6.105** We need more of those.
- 6.106** Yeah, I really like that culture. Goodfellas is one of my favorite movies. And I wanted to ask you, since you're an expert on it, I wanted to say, how do I venture into that culture without being Italian or without knowing that much about it? What are some tips for, specifically, Italians, and then a general tip for different cultures?
- 6.107** Okay, well, I mean, you obviously like the culture. You like mob movies, right? Keep studying mob movies. Read mob books. Nick Pileggi, who wrote the screenplays for Goodfellas and for Casino and many other great movies, he wrote the books of those films. So I would read those books. I would read the books. I'd watch all the greatest gangster movies that you can, all the Scorsese movies, all the Coppola movies. There's other ones. There's Brian De Palma, The Untouchables. There's all kinds.
- 6.108** Immerse yourself in the world. Immerse yourself in it. Study them. I mean, if there's a particular story in that world that you want to tell, is it based on a true story? Or you're making it up in your mind? However you want to do it, again, you don't have to be Italian to write a movie about Italians.
- 6.109** Marlon Brando played the greatest Italian role ever written. He was not Italian, Marlon Brando. He played the Godfather, which connects to Viggo Mortensen playing my father. "Oh, we have to have an Italian to play my father." Viggo Mortensen wasn't Italian. Look at what he did with the role. So you don't have to be Italian to write about that culture, if that's what you want to do.
- 6.110** It's an easy answer, I guess. Anyone would tell you this: immerse yourself in that world. Goodfellas, Casino, watch every Scorsese movie, Mean Streets, all the Coppola films, like I said, Brian De Palma. And there's other great gangster movies. Go back to the '30s and '40s and watch old-time gangster movies. Watch the progression of how they are.
- 6.111** I don't know if your story is like—I don't know anything about your story. But watch other things. It doesn't have to be—they don't have to actually connect to your story.

They could just be cultural. But reading the books, too, will give you a deeper understanding of that type of stuff. You're welcome.

- 6.112** So when you're faced with a situation in which an opportunity is there, for example, you met this person, and that person said, "Let's do a movie." Where did you start? Did you start with like, "Okay, let me analyze you as a person and what we want to talk about." Do I start with the structure? Do I start with the theme? What is it that like, "Okay, this is the thing that I'm going to start, and here's I'm going to continue?"
- 6.113** I'm writing a couple of biopics. One is Connie Francis, who passed away this past year, and I was working on something for her. She got very, very popular again with this song, "Pretty Little Baby." It was a TikTok phenomenon, and there's like a billion hits on this thing. She didn't even remember recording that song, by the way. She was like, "That was like a B-side of the first album," but it became this huge thing last year. So I had her that I personally spoke to, which is lucky for me, like I had my father and Dr. Shirley for Green Book. Her I spoke to.
- 6.114** You want to honor the person. We're talking about how do you write a movie about a real person. Is that what you're trying to say? You've got to honor that person, you've got to get to know them. But you have to also—Connie Francis had a lot of tragedies in her life, and you have to show all that as well. You've got to show the ups and downs. You've got to show the true person, I think, if you're going to really do something compelling.
- 6.115** Over the course of your life, you were exposed to opportunities. There are some people who say, "Create your own opportunities." There had to be a melding of those things in there where you said yes to the opportunities that you saw, but you also mentioned that there was an intuitive underneath drive that this was the thing. Can you describe a little bit more about that intuitive process and what that thing felt like enough that it motivated you to keep going?
- 6.116** Yes. I mean, again, it's scary, too, because what if my intuition is wrong? What if I'm wrong? What if you're wrong? What if I thought I wanted to do all this stuff, but it was wrong? But I put myself out there. Extra work, background work. People would say, "I'm never doing extra work. I'm an actor. I go on auditions, and that's it." Well, I could have said that. How many missed opportunities I would have had?
- 6.117** Chazz Palminteri, again, a great actor, great writer, we talk about this, and Chazz says, "Anything that you can go to, go. Go." He says to me, "Go." I almost didn't go to the Academy Awards, which I'll get into that story when we talk about Green Book. I wasn't going to go to it. He's like, "What do you got? Your mind? Go. Go. You have to go. You don't know what's going to happen unless you go. Unless you do something, you're never going to know what's going to happen."
- 6.118** So the same thing for that. When I was younger, I'm not getting acting jobs. I'm not doing a play now. What am I doing? What does it hurt me to go? I don't believe

anything is beneath you. It's like a movie set. The PA that throws out the garbage, you need that guy. He's not any lower than the director to me. I try to tell this on the small films I've directed, I tell everyone, "Everyone here is important. Every extra is important. Otherwise, you wouldn't be here. Every cog in the wheel is important."

- 6.119** So when I used to go do the extra work or work on a set—I had an acting teacher. Jimmy Voss used to say to me, "What are you doing? What are you doing? You should be doing plays." Because I was late for class. "Why are you late for class?" "Well, I was doing this extra in Sidney Lumet." "What? Extra? Why? Why would you do that? You want to be an actor? You want to be an extra?" Now, on one level, she had a point, but on the other level, to me, it was, well, what else am I doing? I could be home in New Jersey watching television or going to work in my father's pizzeria, or I could be on a set where something may or may not happen, or worst case, I learn something. I watch something, and I learn.
- 6.120** So, to answer—what was your question? Nobody knows. It's all right. But we got through it, right?. Okay. So we have a couple more to do. Thank you.

Lecture 7: Meaningful Writing

At a glance — Meaningful writing.

- 7.1 Hi, everybody. We're going to start this one today. I've talked about different movies and different books and literature and how scripts and stories are affected by what was brought up in the past and written in the past. I thought about this. I wasn't sure if I was going to do it, but I think it's important. I'm going to talk today about A Christmas Carol.
- 7.2 The reason I'm going to talk about A Christmas Carol is because we talked about all the things that as far as Greek tragedies and Shakespeare and the Bible, and then what we're doing now today. But this falls right in the middle of the timing when this was written, what it was written about. So, I thought it was important to mention it.
- 7.3 I won't go into much detail with this as we did with the others, but A Christmas Carol, written by Charles Dickens. And this is a little book that I pulled some information from. It's called [52] Little Lessons from A Christmas Carol by Bob Welch. They do these books. I was talking about It's a Wonderful Life also. They have one on It's a Wonderful Life also, which is a really great book.
- 7.4 They break down the stories, and they tell you a lot of what I was talking about. I went to these for some of my information, just as I did with all of the books that I showed you earlier. I used a lot of those for my research.
- 7.5 How Charles Dickens turned Christian theology into a defining modern myth. We talked about great opening lines. "There is no doubt that Marley was dead. This must be distinctly understood or nothing wonderful can come of the story I am going to relate." Much like Citizen Kane that we talked about, Marley's dead. He's starting us off with a dead character, but there's going to be a story behind this character.
- 7.6 Okay, so this Christmas Carol was started as an 1843 novella by Charles Dickens, and it's the story of Ebenezer Scrooge, a greedy miser who hates Christmas, but who's transformed into a caring, kindly person through visitations of four ghosts, Jacob Marley and the Ghosts of Christmas Past, Present, and Future. This is a classic work. It's been dramatized and adapted hundreds, maybe thousands of times in virtually every medium you could possibly imagine. And new versions are constantly coming up.
- 7.7 A friend of mine, Jesse Corti, he's done for years in a row, A Christmas Carol, a theatrical performance. And he does it in one of the oldest churches in Hollywood, Hollywood Presbyterian Church. So it has this gothic feel to it. And they do the performances inside the church, and it's really magnificent. If you're in Los Angeles during Christmas, go see it.
- 7.8 This was written at a time of change because you had novels being written, but became — at an age when he wrote this, it was one of the biggest selling books ever. It was

really a mass-produced literature that had never been seen before that time. Other than the Bible, in a sense, the Bible was always being sold. This changed like modern pop culture at the time, like what we look at now, the internet. This book changed all that because everyone was reading it and everyone wanted to know this story.

- 7.9** It's a story that, again, it doesn't matter what you believe, what you don't believe. If you are religious, if you're not religious, it's in the consciousness of people. We know this story. It's a very theologically structured work. It's not scripture. It doesn't pretend to be anything close to scripture, but it's written to be similar to the parables taught by Jesus in the Bible. It in itself is a parable. It's telling you a story with a message, and you have to unravel this story to get the message.
- 7.10** It's not just about Christmas either. It's about the human soul and what happens when you move from death to life. But are we talking about actual physical death— we start with a dead guy, he's definitely dead. He says it at the beginning, he's definitely dead. Marley is dead. But when we talk about moving from death to life, what does that mean? Does it mean a spiritual death that we may be having while we're still alive and then coming back to life in that sense?
- 7.11** So he wrote this book in 1843, a time it was at a crossroads of Victorian England, which the industrial modern age was happening at that time. It's called the hinge moment in Western history. The old religious world was eroding at that time. It was changing. The modern secular world was coming into play with the advent of inventions and modern technology for that time.
- 7.12** The population was being reshaped. Factories were being built. Cities were being built. Economic systems that were never in place before. And they were treating people almost like expendable units. This is where the ideas of communism came. People were just workers for the industrial age that was beginning.
- 7.13** So Dickens understood something crucial: that this is affecting people, their hearts, their minds, and their souls. When they're treated like nothing, they're suppressed, and they're kept down. They're not nothing, but they were treated like nothing. We all have the same hearts. It doesn't matter. We talked about this. If you're rich, if you're poor, we're all the same people. We all go through the same emotions.
- 7.14** But it also connects to—we're going to get into the basic storyline, which most people know—but we're talking also about a Citizen Kane type of character. It's interesting how a lot of these movies that we've discussed, or at least I brought up, are about people that have a lot of money, or they fall, or they don't have a lot of money, and they rise and they fall. Even in *It's a Wonderful Life*, you have the Potter character who's trying to just take over the whole town, keep the people down, keep them in poverty, don't give them good housing opportunities.
- 7.15** All of these storylines keep being repeated, and they're repeated for a reason because they're lessons, because through generations, you learn the lessons from the time

you're around. So a lot of people don't look at this old literature—we're calling old—but it has to be redone constantly. And those are themes that people are constantly writing about and redoing because it touches human hearts and souls.

- 7.16** I've talked about all kinds of movies, and I keyed in on certain ones, and I talked about things I like to do. I'm trying to do uplifting stories. There's room for all kinds of movies and all kinds of stories, and you don't have to go deep into this type of stuff for everything you do. But somehow it creeps in, I think, because it's always about human beings. You're always going to have a good guy. You're always going to have a bad guy. Then it comes to why are they good? Why are they bad? Who's good? Who's bad and becomes good? These are the things that make the stories interesting.
- 7.17** This was like a change in society and also the change in how he wrote it and then how it could be mass-produced and gotten out to people on the level that it did for the first time.
- 7.18** They called it a bold literary experiment. He took some of the key moral logic from Christianity: sin, judgment, repentance, grace, transformation—and made it into a very emotional story, so vivid, so compelling. It re-upped people's spirituality. It was for the culture a very important thing. It gave people hope again. It was not that A Christmas Carol just reflected Christian values, but it embedded them again into the cultural imagination.
- 7.19** It doesn't open with a warm thing. It opens up with "Marley was dead" to begin with. So he repeats this. It's not there casually. It's there for a reason. As I said, Christianity doesn't just talk about physical death, but spiritual death. So Marley's death sets a tone for everything else that follows in this story, because Marley represents a soul that's ruined by the loss of love.
- 7.20** So Marley was like Scrooge. They were business partners. It was about the business. It was about money, money, money. So when Marley appears, he's not just a ghost. He's carrying the chains forged from cash boxes, ledgers, locks, keys—a symbol of his life, organized around possessions instead of communion and love for other people. So he's carrying all this weight on him.
- 7.21** It's an obvious thing. It's done physically so that you see it. So his chains are his bondage. And his bondage is not imposed by anyone but his own self. He forged his own bondage by his actions. So Scrooge comes to see this. He tells him, "I'm going to help you out. I'm going to send you these three spirits."
- 7.22** Scrooge is not like a cartoony type of villain. He's not really even a villain. He's just himself. He just has his way of life. And again, as we talked about in one of the hours, I don't know which one it was, we talked about how you put yourself in the place that you're in. You make choices. We also talked about not judging people, because when we finally get into Scrooge's story, we see what happened to him.

- 7.23** But he made choices, bad choices. He had a loss of love. He was going to get married. And his fiancée was talking to him about, "I don't see the love in you anymore. We never see each other. You're not around." "All I have to work, I have to work, I have to work, I have to work, I have to work. And she said goodbye. He was affected by that so much that he lost all his love. All his innocence was gone at that point. His life was all about what? Possessions, making money, right?
- 7.24** I brought this up because I was just going to do a Q&A session today, which we're going to get into. But I wanted to bring this up because it's touched so many people, this story. It has so many themes of what we've been discussing. There's so many—you're on a roller coaster ride, taken through this world, a parable to teach you what? What is your life? What are you going to do with your life? What do you want your life to be? What comes out of your mouth? The things you say, the things you do.
- 7.25** Scrooge has a couple of lines—I'm not even going to go off my own notes now. There's a couple of lines there where Scrooge is saying: "Well, people die. It decreases the surplus population. Oh, do we not have homes for these people? Can't they go to work? People work. I work hard every day. Why do I have to give money to poor people? Why are they poor? Because they're lazy."
- 7.26** So all these things are coming out of his mouth. Things he's saying, things he's feeling. But he didn't always feel that way. He was a young guy coming up, trying to work to make something of himself. So when we find out his past and what he did, we feel sorry for him. But also, if we track him, it's his decisions that got him where he is.
- 7.27** But even as an old man, as old as he is, there's still hope. We talked about the thief on the cross next to Jesus. One of them just said, "Hey, if you're God, get us down." The other one said, "No, you are God. Just remember me." His life changed then. It's never too late. He, as an old man, when he sees, he's allowed to see what his future is, he asked for repentance. "I know I'm an old, bitter old man, but give me a chance and I will change."
- 7.28** It's different than—obviously, I think It's a Wonderful Life took from A Christmas Carol to a point. He doesn't get to see his past. But what George Bailey gets to see in A Wonderful Life is his life without him, how bad it was, how he affected people's lives.
- 7.29** Scrooge gets to see how he did affect people's lives badly, how his person got worse. Bob Cratchit loves him unconditionally. His wife says, "Why? Why do you put up with him? He's a miserable, miserable old man." He goes, "But look what we have. We have a family in love. He doesn't have that." The Tiny Tim character, obviously, a Christ-like character, innocent, innocent, filled with love, Scrooge gets to see—"What do you mean? He dies? That kid dies? Does that have to happen? Is that going to happen? What can I do to change to [not] make that happen?" So he gets an opportunity to change.

- 7.30** So I think the whole point of this exercise is, again, about life. It's about people, human condition that everyone goes through. All of us face these things. And I was talking about what you write. I'm not proud of a lot of things I did. I did movies that I'd never watch or see or write today. Why I did it at the time, you think, "Oh, I've got to move forward. I've got to do this. I've got to do that." You make excuses for everything. But that's life in general.
- 7.31** We make choices. And a lot of times, we make bad choices. But I think that everyone does this. So we all reach a point where we go, "Wait a second—at least I have, for me—why am I doing this? What am I trying to accomplish? What am I putting out in the world?"
- 7.32** I love all kinds of movies, and thousands and thousands of movies don't follow any of the things I've been talking about in these hours that we've been speaking about. Some of them don't even have—not that they don't have a clue. They don't have a care either about it. They're just writing, "Let me write a great action movie. Let me write a funny comedy. Let me write a brutal war movie, death, destruction." Or maybe there's no theme or rhyme or reason in their thought process. And that's valid for them.
- 7.33** But I think even if they don't know it, there is, because we're putting out things into the world. So what comes out of your mouth is important. What you put on that page is important because it's going to come out of someone else's mouth. You're telling people, "Say these words, do these things."
- 7.34** So just be careful with what you do. Take a real heart. This matters. People are going to read this. People may perform this. People may act this out. People are going to see this. What do I want to put into the world? That's how I look at it. And I'm going to say, again, everything I've said here, you could have another teacher. They could have hired someone else to do this, and maybe they will after they watch all this. But that will have a totally different approach from what I said.
- 7.35** There's some things that you can't get around: the technical aspect of it, how the script is formatted, all of that. But as far as reasons why you write and feelings, what you're trying to say, some people aren't trying to say anything. They just want to make a raunchy comedy. And those are valid, too. It's all valid. But I'm here talking about my journey, which we got into a little bit yesterday. And we're going to talk about Green Book, the whole journey of Green Book. So it's only from my perspective. All of this comes from me. So take what you get from me.
- 7.36** Discard what you don't like. Use what is good. Look into other books or people. There's plenty of screenwriting courses now, and maybe there's guys doing it 10,000 times better than I am. This is the approach that I took because this is how I feel in my heart, and I also feel that you're going to start writing. You're all people here at different ages, and men, women, at different points of your lives.

- 7.37** Why are you writing? What do you want to say with your writing? What can you do? And I also talked about how words are so important that they last. They last forever. We talked about the Bible lasting forever. We talked about Shakespeare lasting forever. This story lasts forever. It's done over and over and over and over and over again. And there's a reason for that. Why is it those types of stories last forever?
- 7.38** You may love some raunchy comedy. You may love some great horror movie. I don't know if that affects lives, though. It might be fun at the moment. It's like the popcorn you eat at a theater I love going to a movie, just eating popcorn and seeing a crazy movie. I love action movies. I love horror movies. I love all kinds of movies. But along my journey, I'm finding that, okay, but I only have a certain amount of time here. I only have a certain amount of movies that I believe God is going to let me make. What am I going to do with my time? What am I going to do with my whatever little gift I have or opportunity that I've been given to say something and put it out in the world?
- 7.39** So that's why there's certain literature, film, plays, music that is going to last, and then some is going to just be forgotten and fallen by the wayside. This, to connect it to movies, has been done so many times. The plays have been done for thousands, I mean, thousands of them, different plays. And let's talk about some of the films that were made from this that I think stand out. There were movies of this made from 1910. They were making movies on this. In the '30s, there's one, but the one that stands out for me, the first one I ever saw was on TV all the time at Christmas time was Scrooge.
- 7.40** They called it Scrooge, and it was made in England, and they retitled it A Christmas Carol in the US. It's in black and white, which gives it a very cool sense of putting you back in this time period. It stars Alastair Sim as Scrooge. And even to this day, some of them regard that version of the film, the best adaptation of the book ever made of that classic.
- 7.41** Scrooge in 1970 was a musical version with Albert Finney, great Albert Finney as Scrooge, and Alec Guinness, Obi-Wan Kenobi, as Marley's Ghost. That's an excellent one to watch. George C. Scott, who played Patton, won the Academy Award for Patton. An amazing actor, George C. Scott. He did a version of A Christmas Carol in 1984. That's excellent also. It's crazy that I know all these. I watch them all. Holiday season, I can't—how many times can I watch It's a Wonderful Life? I watch A Christmas Carol, usually also.
- 7.42** The Muppet Christmas Carol is another musical film featuring the Muppets with Michael Caine as Scrooge. That's a very funny one. Really well done. Then there's Scrooged with Bill Murray, the 1988 film. It's a modern take on it with Bill Murray playing Scrooge. That's really funny and well done.
- 7.43** They did A Christmas Carol in 1999 with Patrick Stewart from the Star Trek movies. He played Scrooge. He had done a one-man play about this, and they were going to just

film that, but then they adapted it, and they put all the characters in. He was nominated for several awards for that. That's an excellent version.

- 7.44 Kelsey Grammer also did a musical version of A Christmas Carol, but he did it a little bit like The Wizard of Oz. They combined The Wizard of Oz with A Christmas Carol, which is a unique take on it, but an interesting take.
- 7.45 Have you ever seen the show Peaky Blinders? It's a dark, violent mobster show. Well, Stephen Knight, who wrote Peaky Blinders, did a version of A Christmas Carol. You would think a guy like that couldn't. But like I said, I don't like to be put in a box. There's a lot of talented people out there that can do lots of things. He eventually did Peaky Blinders, but he did A Christmas Carol with Guy Pearce as Scrooge. Andy Serkis, that you know from The Lord of the Rings was in that. Stephen Graham, who just won a couple of Golden Globes. That's a really great cast. That's A Christmas Carol with Guy Pearce.
- 7.46 Then my personal favorite of all time, believe it or not, version is Mr. Magoo's Christmas Carol with Jim Backus doing the voice of Mr. Magoo. It's a cartoon. It was in the 1960s. It's really a lot of fun.
- 7.47 So I was wondering, should I bring this up? But I think it combines what we talked about, the great literature that we've taken from the past to what scripts are done now and movies that we all like. This is right in the middle, and it's still out there, and it still lasts because it's important, because what he wrote was important. So words are important. As Tiny Tim says, "God bless us, everyone," and we'll continue on.
- 7.48 And today, what I wanted to do is get a lot of questions out of you guys to see about the overall everything we talked about. And just to go back to what I was mentioning earlier: what I've chosen certain movies to key on, certain aspects of how to write a script, there's thousands I'm missing.
- 7.49 I mentioned a lot of movies yesterday. I could have mentioned a hundred more movies that have affected my life that are great. I'm going to bang myself in the head and go, "I forgot this. How could I forget that? That was so important to me." There's so many great, great, great, great, great films. But look at the thread of them all. Look at ones the storylines that you go, "I didn't realize that those all have the same type of greedy characters."
- 7.50 There Will Be Blood—that movie from a few years ago, I think it was Paul Thomas Anderson with Daniel Day-Lewis. Amazing. Another story about a guy who becomes rich, and it gets harder. He gets hardened. A lot of these films have these same themes. My point is I could have mentioned a lot of great screenwriters that I just forgot, a lot of great directors and films, a lot more books.

- 7.51** At first I thought, how am I going to fill eight hours of this to talk about writing scripts? I thought it was impossible. I thought I would last eight minutes, and then they'd be yanking me out the door.
- 7.52** But there was a lot more to be learned about, a lot more to read. I talked about how reading is important. Read as much as you can. Like I said, when I was younger, I read a lot because there was some TV, there were no computers, there was nothing. You read. So I had that opportunity. But I still think that's important: get off the computer, get off the television, get off your phone and start reading books, especially if you want to write. You'll always glean something from as much reading as you can possibly do.
- 7.53** This course could have gone a lot of different ways. It went the way it did. That's how it's supposed to go. I might have missed some major things that you could learn. That's why I said: look into other courses, if you get the opportunity. Read other books. Those books that I said I'd never read, maybe read them. You might get a lot of good stuff out of those that I never got. So this is what it is. In the next hour, we're going to do the full Green Book story of how I got it there and how he got it made. I think that would be an interesting journey to see from soup to nuts, how getting a film made to a point of being blessed to win these awards.
- 7.54** When you were writing Green Book, did you receive any signs or synchronicities from God that let you know that this one would be different, that you were in alignment with Him?
- 7.55** Well, listen, I was always praying about it. That was my thing. We'll talk about this more later. I believed in this my whole life. When it started to happen, there were things that were going that I loved about it. There were obstacles. But all that time, I said, "I'm leaving this in God's hands." I had to be open, which we'll get into my reasons why I always wanted to direct it, blah, blah, blah. I made choices that I felt were better for the movie than for me myself. So yes, but I was constantly praying and asking for guidance and to make the right decisions and to pull back when I had to pull back because I'm a pretty big outspoken guy. But when you bring other people in to work with you, you have to be able to let them bring what they bring.
- 7.56** It's okay to argue. It's okay to fight for something, too. I fight for things also. But I also have very talented people around me. So, I was praying for more of what Solomon prayed for: wisdom. "Give me the wisdom to navigate this properly." So, yes, for myself, it was very conscious daily.
- 7.57** I've written my whole entire life since I was a little kid, and I've never had the outline in my head, I guess, to move forward, or I think maybe nobody wants to hear about my story.
- 7.58** Nobody does until you put it out there.

- 7.59 Exactly. But I want to thank you because it's really blossomed and planted some seeds in my head of how to move forward now. One particular thing, if you're writing about something that's sad, not uplifting too much, but there are uplifting parts in your story, how do you add levity to a very serious storyline? You can't have two—
- 7.60 Well, that's a broad question, but a valid question. First, you said nobody wants to hear—why would anyone want to hear this, right? Even for me now, if I'm writing a script now or if I'm going to direct a movie, I think, who wants to see it?
- 7.61 They don't know it exists until you put it out there. So it's all risk. It's any piece of art. It's taking this blank thing, and I hope in postproduction, and then you go like this, and all of a sudden, some stuff starts coming up there, whatever the director decides he's going to put there when I do that. But it's a blank canvas. It's a blank canvas until you put something on it, which we started this whole thing about the blank page. That's what I was talking about. So you've got to push yourself to do it. That's all there is to it. I keep repeating that same thing: you have to force yourself to do it. Get it out there. Spit it out, vomit it out, as I call it, a vomit drafter. Just get it all out.
- 7.62 Now, as far as refining it or if it's a sad story, a lot of people, those sad stories, people like those stories. Well, mostly women like the sad stories. But no, there's an audience for that, too.
- 7.63 You've also got to decide: Why are you writing this? Are you writing to get something out that's personal for you, that will help you ease your pain or maybe think it out? Is that the reasoning? Is it for entertainment purposes? Is it to teach a lesson that, "Hey, I went through this, and other people out there might be going through the same type of pain, so maybe I can explain my journey through it?" Whatever your reasons, get it out.
- 7.64 Can you put levity in it? There's levity in tragedy. That's why it's comedy, tragedy. You find a lot of levity in tragedy because sometimes I've gone to wakes, and then you talk about something that the dead person did, and the people are laughing. How could you laugh at a wake? But we're talking about a life and a funny event that happened. So life changes, moments change.
- 7.65 That would have to happen organically, too. I couldn't really give you an exact example because I would have to talk about the situation, but I couldn't make it up because if you're talking about something personal that even if you're fictionalizing something personal that happened to you and you're putting in made-up characters, you're still putting something that's coming from in here and in here. So you've just got to get it out there. And then you could worry about: Is this sad part funny or should it be funny? You're not going to know that until you get it out, get it out on paper and get your thoughts out. You know what I mean?
- 7.66 Because sometimes I've had things that started. It could be out of laziness that I didn't finish, or I just go, "I don't know where this is going." Most of the time, I have the whole thing in my head, though. You were saying, "I don't have an outline." I don't necessarily

write an outline. As I've said, that's my thing. But I can ruminate on it for a very, very, very long time. I've written scripts in 10 days; I've written scripts in two years. It changes. You don't get it sometimes. The ones that last long, it's because you don't have it in your head. Then I just powered through a couple of scripts, and I go, "Wow, that was good," or, "Wow, that's terrible, but it's out there. What can I use from it?"

- 7.67** But the whole point, again, is, and I think for this class and people watching, it's screenwriting 101. It's not screenwatching 101. You have to write it. Whatever you're writing, you have to write it. Period. Start writing it. "Oh, I want to lose weight and go to the gym." Go on a diet and go to the gym. You have to start it. You have to just do it. It seems such a simplistic answer, but that's all it is. You have to do it. You'll figure that out later on.
- 7.68** If you go by the tenets of, like I said, what I did through osmosis that implanted in us because we've seen so many movies, we've read so many books, it's a beginning, it's middle, it's an end. To simplify, whether it's a four-act structure, a five-act structure, act one and act one D. It's a beginning, it's a middle, it's an end, it's a journey. Take us on the journey.
- 7.69** You take yourself on the journey first. I think I started this whole thing with saying that It's you, that your characters are sitting there waiting for you to do something with them. They can't go anywhere without you doing it. But it's also your journey. Your journey of getting that script done is a journey. It's a story onto itself. You want to hear how I got Green Book made, which we're going to talk about. That's my personal journey.
- 7.70** Now, Brian Currie, co-writer, Peter Farrelly, co-writer, all three of us producers, Pete, the director, they may tell two completely different stories. They would tell two completely different stories because that's their journey of making the Green Book. It's going to be different from mine. And there might be some overlap, and there's going to be a lot of things that they're telling from their perspective that I never saw or thought of. They may be saying, "Oh, that Nick was a pain in the butt." Who knows? But everyone's journey is different, and you've got to tell your journey. Whether you're telling your journey through other characters or whatever it is, the only way to even question what you're doing or seeing if it's good is if you have it in front of you to look at and read.
- 7.71** How do you approach writing a scene that is seemingly driven by small talk, but is really layered in subtext or even a character beat that is still moving the story forward? For example, the fried chicken driving scene in Green Book.
- 7.72** Okay, well, that's a scene. Again, you can look at it that it's layered, and it is. There's a lot going on in that scene. It's about how my father loved life. Food was part of that love of life. He didn't care. What's the difference? We're eating it in the car. We're eating it in a fine dining restaurant. We're enjoying it. "Take it. Eat it. Eat it. Eat it."

"Well, I don't have a fork." "Oh, eat it. Who cares? We're in the car." That type of attitude in love of life.

- 7.73** My grandfather used to say it all the time, and I use that quote in the movie because my father used to repeat what he used to say. "When you work, work. When you sleep, sleep. When you eat, eat. Whatever you're doing, do it the best you can at that moment." Just live it. You're living at that moment. Do whatever you're doing the best you can do. We're here. "I got a bucket of chicken. You want some? What do you mean you're not going to eat it?" He couldn't even understand it. Don Shirley told me that story, because "I was appalled by your father. He ate so much and he just wouldn't stop."
- 7.74** But that scene, that back and forth dialogue on top of the actions that were happening, also talks about their differences. Like you said, it's funny dialogue. It's crazy dialogue. You're talking about fried chicken. But really, what are you talking about? You're talking about these two men are still at polar opposites. And there's something we can agree on: food. If the food is good, the food is good. If I can show you food, you've got your food that you might want me to taste.
- 7.75** So to get to that point, I mean, you can purposely design a scene like that, that you have dialogue that means nothing, but the undertones are something deeper. But that would be—I'd have to know. Are you making a mob movie, and they're talking about going to the grocery store and getting the butcher to cut up that steak? Or are they really talking about, "We're going to go down to the bar, and we're going to cut some guy's head off?" That's a good scene. I might use that somewhere. My point is that.
- 7.76** So then you're doing it purposely, and you're using characters that are double-talking for a reason. It all would depend on your scene and your characters and what you're trying to say. Can you do it on purpose? Yeah, of course. Well-thought-out scripts and dialogue do that. Great writers do that. But yes, you can obviously put that in a scene. Every scene is different. Every scene has a purpose. That's the thing. The other thing is, why are you writing the scene? You've got to give information, which is boring sometimes. So sometimes, if you can give the information in a great way.
- 7.77** I write a lot of dialogue. If there's one thing people like about my scripts, it's the dialogue. The stories are not important to me. It's people talking because I think people talk every day. We love talking to each other. There's friends of mine that go, "Oh, you're going to talk for 8 hours? Oh, my God." I do a lot of talking, but people do talking. That's how we communicate. The word—as we kept telling—the words that come out of our mouth. That's what interests us. That's what moves us. That's how we get into relationships. That's how we express ourselves, mostly through words. So the dialogue is important.
- 7.78** But just dialogue for the sake of dialogue isn't important. Even when I have dialogues doing monologues, to me, it's important. Every word is important. So there's also great

scenes—and that's why I say, look at some silent films. Look at Charlie Chaplin films. How are they making those films? There was no dialogue. Silence, because they're movies. Now we're talking movies as opposed to screenplays in the sense, but the screenplay for that silent movie still had to be written. So how do you express things—feelings, emotions—with no dialogue?

- 7.79** Tarantino, big dialogue guy, big dialogue guy. Amazing, fantastic dialogue. Loves to hear his character speak. Actors love when you give them a lot of dialogue. I'm not going to name names. I know certain actors, they just go, "When do I start talking, first of all? When do I come in? Oh, here. How much do I have to say? I'm not saying enough. I need to say more," because they want to hear themselves speak.
- 7.80** But whatever drives the story, whatever drives your script—and it could be silence. We talked about Lawrence of Arabia; one line is 20 minutes in the movie. The French Connection has that type of thing, too. So sometimes it's the filmmaking. Silence is important. Dialogue is important. It's all important. It all depends on what story you're telling and how you want to tell it.
- 7.81** Look at 2001: A Space Odyssey. At the end of that movie, there's a computer throwing out some words. The main character is not saying anything. There's such a long stretch where there's no talking. It's what you're watching. But even that had to be written in a way to compel people to see the movie when they were reading the script. Stanley Kubrick, he's going to get the movie made, but he's making it for himself. He's really writing it for himself to follow, because at that point, he didn't care what anyone thought about his scripts.
- 7.82** But there's all kinds of different movies: character-driven movies, love stories, romantic comedies, sad romantic films that end tragically. What do we want to know about? What are the people saying? What are they thinking? How do these people fall in love? You can do a movie where people fall in love at first sight, and it's physical. But then what happens to that, eventually they've got to start talking to each other. Eventually, they have to learn about each other. That's why we watch romantic movies. We want to see people get together. Or we want to say, "No, that guy is bad for her. She's talking to the wrong guy. The other guy that works in the pizzeria is the guy, but she doesn't know it, but she's attracted to the flashy guy. No, talk to him."
- 7.83** It's all human nature. It's all a human dilemma. It's all things that we all go through every day. It's never changed. It's never changed, all these human emotions. That's why we're still telling stories.
- 7.84** That's why The Odyssey is going to be a giant movie this summer. Again, The Odyssey, the first thing, one of the oldest manuscripts we have of all time. It's still making it because the human behavior has never changed: love, death, pain, wealth, poverty, all of it. It all goes to the Bible, it all goes back to Shakespeare, it all goes back to Greek tragedies, still telling the same stories over and over again.

- 7.85** So can you use dialogue, like I said, to either trick your audience or just use it as a device for something else that really means you're saying one thing, but you mean something else. Of course, you can do that. That's your job as a screenwriter to put it out there, to express what you want to express.
- 7.86** So yesterday, you talked a lot about how Rocky changed your life and how he won the movie, even though he didn't technically win the fight, but he still won in his mind. What was a moment in your life that you had that reflected that and how did it change you, and what can you teach us about it?
- 7.87** I already cried in this class. I'm not going to—really? Listen, I guess, again, I'm going to do a whole Green Book thing, but obviously, there's many. Green Book is one of those, but I'll talk about another one.
- 7.88** The first time I got a movie made or I was directing a movie, really—more the first time I was directing—I had my whole family there. My mother was there, my father was there, I had aunts and uncles, my brother, everyone was there. So you have a dream for a long time to do something, and then it's actually happening. It's a validation, and obviously, it's a great, heartfelt feeling.
- 7.89** Having my mother on the set was something because on the first day we had the catering truck, and my mother was like, "This food, all these people, they're working, so this is what they're eating?" "No, no, no, no." The next day, she's bringing trays of lasagna, pasta. She started taking over the cooking. So moments like that, you can't really put a monetary amount or something like that. Those are just life moments.
- 7.90** And then it also makes you go, even if the movie wasn't great, the experience of making the movie was great. Sometimes that happens. Sometimes the movie's not great, but the experience is great. Sometimes the movie's great, but you fought like heck to get there. It's a battle, and you're beat up after it's done.
- 7.91** They're all different, but it's all a fight. I'm still in a fight to get movies made. It's not like, "Oh, I won a couple of statues, and they're throwing money at me." In my case, that's not the way it is. I still have to fight for what I want to do.
- 7.92** Do you, as a screenwriter, have influence on who plays what part?
- 7.93** Usually, no.
- 7.94** Okay, so the second part is, I think the first lecture you talked about Clint Eastwood and his eyes speaking pages of dialogue. How could you write that not knowing that it's going to be Clint Eastwood that's going to be doing that? Not everyone could have pulled that off.
- 7.95** Yes.
- 7.96** So how would you put that on a page?

- 7.97** Sometimes I write, and I picture actors in the roles. I write it for them. Sometimes I just write the characters. As the writer, do you have a say? Usually, no. You're selling your script. If you get to a point where you're producing, you're also on as a producer, you have some say. If you're directing, you have pretty much all to say as much as possible.
- 7.98** But then even directing, depending on how you're getting the funding, this gets it to the whole way of getting movies made. You have producers go, "Well, you want that actress, but that actress is worth more money when we sell the movie." "Yeah, but I need her to be blonde. There's a reason. And I wanted to do this and—" "No, we need to sell the movie. You've got to cast that person. Change it around." Things like that happen, too. It's monetary, and you have to sometimes do that to get the movie made.
- 7.99** Actors are almost like spark plugs. They'll just pull one out and put another one in, and they don't care. That's why they say actors fight or make a lot of money when they get to a point. Yeah, because actors don't get treated well at the beginning. They're just used, like chest pieces, spark plugs. Things like that happen, "Oh, take him out, put him in," for whatever reason. "Oh, he dated one of my ex-girlfriends. I don't want him in the movie." "She dated one of my friends. I didn't like her. I don't want her in the movie." "Yeah, but she's perfect for the part." "I don't care. I don't want her. Next. There's thousands of actors. Let's get them." That's how you hear these things. You think it's crazy, but sometimes that happens.
- 7.100** So, do you have a say? As the writer, usually not. You'd have to fight to be a producer, but you might not get that until you get one made that's successful, and then the next one, you say, "I'm a producer." If you have no aspirations to be a director, the best way to have some say is to get on as a producer as well.
- 7.101** About Clint Eastwood, a close-up of his eyes looking a certain way: yeah, you don't have to have any dialogue in those sections. You can still write that. Just write the character. "Close on his eyes. He looks to his right. We know he's going to kill that guy." You can write that. Then you have to get the right actor to execute it. In the case of Clint Eastwood, at that point, he had a lot of say in what he was doing.
- 7.102** I've had actors—there's a great actor. I work with a character actor named James Russo, who's on *Tulsa King* right now. Whenever I've done things with him, he's an opposite guy. I said, "Everyone wants more dialogue." He goes, "Do I have to talk that much? Just cut it out. I won't say anything. You know what? I'll look at the guy." He's one of those guys.
- 7.103** So if it works for the film, now it's working for the film. Like I said, the script is one thing because you have to get across the storyline, the characters, and the plot in your script in order to get it to be a film. But then once it becomes a film, and you're either rehearsing it and eventually shooting it, things change. The blueprint is there, but you change the blueprint because now the film itself is helping you tell that story.

- 7.104** I say my answer to that is write it in, what you see. I try to write what I see. As I said, scripts are what you see on the screen and what you hear. If you want to get into little flowery details, you can, but the audience isn't seeing that. Only the reader is hearing what you're saying. It's like I said, you can't put what's in a guy's mind unless you're doing a voiceover. Voiceovers are a device. Sometimes I've used them because I go, "This is a story that I feel needs to be narrated." Why? I don't know. But it just lends itself maybe to that particular story that I'm telling.
- 7.105** It's all about the script first, though. If you see it and you're watching the movie of your own script, get your movie on the page. Write what you see and worry about that later on. Because, like I said, the script is going to change multiple times, multiple times. Unless you are Tarantino, where it's his movies, you say what's on the page. David Mamet, you say what's on the page. You put the comma where the comma is. You put the period where the period is. If there's an exclamation point, it's like that. There are certain writers that have earned that.
- 7.106** I always feel that the writers are the people that are treated the worst. Meanwhile, they're coming up with the whole thing. I thought, "Shouldn't the writers be paid the most money? They come up with all these incredible stories." "You have to do this for—we don't have a lot of money for you." "But you got a lot of money for everyone else. I created it. Why am I not getting the money?" You get abused.
- 7.107** Writing is a tough one. Writing scripts, you want to write your novel, your novella, and you say, "I'm not changing a word," you can do that. But it's going to change, even if it's great, because then eventually you're going to get it into the hands of the actors. They start saying the words. "I don't feel comfortable saying that. I don't think I would say that." Sometimes they have a point, and sometimes you go, "Well, it's not you saying it. How about just say what's on there? You've got a character. Just say, 'he' would say it. I think the character would say it. It shouldn't be about what you would say." You have those arguments, those things come up, but that's why rehearsals are great.
- 7.108** As a writer, you have to be open to that also, because when you hear it, as I said before, when you hear it out loud, it's spoken. Now it exists. We talked about speaking. Creation was spoken into existence. Well, your script is now being spoken. It's existing in front of you. It's alive. It's come alive. But maybe the actor brings something you didn't think of. Maybe the director does, or a producer has a note about something. "If you cut out here, you don't need all this stuff. Get that out, because later on, we find it out down there." You sometimes don't realize that until you see it.
- 7.109** Also, because you could rewrite and rewrite and rewrite and rewrite forever. The rewrites never end. At some point, you've got to go, "I've got to stop. Do I have my story in there? Do I think it's good enough?" Get it out in the world because you're going to rewrite it again anyway, and you're going to see where and why it should be rewritten. If you're lucky enough to get talented people around you, it's a collaborative medium. Everyone's ego-driven with this stuff.

- 7.110** I have a big ego. Everyone has a big ego. But film is collaborative. The director of photography brings something that you didn't see. He sees something through his lens that you didn't think about. Actors bring something, producers. Like I said, I was on a film once, we took a break, and the PA said to me, "Mr. Vallelonga, did you notice that blah, blah, blah happened over there?" And I'm like, "Oh, no, I didn't notice that." And we looked at the—oh, I had to do it again. So everyone's opinion is valid.
- 7.111** Now, you can't have everyone telling you what to do because you can have 30 different opinions. But you can learn from everyone and be open to going, "Yeah, they may be right about that. Let me at least look into it." But by that time, you're filming it, you're in there. You've got to get the film made, too. That's a whole other conversation.
- 7.112** But the writing, right? If it's the best you can, get it into the best shape you can, and get it out into people's hands. Have readings. If you're not sure, read 10 pages, read 20. Find some actors that are in a local acting group and just say, "Can I come in with some pages and have you guys read them?" Everyone wants to do it. Nobody's going to say nobecause it's good for them, too. Oh, and fresh new material. No one's ever done this. So it's a win for everyone.
- 7.113** I was telling him, "Get an iPhone, film a scene. Just film it. You know what movies look like? Film it." There's so many ways to do it now that you couldn't do back then. There's plenty of opportunities to do it. There's no excuse not to do it, right? Okay. Yes.
- 7.114** Similar to Dr. Peterson or to you—I don't have Dr. Peterson's brain.
- 7.115** Nobody does.
- 7.116** Right. If you were mentoring a brand-new screenwriter who wanted to create—
- 7.117** Isn't that what we're doing right now?
- 7.118** —who wanted to create a timeline, what would you expect from them as far as getting it out onto the page, having something for other people to look at and read and give them feedback on? How quickly would that process go?
- 7.119** You're asking the wrong guy because I never meet timelines or deadlines. Well, look, there's reality. If you're getting paid something to write something, you should deliver it in a certain amount of time. That's usually agreed upon beforehand. I'd say 12 weeks minimum, you've got to give yourself to come up with a draft, I believe.
- 7.120** Like I said, but I've written things in one week, two weeks, and I've written things I was supposed to hand that thing in, and it wasn't done. And then it was six months later, and it was a year later. That has happened for various reasons. But I could do that because they go, "Oh, well, let him do his—" I have the excuse of, "Oh, I got an Academy Award. I've got to think it out." Sometimes I just don't have anything. I can't figure it out.

- 7.121** But if you're starting out and you're actually getting paid to write something or someone's hiring you, or you need to show your work. I think 12 weeks is a reasonable amount of time to get a first draft out of anything. It should be. And like I said, I should follow my own advice. It should be about 12 weeks. Now, rewriting, polishing, going over it, yeah, it'll go through that too. But I think 12 weeks is a fair amount of time.
- 7.122** Describe your techniques on developing a character before you start writing on the page.
- 7.123** Okay, like I said, I've done it in a lot of different ways. Sometimes I have a story I want to tell; sometimes I do have a character that I want to see—what is this character going to do? I mean, it all comes together because the story—there's got to be characters to tell the story. Why am I telling a certain story? Does something happen to a specific person, several people?
- 7.124** It's a tough question because I've also written scripts like we did the other day. I've written scripts where I just went, "Let me just try to come up with something and start writing them." That's rare. Usually, I have something in my head. But like I said, with me, I usually think it out for a long, long time before I go.
- 7.125** Now, maybe the smart thing to do, and maybe it tells you in those books, is when you're thinking it out, write it out. Write out what you're thinking out, and outline it, and say, "Who's my guy? Who's my leading lady? Who are they?" And make breakdowns, "What do I want to see happen to this guy? What's going to happen in the script?"
- 7.126** I have written a script that I don't even know how I'm going to end it. I told you, I've done that. I thought, "Oh, this would be a cool ending of the movie. How do I get characters to that ending?" I've done it that way. But mostly, I'm thinking about the whole story, why I want to tell this story, what is it about? And it all depends.
- 7.127** You get hired. She was talking about getting hired and doing something. "I need a low-budget horror movie, minimum locations, one or two locations, an old house in the woods, and maybe six characters because it's low budget. I don't want to pay any actors." Give me something. Okay, well, you have some guidelines. Now you have to work within those guidelines, right?
- 7.128** Someone says, "I got all the money in the world. I want to make a big movie. Give me a big action movie. I don't care if it takes place in outer space, if it's a Western, if it's a crime drama. We have \$20 million, and what do you got?" It all depends.
- 7.129** I would think in your cases, the first scripts—I don't know if they're first scripts, second scripts, attempts—write from your heart. I told you, write what you know. But maybe I'm wrong. Maybe he goes, "Yeah, I'm going to write—I don't know about mobsters, but I want to write them. I like mob movies, and I want to write one." Okay, so then do the research. Why do you want to write one? What's your storyline that's different

than most of them? Because most of them have the same stories. But you have different gangsters and telling different stories, or a lot of mob stories are based on real-life gangsters because real things happen.

- 7.130** So in your case, do as much research, as I said, watch as many of those movies as I'm sure you've already seen a lot of them, but there's a lot more you can probably research, and then write it. You're a movie fan, right? You like mob movies. Write the mob movie that you want to see, that you'd go to the movies to see, and just start it. But maybe map out the characters. Who's your main bad guy? Is it about the bad guys? Is it about the mobsters? Or is it about the FBI guy that catches the mobsters? What's it about?
- 7.131** Do you keep it within a small family? Is it modern day? Is it older in the 1930s when the mob was starting to get powerful? When does it take place? Who's our leads? Et cetera. It's like any story, you've got to start thinking it out, figuring it out. Probably the best thing to do is—no, definitely the best thing to do is write all these thoughts down. I do it—maybe because I'm lazy, I just think it out enough, where I can go, "Okay, I'm just going to start going," because I have it in my head. I have it in my DNA, so to speak.
- 7.132** I think one last one.
- 7.133** The title. Who picks the title? A lot of times, I see on projects that they'll have a working title, and then it'll end up being something else.
- 7.134** That's because they're saying to the writer, "We don't like your title."
- 7.135** Exactly.
- 7.136** Or if it gets made, there's marketing people that say, "We have to say something else." Title it whatever you want. Whatever you think is the title. Like I said, Green Book, which we're going to get into in the next hour, I titled it Love Letters to Dolores at one point. Because I thought, Oh, it's going to be a small indie movie. It gives it an indie feel. I was thinking of The Notebook, even though Love Letters to Dolores is longer—but The Notebook, what's The Notebook about? But when you watch the movie, you know why they named it The Notebook. When you watch Green Book, you find out why they named it Green Book.
- 7.137** Pick the title that you think is right for it. There's a chance—they tried to change the Green Book. They made the posters and the trailers with a different title on it. To Peter Farrelly, we all said we're not doing it, but Pete had a fight for that. He won. I'll get into that later.
- 7.138** But yeah, so pick the title that you feel expresses what it's about, or if you want it to be obscure, call it The Notebook, call it Green Book. What does that mean? But then you find out when you watch the film or read the script.
- 7.139** It's almost intriguing, Green Book. Like, what is it?

7.140 Exactly. Keep them guessing.

7.141 Exactly.

7.142 Thank you. Thank you.

Lecture 8: Green Book

At a glance — Green Book — lessons from his own film.

- 8.1 Okay, so I'm starting to get tired of the sound of my own voice, but we're going to do this one on the elephant in the room: Green Book. I know I've touched upon it. We've mentioned it here and there, told a couple of stories, but I think you, or maybe I just imagine this, and they want me to discuss the journey of getting a movie made. Now, obviously, Green Book would be the one I'm going to tell you about. Feel free to ask questions at any time during this, at any part. We'll break it up that way.
- 8.2 I'm not sure if I mentioned this. If you don't know, this is a true story. Green Book was a story that happened to my dad in the early '60s, 1962, '63. At the time, he was working at the Copacabana nightclub in New York City as a bouncer.
- 8.3 He had worked at a couple of other places as a bouncer, a place called the Peppermint Lounge that was famous, The Wagon Wheel that at the time was famous. Tough, tough nightclubs. He was a bouncer with Lenny Montana, who was the actor who played Luca Brasi in The Godfather. So you can imagine the two of them in real life together. To walk up to that nightclub, those were the doormen and bouncers.
- 8.4 So he was doing that, and then he got referred to the Copacabana. He started working there, and that's where he was working at the time of this story. He got a bit of a reputation. He was a very tough guy. All those nightclubs then were owned by mobsters. There was no way getting around it. It was all mobsters. Every nightclub was owned by a mobster. And the mobsters, everyone knew everybody. "Oh, get that bouncer, bring him here." And that's what happened to my father. He got the job at the Copa.
- 8.5 He started getting a reputation that you don't mess with him. But my father, really, he told me, "I don't want to get into fights. I don't want to deal with anyone." But he was a guy who knew how to deal with it. He was a street-smart guy that if something came up and someone had to get taken out, he could do it on that level—only taken out in a "take him out of the club" level.
- 8.6 So Don Shirley was a genius pianist, lived above Carnegie Hall in these lofts that they had up there. Marlon Brando was up there. Judy Garland was up there. They had ballet studios up there. This was like an artist's colony that they had, and he had an amazing — I wouldn't call it a penthouse, I guess a penthouse. But these were all on the roofs of Carnegie Hall. And a lot of people didn't even know people lived up there, but they did. And he had floor to ceiling windows like you see in the film.
- 8.7 I described it all. My first description to Brian Currie and Peter Farrelly, they thought it was nuts, but we found the photos showing his place, which helped in the production design of the film. But the way I described it originally, that's what it was. He had a

grand piano in the middle of his living room. He had a throne. He would wear these elegant, beautiful African robes all the time. He was an amazing man. He was well known in the high-society circles, in the political circles, all over the place in that era. He played everywhere in New York for the most elite people that you could play for.

- 8.8** So, you couldn't have had two completely opposite human beings. We lived in the Bronx, an apartment, if you see in the movie, my brother and I slept in the same room as my parents until we moved, until I was 10 years old. It was a one-bedroom apartment. That's where I grew up. So you have these two polar opposites, which sets itself up already.
- 8.9** The odd couple movie, right? There's so many movies based on the buddy movie, the buddy comedies, even buddy cop movies. They disagree. They don't like each other. They're stuck with each other. The captain of the police force throws them together.
- 8.10** In *Midnight Run*, the great George Gallo script and film, but directed by Martin Brest, a bounty hunter with his prisoner, doesn't care what the prisoner is saying, "I'm innocent. You shouldn't be taking me in. The mob guys want to kill me. I'm really the good guy." He doesn't care. He's a bounty hunter. Clashing, clashing, clashing, clashing, clashing. This is, again, something that you see over and over. But when it's done well, people go, "Give me another movie like that."
- 8.11** How do you find that? This story lent itself to that. It just automatically opened itself up to that type of thing. You had the two opposites that are going to clash. So the quick version is, again, I've said it: if you haven't seen the movie, stop, turn this off, watch the movie.
- 8.12** Don Shirley was going to go on another tour of the South. He knew he needed someone to protect him and drive him. As you see in the movie, he asked record companies and people in the industry for references. Don Shirley used to go to the Copa, too. I forgot this. If they ever mentioned that he saw my father in the Copa, I think he did see him, but he was asking people.
- 8.13** So people in the music industry, entertainment industry, all knew the Copa, and they knew sometimes the bouncers and the doormen. The Copacabana at that time, where it was, around the block was the Playboy Club. Down the block was a place called Jilly's. That was Frank Sinatra's club. There were a lot of big nightclubs, and everyone that was in those circles went there. So you had politicians, you had actors, actresses, musicians, top entertainers, all of it, models, the Playboy playmates. It was all going on in the Copacabana. So every time he asked around, Don Shirley, he got, well, "There's a guy, Tony Lip. If you're going to have somebody, you should have him."
- 8.14** So eventually he got a hold of my father, offered him this job. He told him, "I want a butler, I want a valet. You've got to take care of my clothing, shine my shoes. You've got to do this." My father, wrong guy. "You want to get from point A to point B, I'm the guy to get you there. You want no problems along the way. And you, dressed like that,

you're going to have problems. So I'm the guy that could help you, and I've got to get paid this much a week." Don Shirley agreed to it. He was intrigued by my father. He told me, he goes, "I was fascinated by your father, the way he spoke, the way he thought." And they went on this journey together.

8.15 So now that's the basis of the movie. I had that in my head my whole life. I lived it when it happened. I was old enough to understand my father's going away. My mother and father told me, "Dad's going to be gone for a while, but it'll be fine." I really didn't understand the length of time, but I knew he was going to be gone. But they explained it to me.

8.16 Then, when he would come home—the first time he came home with Dr. Shirley was Christmas Eve. That's all true. He walked in, and Dr. Shirley came in. Then I got to meet Dr. Shirley and go up to his apartment, his loft, I should say. He gave my brother and I ice skates. It was the next Christmas, I think—Christmas gifts. He gave my mother lots of gifts. He was an amazing, really special man. It did change my father's life after their trip together.

8.17 I'm jumping ahead, but as far as their trip goes, it was about a year and a half. It went through the Kennedy assassination, which we juggled. We had it written to go in the film. Peter Farrelly felt it was too much. This story is so unbelievable. He thought that part was a little bit too much to deal with the Kennedy assassination. It's been dealt with before. He wanted to keep it a smaller story about the two of them in the car. He made the right decision.

8.18 But a lot of criticism was taken about, well, there's not enough about Don Shirley, about his life and things he did. He was very, very active in the civil rights movement, and it was said about me, written in the press, "Oh, he didn't write—or all of us together didn't write—about that part of him." But again, and I may jump around when I tell this story, Don Shirley told me, "Don't write about any of that." He said, "I only want you to write about what happened to your father and I, and when it comes to that, don't mention that at all." I'm following what the man wanted to do.

8.19 But I had enough material. The story itself was so great. I didn't have to go into that, but I wanted to go into that to show him. For example, my father met Martin Luther King like three or four times. I mean, had dinner and lunch with Martin Luther King. You don't want the scene where Tony Lip from the Bronx is sitting with Dr. Martin Luther King talking about politics and civil rights? Of course, that would have been an amazing scene. The stories he told me and even that Dr. Shirley told me. But Dr. Shirley didn't want any of that in there. The movie shows he's fighting for civil rights, I should say.

8.20 So I followed that eventually when I put the script together and worked with Brian and Pete, and we discussed, okay, how many of these stories are in, how many are out? And even Pete said, "Do we need more Don Shirley?" The studio eventually said, when we got it to them, "We need more Don Shirley." But I couldn't put any more Don

Shirley in, so we had a fight about that. But the film works the way it is. So if you've seen the film, you know the storyline.

- 8.21** So my journey to get it done was, I always knew that story. So even when I was 12, when I was dreaming about making movies, I was thinking about making movies then. I always said, "I want to make a movie. I'm going to make a movie. I'm going to make a movie." When I was 15, 16, I said, "I think I want to start writing some ideas for this movie. I want to record Dad telling me the stories."
- 8.22** My mother came to me and said, "Well, if you're really going to do it, let me show you something." She had 96 letters that my father wrote to her. She had them all in a box, saved them all those years because he would write her once a week or something, or once every couple of weeks from everywhere he was, as you see in the film. We had all those letters that had postmarks that had shown where they were, what they were doing, my father explaining it, talking about his feelings about Dr. Shirley, how Dr. Shirley was treating him, what they did, what they faced. "We went to a place. He couldn't eat. I knocked the guy out." All these letters had lots of the storyline in them. I had that.
- 8.23** I interviewed my father. I interviewed Dr. Shirley. And that's when he was telling me what I could and could not use. He also told me at the time, "But I don't want you even to tell this story until I'm gone." He used the words "until I'm gone." And I think I know why that was.
- 8.24** There's a scene in the movie, I think, that explains that. I think he didn't want some information out there at that time. And so I respected that. So I always had that idea, but I was going to write it right. I wrote treatments, I wrote outlines, I wrote different ways to promote it, but I never got it made.
- 8.25** One time, a friend of mine, an actor named Tony Denison, loved this story. He told Brandon Tartikoff at Paramount, and I went to Paramount to meet with Brandon Tartikoff, who was the president at that time, and he wanted to do it with me there. I told him I couldn't do it. And he said, "Well, you could change it. You could still respect the guy, but maybe we just change the character. You're making a movie about your father." I couldn't do it. But I also felt it needs to be Dr. Shirley, not a made-up character. I want to promote him. People don't even know who he is anymore.
- 8.26** I also had another opportunity at a division of Paramount, Arsenio Hall at a production company, and his president of production, her name was Karen Tangur, a wonderful person, and she loved the story, and she wanted to do it. She heard about it again from Tony Denison. He couldn't stop telling that story.
- 8.27** Tony Denison was an actor who was on a show called Crime Story, the Michael Mann show. He's on The Closer and a lot of films and TV. He was working a lot then, and he was a guest on our Arsenio Hall show to promote some movie he was doing. And then he met the head of his production company. They wanted to do it, too. I just couldn't

do it. I just felt, "You know what? I don't want the guy to pass away. Whenever that happens at some point, then I'll try to do it." So I kept it inside.

8.28 Eventually, in 2013, my father passed away, and Don Shirley passed away a few months later just by sheer coincidence. And I said, "Okay, now it's time to start doing that." Brian Currie and I had worked together as bouncers in nightclubs for years, and we wrote one script together at one point, and then we were talking about doing something again. And I said, "Well, maybe it's so personal. I got this thing about my father, and I was going to write it myself, but maybe we could write it together because maybe I shouldn't write it myself," because I'm thinking maybe I should have another voice.

8.29 And he knew my father and my mother. He knew my family. And he goes, "What story about your father?" And I told him this story. He was flipping out. He was like, "You're nuts. We're working in nightclubs, and you have this story?" He goes, "This is a giant movie. I see it."

8.30 So I said, "Okay, let's talk about doing it." I said, "I've got to go into a storage space, find the box where I have all my notes and some treatments and all my materials and the tapes of the recordings." He's like, "Well, go do it." I was procrastinating.

8.31 And one day he came back to me. He said, "Listen, I had lunch with Peter Farrelly. I told him the story." I said, "Okay." "He wants to meet with you about it." I go, "About what?" He goes, "To direct it. He thinks it's great." I go, "Brian, I'm waiting my whole life to do this. I've got to direct this movie." He goes, "Just talk to Pete. You love Pete." I went and met with him. And when I met Peter Farrelly, it was immediate. There was a connection. He would talk to me about that—ever feel like there's a divine intervention or something?

8.32 It was like God telling me, this is the guy to do the movie. He not only got the story, he was so fascinated by it. And we had a deep four-hour lunch about it, talking about it. And it just hit me. I said, "You know what? Put your ego aside." I mean, it was the most important thing was to direct that movie. I knew that's the movie that I've been waiting for. But it just—something told me to do it with the understanding, and we all agreed, that now we're going to write it together.

8.33 Pete's movies made a billion and a half dollars or more. Brilliant writer. He told me a story: he never wanted to do comedy. He never intended to do comedy. He just fell into it. Now he's doing all these giant comedies because people ask me, "Why did I pick him to direct?" Or even say that, "Would you do it?" It was because I felt talent is talent. You're that smart. I thought he was a genius the moment I met him. I mean, you could tell people, there's certain people that just have it. So, we agreed to write it all together, produce it all together, and Pete would direct it.

8.34 That's how that journey started. So we went around. I think we pitched it. They pitched it a couple of times without me because I couldn't be there. I don't know, people didn't

get it. They wanted to change it. And we all knew we can't change the story. We're not changing anything. We all agreed on the heart of the story and what it needed to be. I played the tapes for Brian and Pete, showed them some of the little things I wrote, but the script was not written yet.

- 8.35** So they went on a couple of pitch meetings, and then I went on a pitch meeting. As you see, I get very emotional. There was a man named Jim Burke who ended up being one of the producers of the film, he was running a company, and I won't mention the company, but at that point, he was running it. We went in, a big board meeting with people. I started telling the story, and about 45 seconds in, I started getting choked up and crying, and he started crying. He just said, "Stop, don't say anything else. We'll do it. We'll make it. We want the movie. We'll do it."
- 8.36** So we got some development money there to make it. We started writing it together. Brian and I did a big pass. Pete was finishing a film, I think, at the time, but we all sat down what needed to be done. We agreed on all that. Brian and I did a pass where we were punching each other in the face half the time. No. It was good because there were a lot of arguments in terms of what do we put in? What do we say here?
- 8.37** But then there were a lot of beautiful moments of that. For example, there's a scene in that movie where it's a true story when they were driving along, and the car got engine trouble, and my father had to pull over, and while he was trying to fix it and put water in it, there were workers, all these African American workers in the field picking cotton, literally. And Don Shirley in the back seat of this car is looking at them, and they're looking at him. They looked like he was a Martian from outer space that landed. He's being driven in a car by the other guy. And it was a very special moment.
- 8.38** At that time, we were writing scenes together and writing scenes separately. On that day, we were trying to get some things done quicker because I had to meet with Pete soon. So I was writing something, and then we said, "Brian, you write that scene." And he wrote it beautifully. He didn't change one word of that. So there were moments like that that were happening. So we knew we had something very important going on, and the connections were good with the writing.
- 8.39** And then we met with Pete. And then we stayed up at Pete's home. He had a writer's cottage behind it, and it was day by day, every single day for several months, so we got it into shape. And he brought in his director's perspective. He really knew what he wanted director-wise. He shortened the timeline that they were together, made the ticking clock of getting home for Christmas a thing. He moved some scenes around.
- 8.40** Like I said, we had written in the Kennedy scene, Brian and I. We said, "Let's just write it in." When my father took Don Shirley, when he heard John Kennedy died, and got Robert Kennedy on the phone the day John Kennedy got shot. He got Robert Kennedy on the phone to give his condolences. That's how tight Don Shirley was with the Kennedy family. We did that whole journey of what happened with them. That was like

a stumbling block in the piece, and Pete felt it stops everything. It stops it. It's historically interesting, but we've got to keep it going.

- 8.41** I think that was a great choice. Not too many people know about it. I don't really ever tell that story. So that was a fantastic piece of editing right there. Great scene, written, fantastic. Sometimes you've got to do that to your own scripts. You go, "This scene is excellent. It's out." Sometimes you shoot the scene, you have a movie, and you go, "It's got to come out. It has to be out." It slows it down. It stops where it's placed in the film or in the script. But we were doing all that, and it all made sense.
- 8.42** I've got to say that the writing of it, I had two Irish guys and an Italian. They teamed up on me a little bit once in a while, but it really was a beautiful experience to get it done. We knew we had something when we were writing it. It was magical.
- 8.43** A lot of lines we wrote came right out of the mouth of Don Shirley and my father because I had taped them. In Don Shirley's case, sometimes just over the phone, I was writing things. So we were blessed. We were given gifts, given a lot of dialogue gifts. My father, talking on tape, "We've got to put that in. We've got to put that in." Don Shirley telling me certain things, "We've got to put it in."
- 8.44** But you have to combine scenes. You have to use some creative license. Like I tell everyone, we were knocked down a lot. "Oh, that didn't happen. That's BS. Don Shirley didn't say that. He wouldn't do this. He has several brothers, not one brother, like he says in the movie." Things like that, we were getting attacked for. We were conscious of all that when we wrote it. If Don Shirley had seven brothers, he told my father he had one brother. That's what's in the movie, what he said to him that day, for whatever reason he said it.
- 8.45** I talked about his psychology degree. So he said things because he wanted to say things to my father for a certain reason. Or maybe he didn't want my father to know much about his personal life and who his family was, really. So that's not my job. I can't interpret him and say, "Well, technically, he had more brothers, so I'm going to put that in." That's not what he said. And I thought it's more interesting that he didn't say the truth about that, that he said, "No, yeah, I don't really talk to my family." Now, he could have had family dinners every night, but that's not what he said. So I'm going by that. That's a whole other aside of what's truthful and what's not truthful.
- 8.46** But everything in there that you see happened. It might not have happened in the order that you see it. There were multiple times they were arrested. There were multiple times they were stopped. There were several times that he was told he couldn't eat. There was another scene in a bar that my father talked the bar to let him eat with him in the bar, food and drink, and then someone didn't like it. They called the cops and they were going to arrest them because he literally was breaking a law and they had to get out. Someone said, "You've got to get out of here." They made a mad chase out.

- 8.47** Not every story made it into the script because some were redundant. We've already proven the point, and maybe with a better way. So some things we combine, some things we move the timeline a little bit because, like I said, they had stories for over a year and a half worth of being together. So we use all that. But what you do see in that movie is true. It's all true and it's from the heart, and with all respect to Don Shirley, and to my father, and to my mother. I'm putting my parents on the screen.
- 8.48** That movie starts—if this was a fictional movie, my father's character, you don't like him. I mean, he's a lovable guy, but you don't like him. He starts with that scene: we had cleaners over the house, and he threw the glasses in the garbage, and my mother pulled them out. Now, it really happened. My mother was yelling at my father. He said, "I know. Okay." But that happened.
- 8.49** But my father said to me, "You have to put that in because you have to show how I changed." This whole story is about how he changed. Now, Dr. Shirley changed also. He told me, "I learned things from your father's street-type things that made sense." He made brilliant sense to me from a street level. It was like street logic, street genius.
- 8.50** Chazz Palminteri calls it street logic because there were a lot of guys that maybe couldn't articulate things on an intellectual level like someone that went to a college, but they could read people, they could understand people. Human behavior is at every level. So my father had that. My father actually was a very nice human being. Like I said, we never were brought up. I didn't even know any racist comments or ideas. That was never in our home in any way.
- 8.51** But we start him out in a certain way. So how are we going to follow this guy? Why do we want to follow him? It's almost like you might turn that off. But you need to keep watching because the whole point is about all of us have past lives. All of us have sins. All of us have things that maybe we regret, and all of us can change.
- 8.52** We talked about knowledge. Sometimes knowledge hurts when you realize something, when you have the knowledge of what was going on, you think, how could I have been so dumb to have that happen? Oh, that person was betraying me the whole time. That hurts. But also knowledge gives you growth. Knowledge gives you knowledge about yourself. Oh, how could I have done those things? What was I thinking? How could I have treated people that way? How could I even think that way? So you change and you grow. So that's the point of, I think, the movie.
- 8.53** It's so easy to say it, but it is. It's simple. Two complete opposite people from different worlds that probably disagree on everything. Stuck together, they learn about each other, they grow, they change. Are we changing the world with this movie? Am I fixing racism forever with this movie? Of course not. It's a small movie. When you boil it down, it's a slice-of-life movie. It's just about these two people. But on an intellectual level, these two people represent all people.

- 8.54** So you get a message, you hopefully have fun along the way. Peter Farrelly— there were so many scenes. The crew trying not to laugh, then as soon as they say "cut," exploding laughter. Everyone going [mimes trying not to laugh] like this. He didn't want to do it like comedy because this is not supposed to be funny. But he realized, too, it lent itself to be funny. My father's character is funny, no matter how you look at it.
- 8.55** The fried chicken scene is crazily funny. Now, people are offended. Fried chicken, it's there purposely. You see it's purposely put there for a reason. There's a scene where my father's talking about—"Why? Why don't you like this?" He goes, "I like your people's food." He said, "I like the coloured greens and all that." Now, there was an actual critic that wrote about the movie that didn't like it. He said, "Nick Vallelonga and the writer, they're so stupid. They don't even know what collard greens are. They wrote it as coloured greens." No, yeah, of course we know what collard greens are. My father didn't know; my father was saying it as coloured greens. I couldn't even believe it when I was reading that. Yeah, we're that dumb. We don't know what collard greens are. It's crazy how people perceive things.
- 8.56** But those types of things coming out of his mouth, because when he says that, you see Shirley's face like, "What? What is he saying? What?" My father's trying to make a point of what's the difference? "I don't care if you say, let's go get pizza and spaghetti and meatballs. I'm not offended by it. Fried chicken? Yeah, I love it. Don't you love fried chicken? It's awesome." Now, he said he never had fried chicken in his life. And there was another thing that said, "Oh, Don Shirley, of course, he had fried chicken." But again, he said to my father, "I never had that in my life. Don't you dare give me that. I'm not eating that." It doesn't mean that it was true, but he did say it, maybe to push my father.
- 8.57** "First of all, Tony, we shouldn't be eating food like animals in a car." There was nothing my father loved more than eating in a car. Me and my brother ate in cars our whole lives. We were always eating in a car. There was no time my father was not eating. Whenever we went, anytime we went anywhere, my mother would have to pack sacks of food, and he wanted to eat in the car. And when we didn't do that, my father would stop. It's burgers, hot dogs. Oh, we've got to go. We've got to take a half-hour ride. We're eating while we're going there. That's the way he was. Don Shirley never even comprehended anything like this. But those types of scenes lent themselves to comedy.
- 8.58** And the one scene that Pete drew the line at was when we would go to pizzerias, my father would get pizza for everyone, like a whole pie, if he needed one or two pies, depending on the people. Then he'd get a pie by himself, and he would tell him, "Don't cut it." He did it all the time. As people are talking, eating, you let it cool down a little, then he would just fold the whole pizza and eat it. Now people say, "Oh, they made that up." No, he did that all the time.
- 8.59** So I put that in that scene. And Pete said, "We can't put it in because it's too funny or it could be funny. It's too jokey. It's not true." So we did the scene. There's a scene when

the bass player played by Mike Hatton—see, Mike? I mentioned your name. Mike Hatton, great actor, writer, director. He played the bass player, and he comes to get my father to say, "Dr. Shirley's in trouble." That scene, we did it several times. I had kept pushing for the pizza. Viggo was like, "We've got to put the pizza in." "Viggo, okay, I'm going to give you one take. One take with the pizza. That's it. Because it's just too much. We're doing a drama. I wanted to do a drama."

- 8.60** But he knew the comedy was in there. But this was more organic comedy than the comedy he's known for. When Viggo did it, the crew didn't know, nobody knew. When he did that, when we said "cut," the crew was dying, dying laughing. They were, "Oh, my God, that's so funny." So Pete was, "Okay, I guess that's the one that's going in," and that's the one that's in the movie. So I got it to the point where we got it made. I'll talk to you about the casting of it.
- 8.61** There were a lot of guys to play my father. I always felt it had to be an Italian. You have to have the olive oil in your veins a little bit to play a real Italian. Otherwise, you're doing a bad Saturday Night Live. That type of a thing. We don't want that.
- 8.62** But Pete called me one night late and he said, "I just saw this movie, Captain Fantastic." I'm like, "Oh, yeah, it's a really great movie." "It was Viggo." "I know." So that's when it had come out. We were in the middle of this casting. We were casting at the time that that had come out. He goes, "What do you think? What do you think?" I go, "About what?" He goes, "About Viggo." I go, "Viggo Mortensen is one of my favorite actors of all time. I love Viggo Mortensen."
- 8.63** Viggo Mortensen played a Puerto Rican gangster in Carlito's Way. If you watched it now, you would never even know it's Viggo Mortensen. He was so good. I remember when I first saw him do it, I thought, "Wow, who's this Puerto Rican guy they got? He's one of the best actors I've ever seen." But it was Viggo Mortensen. Viggo Mortensen played an Amish guy in the Harrison Ford movie, Witness. Viggo Mortensen played the Devil in a movie with Christopher Walken. Viggo Mortensen to me was one of my favorite actors.
- 8.64** So I go, "What about him?" "He's got to play your father." I went, "To play my father? You just watched him play a hippie who's off the grid, raising his kids. He's this thin, with long hair and a beard—you thought of my father?" He goes, "I don't know. It's something I just—I don't know." He goes, "Think about it."
- 8.65** So now, of course, he called me like at 2:00 a.m. Now I can't sleep. I'm thinking about it. I'm looking at pictures of Viggo Mortensen. And then it hit me. I'm like, "Well, what's the most iconic character in film history that's Italian?" I would arguably say The Godfather. Godfather, biggest, most well known, played by Marlon Brando. Not Italian, right? And it just clicked. I called Pete back and said, "Yeah, I'm in. Let's try to get Viggo."

- 8.66** Viggo, when he was presented with it, he thought the same thing. "What? They want me to play what?" This script is great. He loved the script. He thought it was amazing. He goes, "I can't do this. Get an Italian guy to do it. You've got to get an Italian guy to do it." But we kept fighting for it, fighting for it, fighting for it. And then he said, "Well, was the son—Pete, I appreciate it, but the son, this Nick Vallelonga guy, he's okay with this?" He goes, "Yeah, Viggo, he loves you. He wants you to do it." He goes, "Well, I'm not doing it unless I talk to the son. I've got to talk to the son."
- 8.67** So we set up a meeting for him to come to New Jersey. My brother had a restaurant called Tony Lip's in Franklin Lakes, New Jersey, and he was going to come for lunch, Viggo. He stayed eight hours. My brother kept bringing food, bringing food. I had my uncles there, cousins. He was hanging out. He started out as Viggo Mortensen. By the end of the day, he was going, "Hey—" I'm exaggerating, but he got it.
- 8.68** He saw the family and he said, "Okay, let me think about it, Pete." My brother and I told him, "You could do this. We'd love you. My father would be honored to have you do it and bring to it what you bring to it, your talent." He said he thought about it, thought about it. Then he told me privately, he said, "I had one more weekend before I had to give the answer." He goes, "I really thought I'm not doing it. I can't do it. But I read it three times, I couldn't stop reading. I loved it, loved it, loved it."
- 8.69** So he said he was walking in his garden pacing. His wife was out in the garden. She was doing something like pruning roses or something like that. She goes, "What's with you?" He goes, "This movie, I can't do it." He goes, "They want me to do it. I can't do it." He said his wife didn't even look at him. She went, "You know you're going to do it." And he went, "Yeah, I guess I have to do it." And then he did it.
- 8.70** And then once we had Viggo, I'd seen Mahershala Ali in an episode of a television show, and I just thought he was amazing. He was always in my head, and I kept saying his name.
- 8.71** You get into that thing, what are actors worth? At that point, he was starting to get a little known, but he was just a character actor. And so no one wanted to hear it in a sense. There were other names or big African-American actors that they were talking about getting. And then he wins the Academy Award for Moonlight. So I'm like, "See, Mahershala Ali, see?" They go, "Oh, no, we can't get him now. Now he won the Academy Award. He's too expensive. We're not going to be able to pay him for that."
- 8.72** But ultimately, Pete said, "No, no, let's try to get Mahershala Ali." And we brought it up to Viggo, and Viggo said, "Oh, I met Mahershala during that run when he won. And we talked. We had a connection. We thought, 'We're going to work together one day.'" So Mahershala read it. He came in, and the rest is history. You got those two guys. Now we're going around shopping it with those guys.
- 8.73** The original producer I told you that took the film, ended up leaving that company. I remember, they called us up there, Brian and I. This is where it gets crazy. They said, he

can come to this meeting for some reason. So Brian and I went to—now, Jim Burke had left that company. And they said to us, "He's not here anymore. We hate this thing. It's not good. We think it's terrible. We don't want to make it, and probably no one wants to make it." So we said, "Okay, unless you really change it and do extra, we're not doing that." So where do we stand now?

- 8.74** So now what happens is if a company doesn't want to make it, you can put it in what's called turnaround, where if we can get it set up somewhere else, they'll let us buy it back, whatever they paid us to write it, plus a little—they're like mob guys, a vig on top of what they paid. They make a little more money, and they let it go, and they happily let us go. Where those people are now working, I don't know, but they let it go.
- 8.75** And then Jim Burke joined us as a producer, and Pete brought on another producer that had worked with him, Charlie Wessler. And we went around and we found a home for it. He was bringing it around, and somehow it got into the hands of Spielberg, who thought it was amazing. And there was another company under his company, Amblin, Participant Media, who was funding films. They made *The Help*, I think, like that. So we got it set up there. And once Spielberg said, "I want to distribute this movie," it went from a little indie film to now, okay.
- 8.76** But they still wanted to keep the budget very low because you still get into that crazy thing of, "Oh, how much is Viggo Mortensen, Mahershala Ali, worth for a film?" But that went out the window because foreign sales and all that nonsense that they do, I think they all recognize, "We want to make a good movie," but it was still considered a low-budget movie at the time. And then we went off and we made the movie.
- 8.77** Now, there were a lot of other obstacles along the way. The making of the movie was fantastic. Like I said, Pete did an amazing job. Great cinematography. Everyone on the movie knew we had something. Like I said, the crew was very in tune with this movie.
- 8.78** At first, when you work with crews, sometimes it's just a job for them. They all care about what they're doing, but it's another job. But sometimes you see something special. And once we started seeing scenes with Mahershala and Viggo, they realized, "Oh, this is not just another movie. There's something going on here." And there were moments of Mahershala's acting and Viggo's acting when we all knew, "Oh, and the Academy Award goes to"—moments. You dream about it, you think it. But either way, I never thought that far. But I did know, "Oh, this is special."
- 8.79** Because of Pete directing and those two actors, I knew the great Linda Cardellini came in to play my mom. Amazing. She looked just like my mom. I'll do an aside story on that, too. She looked just like my mom when my mother was that age—it was blowing my mind. My mother had that same vibe and look to her. So I went to have my first meeting. She was dealing with Pete. He's the director. But she still wanted to talk to me about my mother, get as much information as she could get.

- 8.80** And we were talking and she said, "There's certain questions I want to know, just so I have it in my head." She's asked me different things. And then she said, "What's her birthday?" And I said, "Oh, my mother's birthday was June 25, 1932." She was like, "Oh, come on, what's her birthday? I go, "June 25?" She goes, "That's my birthday." So that happened, and she was fantastic.
- 8.81** I had all my relatives talking to her about my mom, and so she just embodied my mother. I had my relatives there. My brother played my uncle, Rudy, my father's brother. My brother played him. The real Uncle Rudy played his own father, the one Italian grandfather. And my mother's brother, Uncle Lou, my uncle Louie, played his own father. So the two grandfathers were played by real family members. My brother was my brother. And it made those scenes, the family scenes, like an intangible thing that you can't put your finger on. Why are these scenes so good?
- 8.82** Spielberg said to my brother, "Frank, those scenes, they're unbelievable. Where did you find the old guys to play the grandfather?" He goes, "Those are my uncles." And then he realized Frank was my brother. He couldn't believe it. But he said that brought so much to it because there was a richness to those family scenes because you're in scenes that people were actually there when those things happened.
- 8.83** A lot of the other characters that were in the movie, for example, Johnny Roastbeef Williams, who played the guy eating the hot dog contest, you may remember, he has a great scene in Goodfellas. He was in Goodfellas and a lot of those types of movies. He knew my father very well. So why does that scene work so well? Because he really did eat hot dogs with my father all the time. And there he is eating hot dogs with my father.
- 8.84** There were several other guys, the bouncer and all the nightclub scenes at the Copa were all my friends that I was a bouncer with, but they all knew my father. So a lot of people in the movie knew my father. So when Viggo is doing scenes with them, they did scenes in real life with my father. So it changed the vibe.
- 8.85** My scene was weird. I played the mob guy. And that came up because it was always known Brian was going to be in—he's an actor. He was going to do a scene or something, play a role. He played the state trooper at the end that shows up in the snow and helps them out. A nice guy.
- 8.86** I'm thinking, I'm going to play one of the family members. I'm going to play part of my own family. I'll play one of the cousins or brothers or uncles or something. So it came down to it. Pete said, "Okay, what are we going to do with you? What do we do?" I said, "Well, Pete, whatever you want me to do. You're the director. Just tell me what you want to do." He goes, "Well, you're going to play the mob guy in the diner." I said, "Well, okay, but I can get you some really good guys to do that. Shouldn't I just be in my own family? Shouldn't I be the family?" He goes, "No." He goes, "We have to like the

family." He goes, "We should love them." He goes, "You play the evil mobster." So that's why I played that part.

- 8.87** So that was a weird scene for me because I'm talking to the character that is my father, played by Viggo. That was a little mind-bending. But a lot of it was mind-bending on the set because when we were recreating all those family scenes of where I lived and all that stuff, it was just very emotional and very surreal, I should say. So we got the movie done.
- 8.88** I think I might have mentioned this. There were people that were saying, "You've got to cut it. It's too long. Cut this out, cut that out." There was even, "Let's reshoot the ending." "You've got to cut Christmas out. It's offensive." Now, when we all heard that, we were like, "What? Offensive to who?" "Well, to a lot of people. Not everyone believes in Christmas." I said, "Well, so what? Some people don't believe we went to the moon. Some people believe we went to the moon, but Christmas is celebrated every year. It's a holiday. People can relate, no matter what you believe or don't believe, people celebrate holidays. He's getting home for a holiday, no matter what his holiday, it was Christmas. Why is—" "No, we've got to get it out." But we won that battle. We fought that.
- 8.89** "Cut out most of the family scenes. We don't need them. No one wants to see them." Again, Pete had a fight, fight, fight. Ultimately, it came down to, I've got to say, they wanted changes in the script like the first company did. Then they wanted some changes also in the script. We never changed it. Why? Steven Spielberg said, "Don't change it." He said, "Pete, go make your movie." Pete made the movie, showed his cut. They wanted to cut out almost 40 minutes of it.
- 8.90** He sent it to Steven Spielberg, and Steven Spielberg just said, "You're not cutting a frame out of this movie. The only problem with this movie, it's not long enough." And that was that. What are they going to say to Steven Spielberg? He doesn't know what he's talking about? So he saved us. I've got to say that he really was behind this film. He championed the film. Thank God he was around because I don't think it would have come out the same way.
- 8.91** But Pete was very—see, Pete's a super nice guy, but I told you he's a genius in intelligence. He knows how to work the studio system. I want to flip the table over and tell them, "Screw you." But Pete was able to manipulate all that in a nice way because he knew what he wanted. It was a big movie for him, and he directed the heck out of it. But Spielberg was behind it and supported him.
- 8.92** One of the biggest tragedies, I think, is—then we started winning a lot of awards in Golden Globes, and that was a year that they were—it was mudslinging, like you cannot believe, of attacking movies. They attacked me, they attacked Viggo, they attacked Pete, bringing up things in the past that we may or may not have said. Stuff with me, they just made things up. I'm reading actual lies and I'm like, "How are they

allowed to print this stuff if it's not true?" But they did because they wanted to knock the movie down because we came out of nowhere.

- 8.93** That year had fantastic, great, great movies. I mean, I can't believe the list of movies, and you can look this up. There was *The Favourite* that year about the Queen. There was *BlackKkKlansman*, *Black Panther*, *Vice*, *Rac*, *Bohemian Rhapsody*, *Roma*. I mean, the list goes on and on.
- 8.94** There were so many fantastic movies and fantastic writers that were up for the writing. Paul Schrader. I'm like, Paul Schrader? I'm like at an event with Paul Schrader, and I go, they're even talking about me being a writer? They should name it the Paul Schrader Best Screenplay Award for the Academy Awards. So all of that was fantastic, but we were being attacked almost mercilessly.
- 8.95** But the one thing I thought that was just beyond comprehension was Peter Farrelly was not—he was nominated for the Directors Guild Award. He was in the top five. He was not nominated for an Academy Award for Best Director, which I thought was absurd. We're nominated for Best Picture. Did the picture direct itself? How could you nominate a movie and not nominate the director? So that was a big controversy that year.
- 8.96** And actually, it happened to Bradley Cooper also. *A Star Is Born*, another movie that year. *A Star Is Born*. Awesome movie. He was a fantastic actor in it. The whole thing, amazing. Directed impeccably, not nominated. So Peter Farrelly, and Bradley Cooper, not nominated in that year, *A Star Is Born*, *Green Book*. I'll never understand that. But he deserves a lot of credit.
- 8.97** He made the movie and people say, "Oh, you wanted to direct it." I go, "You know what? It won Best Picture." I couldn't have directed better than him, I don't believe. I could have directed my version of that movie, and a lot of it might have been the same if you're directing the script. But he brought what he brought to it, and there was never any moment of me being there going, "Oh, that's not, oh no—" No, it was really—I was beyond happy and delirious of the decision that I made, and he deserves all the credit he could get. Brian Currie brought it to him. We all wrote it together.
- 8.98** It was a blessed project, I think, from the beginning. We never should have won those. There was so much against us. The odds, there were so many. Everyone was telling us, "Don't read the papers, don't see videos." It was madness on the internet about who was going to win and how we shouldn't win and all this stuff.
- 8.99** When we were there at the Academy Awards, I went with my brother, and my nephew came, too. But my brother and I sat together, and he's going, "You guys should win this." I'm like, "It's because it's about us, and dad, you want us to win?" I said, "We're not winning this." I said, "Look at all these movies. Look at all these people." I go, "We won. We made a movie about mom and dad. I got the story out. I've been trying to do

this for 45 years." I go, "I did it. So look at where we are. We're at the Academy Awards. We won."

- 8.100** So Spike Lee was very unhappy about us because I think it was *Do the Right Thing* was up against *Driving Miss Daisy*, and *Driving Miss Daisy* won. So he's like, "I got another movie about two guys in a car driving around, written by a white guy." He was a little upset about that, which maybe he had a good point, possibly. So it was very controversial, but when our name was called for the screenplay, I didn't expect that. I said to myself, "Oh, that's God. God did this because the odds were so against us." And then we won Best Picture.
- 8.101** I think I mentioned this in the first one. I said, "There I am going up for the Best Picture because I produced it as well." I got Julia Roberts giving me the award, hugging me and kissing me. I went, "Is this fake? What's going on here?" So we were blessed. I have that for whatever that means. But as we know, as the story, all the gold and the prestige in the world doesn't really mean anything. It's about who you are and what you do.
- 8.102** It has not really been easy for me. I've not made another film since then, at least at this taping. Hopefully, maybe when it comes out, I'll be in the middle of making a film. I'm close to getting one done. But it was quite a journey unto itself. A movie could be made about the making of this movie.
- 8.103** I did see Spike Lee backstage because when you win, they have press conferences backstage before they take you to take—these awards are the actual ones that were given to me on the stage. So they hand it to you, but it's blank. It doesn't have all the writing on it. And then there's ceremony behind the scenes while they're throwing the parties, the Governors Ball. You go in and you hand them that, and they make the plate for it right there and then. They do it. There's a whole security thing about it. You can't sell it. You can't give it away. You can't pawn it. You can't do anything. There's a lot of rules. But why was—
- 8.104** So when I was backstage doing that, Spike Lee did win Best Adapted Screenplay for *BlackKkKlansman*. So he had his Academy Award; he was sitting with his wife. And I had these two weights almost in my hands. And I saw him, and I had never spoken to him before. I just went right for him, and I saw his wife going, "Oh, the guy's coming over." And I just said to him, "Hey, Mr. Lee, I think you're awesome. You should have 10 of those already. Congratulations. It was a great honor to be in the same category as you." And he was like, "Oh, hi." And he introduced me to his wife. He thought like, "Oh, maybe I was going to come over and try to hit him on the head with the thing." Why would I do that? I think he's a tremendous filmmaker.
- 8.105** And then afterwards, he had been saying all this stuff, but he did his interview, afterwards. I saw one of them. He goes, "Let's talk to the writer. We're all cool. Everything is cool." So that was nice to see.

- 8.106** So it was quite the journey. I'm still on the journey. It doesn't end. We want to keep following this world and this profession. What do you've got to do? You have to write another one. You've got to start all over again. You've got to write one. You've got to get one out in the world again. It's the same process. It doesn't end.
- 8.107** So I hope that some of the things I've said over these last— I can't believe—eight hours that you glean something from it. Like I said, don't just listen to me. Go out to your own research, listen to other people, read some of those books that I showed you. But the bottom line, I would say, don't give up. Pursue your dream. That doesn't mean it's going to end up—you might not get the reward now, but you may get a reward just by getting something accomplished and finished, and maybe that's your journey. You may get it made. Whatever the level that you're taking it to, keep fighting for it.
- 8.108** But again, fighting and dreaming goes nowhere without hard work. It's really hard work. It's hard work to write a script, to write anything. It's hard. But you've got to put the pen to paper or you've got to start clicking the keys, and you have to keep pushing forward every single day.
- 8.109** So thank you for listening to me. We're going to take some more questions, but I just wanted to put that out there. I appreciate all the time that you've spent here listening to me. I hope your writing goes well and you get all these scripts finished. And maybe you'll be up here one day talking about it. Thanks. Any questions?
- 8.110** Have you ever considered writing a documentary about your dad? Why did you decide to do a narrative versus a documentary?
- 8.111** I started a bit of a documentary about my dad. I filmed my dad about five—well, he died in 2013, so it was around 2011 or '12. I did a lot of taping of my father telling stories. One day I might do that. I can make 10 movies about my father. He really had a crazy life. This was just one little bit of his life.
- 8.112** He became an actor. He ran restaurants. I mean, he was in *The Godfather*, and he was in *Raging Bull*, and he was in *Goodfellas*. And if you're a fan of *The Sopranos*, my father, Tony Lip, played Carmine Lupertazzi, the New York mob boss on *The Sopranos* for three seasons. And then I ended up doing *The Sopranos* prequel movie. I ended up being in that because my father was in that one. They asked me to do that in honor of him.
- 8.113** But my father, crazy amazing life, full, full, rich life. I do have a lot of footage on him. I started playing with it at one point. But again, all these things, you've got to finish them. You've got to finish them. It's something that's in the back of my head that I still might want to do.
- 8.114** Clearly today, people are consuming a lot. Social media, TV, podcast, or there's an overconsumption of media. It doesn't seem like there's a lot of creation. So do you think that the screenwriting profession today is "easier" to get into versus 50, 100 years ago in terms of competition, or do you think it's harder?

- 8.115** It's always hard. I think it's always been hard. It always will be hard. The one good thing about—I mean, there's a lot of reality stuff because people are just filming themselves doing things, and they make—It all started with reality programming. But there's always need for drama. People want to—they like human emotion. You want to listen to people.
- 8.116** So movies have gone down in a sense, but movies have gone down other times. When videotape first came out, "Oh, you can watch movies at home on video." They thought that was the end of movie theaters, the end. Videotape. Well, for a while, there was a little lull. But what are you going to do on a Saturday night? What are you going to do when you're a 15-year-old teenager and you get your first girlfriend? You're going to go to the movies. People want to go to the movies. You've got to get out of the house. It doesn't matter. We have giant, beautiful screens now. It's great to stay home and watch a movie at home. But it's not like going out to a movie.
- 8.117** Some movies you have to see on a big screen. Like *The Odyssey* that's coming out. How are you going to watch that on a television? You've got to go see it in IMAX, right? So I think that's going to come back. There's always the ups and downs. So there's always room for scripts.
- 8.118** The good news is there's so much, like I just said, information and media out there, but there's a lot of streaming. They need content. A lot of people make movies knowing it's just going to stream on one of the platforms. But you get it made. You get it seen. Sometimes there's some movies that get seen on streaming that would never reach that audience if it was out in a movie theater. It used to be even small movies came out in theater. Some people saw them, some stayed small.
- 8.119** *Green Book* was one that made a ridiculous amount of money in the box office. It was seen by lots of people besides also winning awards. So don't even worry about that. It's either going to happen and you're going to sell it and get it made or you're—It's the same thing. I won that. I've gotten writing jobs. Some of them are supposed to be made. They haven't been made yet. You can't think about that. You've just got to pursue it and put your product out there and see where it lands.
- 8.120** Do you write with a budget in mind, or do you just write and then hope that you get funding?
- 8.121** Usually, but sometimes there's a budget in mind. If you're writing on your own, don't even think about a budget. Just write your movie. I think we talked about this earlier. If you go, "I want to make a low-budget horror." Then you write, keeping in mind, "Let me do one or two locations. It's about these 10 people that go on a camping trip in the woods and the guy with the hatchet is chasing after them." Well, already you know it's only one location, basically. Maybe you open them up, they're getting in their cars, but basically it's one location. It's a certain amount of actors who keep getting eliminated

along the way, you get rid of them. So you say it's a low-budget horror movie, you're devising it to be that.

- 8.122** There are times you're hired and they say, "We have 2 million bucks. We need a cop movie, but it's got to be 2 million bucks." So you can't have cars exploding and giant sequences. So you have to keep all those elements in mind.
- 8.123** But don't restrict yourself when you're just writing something unless you already know, "I want to direct this." So keep the budget down in your mind to begin with because they're more likely to let you direct. They like writer-directors, even if they're first time. It's not easy, but it's easier if you've got a great script and the budget's not high, and if you have anything to show them—that's why I say, make your iPhone movies do anything to show them. Make a scene, record a 10-minute scene, but keep the budget down, and you're thinking about that in advance when you write it. But if you're writing, you want to write an epic movie, then write an epic. Write it as big as you want. Don't restrict yourself. There's both ways to do it.
- 8.124** You talked about that journey of producing or getting *Green Book* onto the big screen, and I'm sure that's a similar story to a lot of screenplays, whether they're yours or others.
- 8.125** Sure.
- 8.126** There's sticking to your principles and there's picking battles. What have you learned from that journey that you could give in terms of advice? Look, you can't win every battle. But you've got people giving you notes: "We'll green-light your film if you take our notes." But you're going to stick to your principles.
- 8.127** Yes, it depends. George Gallo and I just wrote a film about Carlo Gambino that hopefully by the time this is going, that will be made. It may not be made, but right now we have John Woo, the legendary John Woo, who's going to direct this movie. John Woo loves the script, loved the script, but we've had a dozen or more meetings with John Woo where he made changes. He made the script better. Better, because he's the director, he's a genius, and he's John Woo. What he wanted to do with the scenes or add a scene or take out a scene or change within the scene made it better. It's all perspective.
- 8.128** You can get a good idea, like I said, from anybody. But when you're in the position of getting your movie made, like when you have Pete, myself and Brian knowing what this film is and needs, and Pete says, "This is the script I want to direct." Then you fight. Then you fight, then you fight, then you fight.
- 8.129** If you hear something that goes, "Could you just do this little adjustment?" and it makes some sense, you can give in to that. It all depends on the situation. We had a director who knew what he wanted. He was one of the writers. He had the script he

wanted to do. But luckily, we had other bigger people saying, "No, do it." So it all depends on who's giving you the notes and who's it coming from.

- 8.130** A couple of times people say, "Can I read your script? I just want to make—" "Okay." "I got some notes for you." "Did I ask you for any notes? No." "Okay. I don't know."
- 8.131** The problem is with me, I do my own notes, I'd like to think. There's a script, someone hired me to do a script, and then they told me they're sending it off to some script [service] that they do coverage and they give notes. So I go, "Oh, no. How much are you paying for that?" "Oh, \$5,000." I say, "Oh, before you do that, I got someone that can give you really good notes, this guy. He won two Academy Awards, two-time Academy Award winner. He'll do it for \$5,000. I can get him to do it. He gets a lot more to do that." That's who we should get because who's giving the notes? "Oh, this is some company in New Jersey, some 20-year-old college kid." God bless him.
- 8.132** But I did my own notes. I'm giving myself notes. Now, that doesn't mean I have to have my ego, my head so big that I don't listen or hear things. I send my script to Chazz Palminteri. I send it to George Gallo. I want their notes because I know they have the same sensibilities that I have, and they'll be honest with me. I want them to be honest and brutal.
- 8.133** In the case of Green Book, and I'll finish with this, I sent it to Chazz and to George Gallo, and they both said no notes. And Chazz told me that only happened to him two times in his life, and Green Book was one of them.
- 8.134** So be open, be honest with yourself. I think I learned enough that, like I said, with Green Book, ego aside, I didn't direct it. I found the right director. You can listen to people, but stick to your guns, especially at first. Fight for what you want, but be open to possibly bending and changing it.
- 8.135** I think we're good. Thank you so much for being here. I appreciate you all. Thank you.